Showdown in Chinatown

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Fresh Police Story

SC-01

It is said that during the Shāng and Zhōu Dynasties, our land was plagued by malevolent creatures. They roamed the land, bringing havoc and leaving the nation and its people in endless suffering.

On the emperor's order, Fāngxiàngshì the Wise sought the assistance of the twelve gods of Shètí. Bestowed with their divine might, Fāngxiàngshì bound the creatures and turned their monstrous power to the service of the people. These creatures became known as the Xiǎndào Beasts, guardians of the perilous path.

Now reformed, the beasts were used to drive away evil and protect the land, and thus earned the reverence of the people.

However, by the end of the Táng Dynasty, there arose many wars and troubles.

To preserve the legacy of the Xiǎndào Beasts, the last Fāngxiàngshì entrusted them to the Twelve Zhènzǐ, servants of the ritual, before passing away.

Among the Xiǎndào Beasts, Qiángliáng, whose body was like a tiger with a serpent's tail, was considered unmatched in ferocity.

The Zhènzǐ who was entrusted with Qiángliáng took Liáng as their surname, passing this knowledge down through their descendants.

Liang's Father: *Until today, while the world no longer suffers from the evil spirits of the past and the reputation of our family has lessened, we have never forgotten our ancestors' teaching.*

Liang's Father: *That is, self-restraint, propriety, righteousness, and the art of banishing evil. Study our family's history, and you will find each generation has lived up to our family name and our motto. To practice restraint, seek justice and expel evil.*

Liang's Father: *Yet, Qiángliáng had not appeared to us for almost a hundred years.*

Liang's Father: *That was, until you, my daughter—my pride, successfully summoned it after these long years.*

Liang's Father: *Do you understand the weight of the expectations you now carry?*

His hand rests on the girl's shoulder, its weight like that of the world.

Girl: *I understand. You can trust in me, Father.*

She has heard this story a thousand times, and for years, this answer has been engraved in her mind, for it is the only answer she has ever been allowed to give.

Liang Yue: I will not fail our family. I will fulfill my destiny as a worthy master of Qiángliáng.

Division of Arcane Affairs, LA

Poitier: Morning, guys. Alright, who wants to hit me with some good news and make my day a little easier?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: The report on that summoning ritual is done. Seems like the destination was some farm out in the sticks.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Hey! Did someone take the pendulum without signing it out? We've only got one to go around.

Everyone in the Division of Arcane Affairs is caught up in the chaos of their own work, too busy to notice the officer who has just stepped in.

Poitier: Let's try this another way. First three of you to give me some good news will earn yourselves a coffee, my treat.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Get ready, Poitier, cause what I'm about to tell you next is gonna blow your mind.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Save me a cup. I gotta find our pendulum thief first.

Apparently, it doesn't take much to become the most popular person in the office. But before anyone can earn a steaming cup of joe, an angry shout interrupts them.

???: Hello. Excuse me. I'm still here.

???: *tut* I'm a tax-paying citizen. I pay your salary, so why don't you stop gossiping and do your job?! A crooked stick will have a crooked shadow!

He shoots Poitier a glare before stomping his way out of the Division of Arcane Affairs, muttering curses under his breath.

Poitier: Him again? What's he complaining about this time?

Having brought the missing pendulum back to its place, the officer strides over and grabs a coffee. He shrugs.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Ah, some nonsense about making a mistake while we were out searching for a dog in Chinatown.

Poitier: A missing pooch? Since when are we the dog patrol?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Ah. I know. It's not our job. And then he got all huffy about us being brash and naive, and then it was right back to complaining about the incident last year.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: You remember? When that rookie saw bruises on a kid and kicked up a whole fuss about child abuse? Turned out it was just some traditional Chinese massage. After they got cleared of the charges, the kid's parents were fuming about it for weeks.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: But like, come on, it's literally a rookie mistake. He apologized, and they forgave him. You'd think that'd be problem solved, right? But this guy just wouldn't let it go. He's not even related.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Still, must have left a bad taste in his mouth, I guess. I just don't get why he's complaining about it to us. We don't find missing dogs. We find critters.

They exchange a glance, and Poitier lets out a sigh.

Poitier: Well, at least most folks are friendly.

Poitier: Yeah, yeah. Well, I was asking for good news. So how about something upbeat?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Sorry. I've got nothing of that particular flavor. Just the opposite.

Poitier: Let me guess. Our "vigilante" struck again?

The officer drops the morning paper in front of her. As her eyes land on the headline, her coffee suddenly smells bitter.

Poitier: "The Vigilante 'Nightpiercer' Bestows Justice to L.A. Streets." Urgh, so melodramatic. Who got hit this time?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Some rich varsity boys. They got in the news over some hazing incident that put a teammate into the ICU. But, you know how it is. Strings were pulled, and all the charges went away.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: But, get this: all of them were found pinned up on the school's fencing this morning, and with those injuries, looks like they can kiss college football goodbye.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Hate to say it, but I gotta side with the vigilante on this one. Those kids were monsters. Still ...

Arcane Affairs Officer II: We're the police, and crime is crime. Doesn't matter how scummy the victims might be.

Irritated, Poitier tosses the newspaper onto one of the many cluttered desks around her.

Poitier: The arcane skill this guy cast, using those needles? It's like he's trying to imitate Detective C07. What's up with that?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: C07, like from the movie series? Don't act so surprised I've seen them. You know I love movies about arcanum.

Poitier: So, do we got anything?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Ha. Have you seen the look on Chief Elden's face yet?

Poitier looks over at the Deputy Chief's Office, squinting as she tries to see through the slatted blinds.

Poitier: Hot damn, I know that look. Wasn't the last time when he found out his daughter was dating some jackass crook?

Poitier: I know this Nightpiercer guy's been tricky, but is it really that bad?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: You don't know the half of it. The pressure's been building on him. Now, apparently, the up-tops are sending us some support.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Some cadet, from the Vigiles Bureau. I guess they've decided we're not working hard enough, or something.

Poitier: Vigiles? From the Foundation? Aren't they only responsible for the arcanum crimes that'll "cause serious consequences"?

Poitier: I don't see how this Nightpiercer guy is their kind of trouble.

Poitier: Besides, how's a vigil even going to help us? They don't know this city like we do. And not even a full agent, just a cadet.

Poitier: Wait, did you say cadet?

Poitier's head snaps back to the officer, her eyes wide. She can't just let that word slide by without notice.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: You heard me. Apparently, they decided this is gonna be a thing. Send the cadets along to assist and test their chops. So now we're not just dogcatchers. We're babysitters, too.

Poitier: Is this some kind of joke?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Your words, my lips.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: The Chief said it's a chance to develop a better working relationship between us and the Vigiles. I think brass just wants to cozy up with the St. Pavlov Foundation.

She downs the rest of her coffee and tosses the empty cup into the trash.

Poitier: Yeah, that would explain the look on Elden's face. So, what? Anyone know when this cadet is due? Or hell, anything useful at all?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: I heard tell it's some Chinese girl from a famous family of arcanists. She's got a mega-powerful familiar, and that's why the Vigiles recruited her.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Really, just for her familiar? That can't be the only reason. Did she at least like score well on her tests?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Apparently, she didn't even take the test. She was still in training when she was picked. No field experience at all.

Poitier tries to maintain her steely demeanor, but the frustration proves too much to contain.

Poitier: So you mean this girl's a total liability? Some spoiled rich kid debutante looking for a chance to polish her resume?

The officer lets out a dry chuckle, but as her reply is about to leave her lips, her eyes flick behind Poitier, and her tone changes.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: That's not exactly what I said.

They wouldn't put just anyone in this position. The office falls silent as all eyes turn to the unfamiliar figure standing in the doorway.

Liang Yue: Excuse me.

Liang Yue: I'm vigil cadet Liáng Yuè from the St. Pavlov Foundation, Vigiles Bureau, reporting for duty, ma'am. Could you please point me to Deputy Chief Elden?

Poitier: Hmm. He's in his office.

Poitier is the one to break the silence. She jerks her head toward the office in the corner as she speaks.

Liang Yue: I see. Thank you.

She offers a slight nod and, under the scrutiny of every officer present, makes her way to the Deputy Chief's Office.

As soon as the door is shut, murmurs break out like wildfire.

Poitier: That's our princess? I've seen street rats bigger. I bet I could lift her up with one hand.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Don't forget her familiar. Though, I don't see it now, so she must be a summoner.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Lucky her. I wish my great-great-great grandpa left me something like that.

Poitier: So, what's Elden gonna do? No way he's letting this baby rat scurry into our investigation. I'll show her the door myself if he'll let me.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Guaranteed our vigil-to-be is a spoiled, air-headed legacy pick. I can't imagine she's the type to follow orders.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Guys, we won't get any answers just sitting here.

Poitier: Yeah, you're right. I need to get back to work. Josh is out on leave, so I've gotta cover all his cases.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Hey, hold on. I've got a way to get the scoop on this girl.

Before Poitier can walk away, she grabs her sleeve and, with a knowing look on her face, indicates toward the Deputy Chief's office.

Deputy Chief's Office

Deputy Chief Elden: Liáng Yuè, specially recommended by the Foundation's East Asia branch for selection into the Vigiles Bureau, top-of-class during your training, selected to serve as the pilot for the vigil cadet field training program with the LAPD Division for Arcane Affairs.

Deputy Chief Elden: Hmph. It's an impressive resume.

Liang Yue: Thank you, sir. Actually, it's not that—

Deputy Chief Elden: Did I ask for an explanation?

Her voice falters for a moment.

Liang Yue: No, sir.

Deputy Chief Elden: Then don't give me one. You talk when I tell you to talk, you sit when I tell you to sit, and you do exactly as I say, when I say.

Deputy Chief Elden: Do I make myself clear?

Liang Yue: Yes, sir.

On the other side of the thin walls of the office, the officers exchange smirks as they listen in to their conversation.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Classic Elden. Reminds me of the good old days.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Good? The hell was so good about them? Think you've taken one too many smacks on the noggin. Still, she isn't as stuck-up as I expected.

Poitier: Then she's probably a wuss. I figured she was gonna back talk him—more like a meek little mouse than a rat.

They press their ears against the wall and fall silent once again.

Deputy Chief Elden: I've been told you're here to assist us in catching the vigilante known as Nightpiercer. But one look at you tells me you don't have the chops.

Deputy Chief Elden: I'll bet you're greener than any rookie on my force. Now, Liáng, answer me. Are you ready?

Liang Yue: Yes, sir.

Deputy Chief Elden: On this beat, you're going to encounter arcane crime that is worse than anything you've seen in your training—beyond your imagination. Are you prepared?

Liang Yue: Yes, sir.

Deputy Chief Elden: When it comes to dealing with arcanist criminals, you need wits and you need strength. One mistake, and you could end up in a casket on that long flight back home.

Deputy Chief Elden: So I ask again, are you up to this challenge?

Liang Yue: Yes, sir. I'm ready.

Deputy Chief Elden: No, you aren't.

He pulls a newspaper from a drawer and slams it onto the desk.

Deputy Chief Elden: Read it.

Liang Yue: The arcanist scammer, Johnny Three-Times, has been apprehended. Using his arcane skill "Omnis Obeisance," he manipulated his victims to do anything he asked, specifically, transferring all their money to him.

Liang Yue: In order to successfully cast his arcane skill, he requires his target to answer "yes" three times in one minute.

Deputy Chief Elden: If you had been dealing with him, he'd already have you dumping your trust fund into his bank account, or worse.

Liang Yue: With all due respect, sir, that isn't a fair evaluation. I wouldn't have answered you that way if you were not my commanding officer.

Deputy Chief Elden: Fair? There is no fair when it comes to arcanists. You've read the headlines about this guy and think you know what to expect, but what if he had abilities the news didn't know about? What if he could disguise himself?

Deputy Chief Elden: Or do you think that crooks just leave their resumes behind at the crime scene?

For a brief moment, she is at a loss for words.

Liang Yue: No, sir.

Deputy Chief Elden: This article was published a week ago. If you were as ready as you claimed, you should've known about this conman and his arcane skill. If you had any smarts, you'd have at least figured out I was probing you.

Deputy Chief Elden: But you didn't. I don't know what the Foundation and your Vigiles teachers taught you. Frankly, I don't care. Because you don't have the practical skills necessary to keep yourself alive on these streets.

Deputy Chief Elden: I will absolutely not put a kid like you on the Nightpiercer case.

His cold voice carries through the wall. The officers outside exchange glances.

Poitier: Cold and ruthless as a Minnesota winter. Elden's never been a people person. Guess that's why they keep him stuck down here with us.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: I don't know. I agree with him. But he's being pretty rough on her.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: She's definitely too young for this. Whatcha think? She gonna cry?

Poitier: Look, if she can't handle the Chief, then she can't handle the city.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Is that right? I seem to remember someone's eyes going red a few times on her first day.

Poitier: What? Shut up. I didn't.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Shh. Listen.

They fall silent again, waiting to hear what fate will befall the young vigil cadet.

Deputy Chief Elden: End of discussion. If you want to call home to your daddy or the Foundation and get reassigned somewhere else, be my guest.

Deputy Chief Elden: But as long as you're in my department, you'll follow my rules. For now, I'll assign you some of the lighter cases. This is grunt work, kid. Try not to mess it up.

Poitier: Hold on. I've got a bad feeling.

Poitier's eyes widen, but it's too late to act.

Deputy Chief Elden: Arya Poitier will be your partner and field training instructor. She'll be happy to help you adjust. Isn't that right, Officer Poitier?

Poitier can't help but mutter a curse under her breath.

Poitier: Crap. Guess my day isn't getting any easier.

This Is NOT a Business Ad

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

> It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.
>
> And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

We are! The Vigiles Bureau!

"Is there an arcanum situation you're dealing with?"

"Got a dispute with your arcanist neighbor?"

"Don't worry! We're here to help!"

"We are—the Vigiles Bureau!"

"Committed to upholding the Vigiles Mediation Code! Protectors of peace in every situation!"

"Whether it's for you or your local police, we've got your back!"

"Next time, leave this to the foundation's PR department. These guys are hopeless at this," the senior remarked, sealing away the footage while struggling to keep a straight face. "I'm getting a headache ... Their evaluations will just have to be postponed for another three months."

This Is 100% a Business Ad

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

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Branch 1

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Branch 2

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Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

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Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Your Close Companion is Here

"Close Companions," everyone's best friends. The earliest of these companions can be traced back to the East, where the "Zhenzi" befriended the powerful "Xiandao Beast." Together, they battled against evil and maintained peace and harmony. To this day, the "Liang" family still takes pride in the bond their ancestors shared with "Qiangliang the Xiandao Beast." The Xiandao Beasts protect the world, a story familiar to every child, often whispered by their mothers to soothe them to sleep ...

But it's not just a legend; close companions also exist around us. Your grey-headed chickadee poet, your imaginary wolf friend, your changeling childhood playmate—they've long been a part of our lives, and have become our most loyal friends ...

Now, it's your turn to find your own close companion—or perhaps get one for the kids! Thanks to the NewBabel Critter Rehab Center, critter companions are coming to every home!

Special thanks to the St. Pavlov Foundation for providing the companion footage featured in this program.

Total Crisis · 1/2

SC-02

Poitier: Here we are. Get out.

Street, Los Angeles

Poitier: First case of the day.

Poitier: Any time regular beat cops find a case related to arcanum, they'll call it in to Dispatch, then we get to come mop it up.

Poitier: This is what we call a Basic Arcanum Incident, the bread-and-butter of our work, kid. It's not often that we get anything urgent, but you've gotta stay on your toes.

Poitier: But to be honest, I hope we don't get anything big today. Last thing I want is to take a rookie like you into a real emergency.

Liang Yue: I hope so, too.

Poitier: That's "Yes, ma'am." You got me?

Poitier: You're probably thinking I'm trying to put you in your place, huh? That I'm just bossing you around.

Poitier: But get off your high horse, princess. Cause as long as I'm your field instructor, you need to show some respect.

This is the "pro tip" her colleagues gave her before she left. If your trainee has powerful connections, you've got two choices: either make sure they know who's in charge from day one, or spend the rest of your day sucking up to them.

But it seems she and her colleagues were worrying over nothing.

Liang Yue: But I don't have a horse, and I didn't think you were bossy. I'm honored to have you as my partner and field instructor. I look forward to learning under you.

Poitier: Hmm?

Pretty humble coming from a big-shot cadet. Poitier narrows her eyes, only to be met with an earnest, slightly puzzled gaze.

Liang Yue: Is there something wrong with what I said, ma'am?

Poitier: Are you just that much of a pushover, or is this all an act?

Liang Yue: P-Pardon? I don't quite understand.

Poitier: Nothing. Just keep close. You never know what can happen with these cases.

They take their last few steps up to the door and ring the bell. Heavy footsteps approach from within, and the door is flung open with a bang.

Citizen I: Oh, finally. Do you know how long I've been waiting? Those monsters are at it again. Do something.

Such an "enthusiastic" welcome isn't exactly what the vigil cadet was expecting.

She turns her head, only to see her instructor comfortably positioned a few feet behind her. Looks like she'll have to handle this one on her own.

Liang Yue: Um, please remain calm, ma'am. We're here now, and we won't let them hurt you.

Liang Yue: Am I correct that you reported there are critters that have broken into your house? Could you describe them for us? Do you have an idea how many?

Citizen I: I don't know. Like a ton, a bunch, two and a half butt-loads. I didn't stick around to count them.

Even among the woman's chaotic shouting, useful information can be extracted. Liáng quickly formulates a plan.

Liang Yue: So, there are many of them. Hmm, in that case, I suggest we split up, ma'am.

Liang Yue: You could stay here and keep the lady safe, and send me to take the critters down? Given we're in the city, I suspect them to be tamed, and it's possible that someone may be controlling them.

Liang Yue: Once we've established their type, we may be able to deduce the incantation that's controlling them. Some incantations can be easily traced, such as the Manipulation incantation or the Shadow incantation—

Citizen I: Ahhh. Over there. There they are.

Liang Yue: Please stay behind me, ma'am. Where are ...

Liang Yue: ... are ... they ...?

She freezes mid-step, her eyes locking onto a corner of the yard. From the shadows, a row of plump creatures waddles into view.

Munchalo: Mooo.

Liang Yue: Is this ...?

Liang Yue: This appears to be a Munchalo, a new breed of critter from the Ms. NewBabel Critter Rehabilitation Center, endorsed by the LSCC. They're medium to large in size, and classed as non-aggressive.

Liang Yue: The Munchalo consumes base arcane materials and extracts the energy from them. They're intended to assist in the arcane production industry. They've been slated for worldwide distribution.

Liang Yue: But, why are they here?

Citizen I: Well? What are you waiting for? Do something. Kill them, ah!

Liang Yue: Kill them? Oh, ma'am. Please don't worry. They will not attack people, and it's against our procedures to kill non-aggressive critters without authorization.

Citizen I: But they're destroying my azaleas. And the stairs and my lawn. And they almost bit my sweetie's tail off, ah.

Even the ever-composed vigil cadet is momentarily at a loss for words.

Liang Yue: Your sweetie? Um, I see, ma'am. I will do my best to get them out—

She decides to put off investigating "sweetie's" identity for now. But before she can act, a shrill voice interrupts from outside the yard.

Citizen II: Hey! Don't you dare lay a finger on my precious munchies.

Liang Yue: Wha—Can I help you, sir?

Citizen I: I-I knew it. This jerk is my next-door neighbor. He keeps all kinds of these ridiculous, smelly critters around. I order you to throw him and all his disgusting little pets in jail.

Citizen II: Are you out of your mind? They're just some adorable Munchalos. What kind of sicko would wanna hurt them?

The shouting match quickly escalates as a barrage of increasingly colorful insults fills the air.

Liang Yue: ...

Liáng glances at her instructor. Poitier simply smirks and shrugs.

Poitier: What did I tell you, huh?

Munchalo: Mooo.

Spot Check

小径

Here is a well known question you must have heard: "What goes on four legs in the morning, two in the afternoon, and three in the evening?" it's so well "known" that no one finds it novel anymore.

But please do me a favor and answer me yourself.

Choices

1. "A human being"
2. Let's talk about the questioner instead.

Branch 1

Correct! This is the same answer Oedipus gave to defeat Sphinx. Thus becoming a hero, but also starting him on his ill-fated destiny.

Raise a question, give an answer. This is the most fundamental ritual. Through this, we get nearer to God.

Branch 2

The Sphinx, an embodiment of mercy and nobility in Egypt, was seen as a mystery to the Greeks: a dangerous being that kept secrets, and delivered the punishments of the gods.

When the question is answered, the ritual is finished, and the answerer is granted the right to reach the treasure it guards.

Choices

1. Ritual?

Yes, a ritual. Whether it is by pouring out wine; slaughtering a calf; or circling round a fire with a baby in your arms... It is an agreement; a question that demands an answer.

Every desire has a price. Whether it is paid in wine, blood, or fire, but sometimes that sacrifice is taken from you without it ever being noticed.

And the treasure you seek might be the undoing of your own desires.

Let us take a look at another question: "Stranger, what's your name?" Cried Polyphemus.

"Nobody!" Odysseus answered, and it allowed him to flee the cyclops' cave, safe and sound.

A human being and nobody, two answers that could not be more alike, yet both were bound to fate by their answer.

Alright, dear, time to call it a day. As for you? You'll get the answers you seek, you've already paid the price.

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Total Crisis · 2/2

SC-02

Restaurant

Poitier: Finally, lunchtime. I'll grab the cheeseburger and an Americano—large.

The front door to the diner has barely closed by the time Poitier has shouted out her order. It seems this is just another part of a beat cop's routine.

Poitier: So, some fluffy trespassers, an alchemy incident, a noise complaint for a werewolf-infected, and a speeding ticket on an unregistered arcane vehicle ...

Poitier: Honestly, busier than I expected, but it all went smoother than I expected too. We've earned ourselves a decent lunch, I'd say. So, what do you want, princess?

Liáng studies the menu on the wall, hesitating to answer.

Poitier: What? Don't tell me our little vigil princess can't stomach a bit of fast food?

Poitier: Better get used to it, kid. We're on a tight schedule. There's no time for fancy dining.

Liang Yue: Oh, it's not that. It's just ... Are all the restaurants here so expensive? This is the first time I've been to L.A., and it seems things cost more than I expected.

Poitier is taken aback.

Poitier: What, you broke? You telling me the Foundation—THE FOUNDATION—can't afford to pay you a decent wage?

Liang Yue: Oh, no. No. It's ... My subsidy should be enough for daily necessities. It's only that I was hoping to save some money, but it seems the prices here won't allow me to.

Liang Yue: Sorry, please forget it. I'll have a chicken sandwich. Thank you.

Poitier: Okay.

Their orders placed, the two take a seat at Poitier's usual spot.

Poitier: Alright, question time, rookie. Cause I think I've got the wrong impression.

Poitier: What I heard was that you were some pampered rich kid from a crazy old legendary family.

After a brief flicker of surprise, Liáng's expression shifts. It's as if she expected to hear this question, or at least has grown accustomed to it.

Liang Yue: It's true. The Liáng family have a long history and many legendary ancestors.

Liang Yue: But that was a long time ago. Nowadays, we're not so different from any other ordinary family.

Poitier: Mhm, sure. "Ordinary," that's definitely what I think of when I see you.

Poitier: I also heard that you've got a familiar.

Liang Yue: You mean Qiángliáng?

Poitier: Yeah, sure, that. Come on. It's some mysterious arcane creature from the Far East. Everyone in the DAA's curious about it, myself included.

Poitier: So, you gonna show me?

Liáng looks a little troubled.

Liang Yue: Um, now? I'm sorry, but I must refuse your request, Ms. Poitier.

Liang Yue: With all due respect, the Qiángliáng is a sacred being. It is deserving of great respect.

Liang Yue: It has a divine mission to expel diseases and evil beings and has guarded the world through the ages.

Liang Yue: Maybe that just sounds like old legends, but it's the truth. We've recorded every battle it fought in our family chronicles.

Liang Yue: And we're only allowed to borrow its power when we are in the greatest of danger.

Liang Yue: Please understand that I can't just summon it simply to show it to others.

Poitier: Okay, okay. I'm not unreasonable, princess. If it's a sacred thing or whatever, I won't bother you over it.

From Liáng's sincerity, it's clear that this isn't just an excuse. Poitier isn't annoyed by it, but she does seem a little bored by the overly serious response.

An awkward silence falls at the table. Luckily, the waitress breaks it with the arrival of their meals.

Poitier: Anyway, I guess I should say, you're doing a lot better than I thought today. And I don't just give out compliments, you got that? So, take some pride in it.

Poitier: But don't get cocky either. This was all chump work. You haven't seen the ugly side of this job yet.

Poitier: This morning might have been a cakewalk. But this job can blindside you just like that. Never underestimate anything.

She takes a hefty bite of her burger and launches into a monologue, the food still rolling around in her mouth. Liáng simply looks blank. Poitier finally swallows.

Poitier: Hey? You in there, princess?

Liang Yue: I apologize, but in our family, we have a rule, Shí Bù Yán, Qǐn Bù Yǔ. It means we believe you shouldn't talk when eating or sleeping.

Poitier: What? You're kidding! You trying to say I'm being rude? Or wait, you're serious, aren't you?

Liáng sits totally still, her expression unchanged.

Poitier: What kind of stupid rule is that?

Poitier: Besides, why would anyone be talking while they're asleep? What, like you can't sleep talk? How do you even control that?

Poitier appears to be giving the question some genuine thought.

Liang Yue: Sorry, maybe I didn't translate it right. It means "keep quiet before sleep."

Poitier: ...

For a long moment, Poitier stares at her, dumbfounded. Then, she slumps back in her seat.

Poitier: The heck? So many rules. Damn, princess, you must've had a miserable childhood.

Poitier: Let me guess. Every day was courses and training, stuck inside, no books, no movies. Did they even let you watch Saturday morning cartoons? I've heard of kids like you. Sounds worse than jail to me.

Poitier: A childhood like that is rough, kid. It's bad for your head. Bad for the job, too.

Liáng furrows her brow a little. She can't follow her thought process at all.

Liang Yue: I don't understand why you're upset, Ms. Poitier. How is it bad for the job?

Poitier: Did you check the list of incidents before we set off? There's a case we're going to after lunch. A director that received some kind of threat. She's shooting a film in Chinatown.

Poitier: Anyways, this director's an arcanist, and her movie is all about arcanum. So, it's in our department.

Poitier: The point is, knowing's half the battle in this job. It'd be easier if you were a cinephile or at least familiar with films. Maybe then you'd know a thing or two about her.

Poitier: She's famous for those Detective C07 films, the first movies to really put a focus on arcanum and arcanists. Something about it, though: the detective in those films used a skill a lot like this Nightpiercer crook.

Poitier: What's her name again? Something with an N? Nu ...

Poitier strains to recall the name. She only saw it flash on screen for a moment when she watched the film way back when. In her focus, she fails to notice the flash of surprise on Liáng's face.

Liang Yue: Noire.

Poitier: Yeah. That's it.

Poitier: Wait, so you—

Liang Yue: Yes, I've watched her movies, too.

Poitier: I'll be damned. So, was it a special reward for getting straight A's? Or—

Dispatch Center: Calling all nearby units. Code 3. We have a hostage situation at City Hall.

The radio announcement cuts their get-to-know-you session short.

Dispatch Center: Suspect is a registered arcanist, posing a threat to life. On-scene officers are requesting immediate arcanist support.

Liang Yue: City Hall? We're close by, aren't we?

Poitier: Pack up. Lunchtime's over.

Order and Chaos

SC-03

City Hall

Old Police Officer: Let go of the hostage, sir. This won't do you any good.

Enraged Man: Go away!!

Old Police Officer: Damn!

Old Police Officer: That was close! Where's our backup?

Poitier: DAA, at your service.

Liang Yue: What's the situation?

Old Police Officer: See for yourself.

The City Hall, usually bustling with foot traffic, now stands eerily empty. The reason is immediately clear.

Enraged Man: Don't come any closer! Stay back! Stay back!!

Hostage: Please! Don't kill me! I'm sorry, I really am! Please let me go!

Enraged Man: Shut up! It's too late now. Say another word, and you're dead! Stay back!!

He swings the blade in his hand wildly, his voice a furious, panicked snarl.

The crowd on the other side of the police barricade instinctively recoils, but the woman standing just ten paces away doesn't move an inch.

???: Hey, hey. Trust me, pal.

???: You really don't want to do this.

Poitier: Who's that? Doesn't look like one of ours.

Old Police Officer: Just some civvy. She was talking with the suspect before we got here.

Liang Yue: That woman ...

Poitier: What, you know her? Look familiar or something?

Liang Yue: No. Just a thought. It's nothing.

???: ...

The woman glances toward the officers, seeming to notice their conversation.

???: People make mistakes. But some mistakes can't be undone. Don't put that blood on your hands, or it'll never wash off.

???: Is hurting this guy worth all that pain and guilt?

???: Sooner or later, he'll get what's coming to him for what he's done. I promise you that.

Her words seem to have an effect. The hostage-taker hesitates, his face contorted in pain, his grip on the knife faltering.

Enraged Man: But, but, I must ...

Poitier: He's distracted. Rookie, time for us to take him down!

Liang Yue: Please stand down, sir.

Although almost half his size, Liáng manages to pin the suspect to the ground. The other officers swarm in, snapping handcuffs around his wrists before he can put up another fight.

Old Police Officer: Suspect under control. I repeat, suspect under control. No further backup needed.

Looks like this case is wrapped up.

Poitier: Nice moves. I was kinda hoping we'd get to see that familiar of yours, though.

Liang Yue: A simple threat like this isn't worthy of Qiángliáng. I have to reserve its assistance unless absolutely necessary.

Poitier: So, is this just another one of those rules? Or, do you mean its help comes with a price tag?

Liang Yue: Both.

Despite the curtness of her response, her eyes widen a little at Poitier's astuteness.

Poitier scowls.

Poitier: That it?

Liang Yue: What do you mean?

Poitier: I mean, so far, every time you talk about the job or your family rules, it's just the surface-level stuff. How do you actually feel about any of this?

Liáng looks genuinely confused.

Liang Yue: How I feel? I-I don't understand why it would be necessary to mention that.

Poitier: Cause we're partners, kid. We've got to trust each other. How am I gonna let you watch my six if I don't even know how you tick?

But Liáng still doesn't seem to get it.

Liang Yue: I see. You're my partner and instructor during my assignment with the LAPD Division of Arcane Affairs.

Liang Yue: So, I will do my best to learn from you and complete my work as assigned. I won't slow you down.

Poitier: That's not what I'm—Urgh. Forget it.

Liang Yue: ...?

Liáng's tone all but says, "My personal feelings don't matter." Poitier gives up trying to argue with someone with such a stubborn, unreadable demeanor.

She simply stares at her, quietly seething to herself. Luckily, before things can spiral further, the hostage cuts through the tension.

Hostage: Oh, thank God you took down that lunatic. I'm really grateful, Miss.

Hostage: But, ain't you a bit young to be an Arcane Affairs Officer? I think I've seen that uniform somewhere else before. You're a vigil, right?

Liang Yue: Yes, sir. Wait.

Liáng swallows the rest of her words as she stares at the hostage she just rescued, her expression suddenly wary.

Liang Yue: I know you.

Liang Yue: The arcanist scammer, Johnny Three-Times, has been apprehended. Using his arcane skill "Omnis Obeisance," he manipulated his victims to do anything he asked, specifically, transferring all their money to him.

Liang Yue: You're that scammer, Johnny Three-Times.

Johnny Three-Times: Oopsie. Guess that's the downside of getting your name in the papers.

Poitier: What? Didn't we already book that guy? What's he doing here?

Old Police Officer: He got a sweetheart deal. A reduced sentence in exchange for revealing where he stashed all the dough he stole.

Old Police Officer: And it was a s**tload of money too, apparently from some big donors to the mayor's re-election campaign.

Old Police Officer: Of course, he demanded he be present for the unveiling of his stash. So, they brought him here. That's when this loony attacked the police escort and took him hostage.

Johnny Three-Times: Hey, easy, officer. You've already got me. No need to be so rough with the cuffs.

Old Police Officer: Clam it, Johnny.

Poitier: We should've just let that guy ice him.

Liang Yue: May I ask, officer, do we know if the man trying to kill him was—

Old Police Officer: Yeah, he's the son of a victim. This bastard took his mom for all she was worth, and when she found out—boom—heart attack.

He shakes his head, heaving a weary sigh. Johnny Three-Times snickers.

Johnny Three-Times: Ha. Like mother, like son. He was just as dumb as his doddering old mom. Worse even, cause he didn't even catch wise to it.

Johnny Three-Times: It's a concrete jungle, baby, and it follows jungle rules. Survival of the fittest. Crap for brains here never had a chance.

Johnny Three-Times: If it wasn't me, it woulda been someone else. What a joke! Imagine keeling over just cause you lost a bit of cash.

Johnny Three-Times: Then we've got this dumbass, coming at me with even less of a brain. Think about it. If he killed me, how's he gonna get his money back?

Poitier: Shut the f**k up, asshole!

She levels a punch to his gut, sending him crumpling to the ground, gasping for air.

Johnny Three-Times: UGH!

Liang Yue: Officer Poitier, what are you doing?

Poitier: What? I'm teaching this douchebag a lesson.

Liang Yue: But we can't do that. It's against the rules.

Liáng steps between the two, blocking Poitier from doing any more.

Johnny Three-Times: *cough* Well, I guess the Vigiles are a cut above the trash when it comes to the DAA. Am I right?

Poitier takes a deep breath as she tries to rein in her frustration.

Poitier: Let's get this straight, rookie. You don't tell me what to do.

Poitier: I should've known. You're just the worst kind of cop—Everything by the book, sticking to your high-and-mighty principles like you know what's best.

She lets out a frosty huff and turns away.

Liang Yue: ...

Girl: Liáng Yuè! How dare you rat us out?

Liang Yue: Be-Because you did something wrong.

Girl: Then you're a rat. I didn't really care if you wanted to come along, but now you go and snitch on us?

Boy: I told you we shouldn't have invited her.

Liang Yue: Wait, don't go.

Liang Yue: I—

The clamor of fearful voices cuts her off.

Young Police Officer: No. Somebody stop him.

Exorcism · 1/2

SC-04

Johnny Three-Times: Stay back!! Help me! Help!!!

The City Hall has been plunged back into chaos. Johnny lets out a shriek, scrambling to get as far away as possible.

Enraged Man: Get away!

Young Police Officer: Urgh!

He hurls the officer aside. Blood drips down his fingers from the thumb he broke to slip his hand out of his cuffs.

He moves with inhuman strength, fighting off the approaching officers with ease.

Enraged Man: Out of my way! I will kill you! I will kill you all!

Poitier: Damn it! Is this dude high or something?

Liang Yue: No, no. I don't think this is drugs.

Liang Yue: It's an arcane skill. I sense some kind of evil spirit.

Liang Yue: I think I can stop him, ma'am.

The tension between them has been totally forgotten. The situation is urgent. Poitier gives a sharp nod.

Poitier: Fine. Whatever it is, and whatever you think you can do, do it.

Liang Yue: I will. This is my duty.

Liáng gives a firm nod before rushing toward the suspect.

Enraged Man: Kill ... I must kill this bastard.

Enraged Man: Who are you?!

Liang Yue: Please stay calm, sir. I have no weapon.

Liang Yue: I'm just here to make a phone call.

Enraged Man: What? A phone call?

Liang Yue: Yes.

Liang Yue: And you're going to make it.

Enraged Man: Who are you dialing?

Liang Yue: You'll soon find out.

Liang Yue: Arise Qiángliáng, swift and fierce! Banish all evil and cleanse this place!

Deleted Scene

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.

And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Live Tonight with Special Guests

"Tonight's first guest is a brilliant young actress you've seen in C07 Part 1 and C07 Part 2. Now, she's returning for the upcoming C07 Part 3—though, honestly, why not just call them C08 and C09? Anyway, please welcome Qi Xing!"

...

"And then? You know what Noire said? She said, 'We're wrapping up, so we might as well use all the explosives!'"

"So your reaction to the explosion wasn't just your stellar acting?"

"I'd like to think some of it was! But that wide-eyed reaction when the explosion's shockwave hit me? That was definitely real."

"No more big fireworks for Part 3, I take it? You must have used them all up in the last one."

"Fifty-fifty."

"What's that?"

"Fifty-fifty. Either this film ends the series with a bang or flops on its face because of its garbage excuse for an ending. It—"

"Whoa, whoa, whoa! I think we're about to head into spoiler territory! Before Noire sues us, let's cut to commercial!"

Routine Check

小径

Look at this mirror, dear. There's a sizable stain on it.

Choices

1. It's broken.

2. I don't see any stains.

Branch 1

Yes, it is. Maybe its owner meant to break it so that the stain would be thoroughly removed.

Now the stain is gone, and the owner has a collection of little mirrors. She must have accidentally left this one behind.

Branch 2

Look closer, dear. You can no longer see the part that has broken off, but you can see where it once was. Right there, a sizable stain.

The owner thought the stain would be removed if she smashed the mirror. Now she has a collection of little mirrors, and the stain has gone into hiding.

Choices

1. Whose mirror is this?

A lady with great ambitions and an unconscious charm. A lady who wishes to make the rest of the world accept who she is, and has suggested that many others join her way of thinking.

Her brother, on the contrary, hopes to be taken in. In his attempt to act like everyone else, he lost an arm in a duel.

If you ask me, dear, I'd say they're very alike. Equally lonely.

The brother and sister are a mirror image of each other. She's often repulsed by the sight of him, unable to reconcile herself with all that he reminds her of.

Now, the brother has found his missing arm, along with his long-lost dignity. The surgery that the sister had been hoping would be done on this world has finally started. But all of a sudden, she's terrified of the incisions.

As I said, despite their differences in approach, the brother and sister are mirror images of one another.

But now the mirror is broken. I hope she can make it through the seven years of bad luck. Poor thing. There's no way around it.

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Exorcism · 2/2

SC-04

Enraged Man: No! No! My head! Ugh!

Enraged Man: I'm so sorry, Mama.

With one last garbled whisper, the man collapses. The officers around him remain frozen, still too wary to approach.

Young Police Officer: Should we cuff him?

Liang Yue: Allow me. But I believe we should bring him to the hospital to be checked over immediately.

Old Police Officer: Think you can handle him? We got this conman to take care of.

She follows the older officer's gaze.

Not long ago, Johnny Three-Times was brimming with arrogance. Now, he is a crumpled heap on the floor. A dark stain has formed on the crotch of his pants.

Poitier: God, what a loser.

Poitier sneers, shaking her head as she turns away. She hesitates, then shifts her gaze to Liáng.

Poitier: So, uh, y-you know what I'm about to say, right?

Liang Yue: ...?

Liáng looks visibly confused, although more understandably this time.

Poitier: Okay. I'm sorry. Is that what you want? For me to say it? Sorry.

Poitier: I felt bad for that guy, but there was nothing we could do for him while he was possessed. If it weren't for you, we might've shot him.

Poitier: Well done, Vigil Liáng. And please just forget what I said. I was out of line.

The moment her apology ends, she turns her head, unwilling to see Liáng's reaction. But after a long pause, there is no response.

Poitier: Say something.

She looks back to see Liáng frozen in surprise.

Liang Yue: Oh, right, I ...

Liang Yue: It's okay. I didn't take it to heart.

Poitier: Ahem. Good.

???: Heh heh.

Poitier: Who's there?

A stifled laugh hits their ears. Poitier springs back like a startled cat.

???: Sorry, I shouldn't eavesdrop. It's a bad habit.

???: It's just you remind me of my friends back in the old days.

Liang Yue: You're the lady that tried to help us soothe him. Thank you for the help.

Liang Yue: It could have turned out much worse if you hadn't been there. Thank you again.

???: That's too kind of you, young vigil. I just did what anyone should. Really, it was you and your partner that were the real heroes.

Liang Yue: You're too modest, ma'am. Actually, forgive me for asking.

Liang Yue: Haven't I seen your face before?

She studied the woman's face for quite some time before speaking this thought aloud.

They haven't met in person, no, it was in some other way, but how? Where? She has barely begun forming the words when the woman gives her the answer.

???: Good to know that someone still remembers those old flicks, even after all these years.

The features of the face beneath the beret overlap with a face from Liáng's memory.

But the face she remembers lacks the maturity and composure of the woman before her. That face was brimming with youthful confidence, full of fire and energy.

But one thing has remained the same—those bright, shining eyes, like stars twinkling on silver screens and television sets.

Liang Yue: Yes, from the movies. That's right.

Liang Yue: You—You're ...

Qi Xing: Oops, you got me. I'm Qí Xīng, or were you hoping I'd say Detective Co7?

She winks at the two dumbfounded officers.

Hospital

ER Doctor: Our full report will take some time. You'll need to wait for now.

Liang Yue: Thank you, doctor.

Poitier: Our perp had his ID with him. That saves us a lot of digging. Eric Wong, 43, runs a grocery store in Chinatown.

Poitier: Let's see. The only family member we've got is his wife, a Lilian Lau, who immigrated to the States 10 years ago. Both have no criminal record, totally clean.

Poitier: He's an arcanist, apparently, and a powerful one at that. But no reports of any prior misuse of arcanum.

Poitier: His car was found near the crime scene, all filled up with potatoes and carrots from the wholesalers. Either this was just a spur-of-the-moment whacko move or some bizarre attempt at a tuber-based alibi.

Poitier: Anyway. We've contacted his wife, and she should be here soon. Maybe we'll get some more clues from her.

Poitier: Yo, Liáng? You listening?

Liang Yue: Oh. Y-You're right.

Poitier: ...

The answer is obvious—No. Poitier takes a deep breath.

Poitier: Earth calling Liáng.

Liang Yue: Whoa!

The sudden shout snaps Liáng out of her daze.

Liang Yue: Officer Poitier, we're in a hospital. We should keep quiet.

Poitier: Hmph. I would have, but that didn't seem likely to bring you back to earth, space cadet.

Poitier: So, what's got you lost in space now?

Liang Yue: Um, I-I'm just thinking.

Poitier: About what?

Liang Yue: About Ms. Qí Xīng.

Poitier: Ha, right. I guess you're really into those movies, huh? It's all good, boo.

Poitier: I get the picture now. Our little C07 fan sneaking into the cinema behind her parents' back. You know, you're beginning to almost seem human, princess.

Poitier: At first, I thought you might be an android, like those Laplace bots that they've got writing parking tickets for us.

Liang Yue: I ...

Liáng looks as if she wants to argue, but at the last moment, she stops herself.

Liang Yue: In fact, I do like Ms. Qí Xīng's C07 movies very much. Her character means a lot to me.

Poitier: Oh. Is that the reason why you decided to be a vigil?

Liang Yue: Specifically, yes. It's the reason I decided my destiny was to be in the police.

Liang Yue: But back to the topic. I was thinking about Ms. Qí Xīng, but it wasn't because I like her or anything like that.

She shakes her head, her gaze sharpening, her brows furrowed slightly.

Liang Yue: It's just that ... her being here made me think about Nightpiercer. Ms. Qí Xīng has a similar arcane skill to the one he appears to use. She called it Silver Needle. She even performed it in her movies.

Liang Yue: Could that really just be a coincidence?

Poitier: Huh?

The officer knits her brow as if she's just been hit with a bad joke. But Liáng, deep in thought, continues.

Liang Yue: And what she said felt meaningful, in some way.

One hour earlier

Liang Yue: It's a great pleasure to meet you, Ms. Qí Xīng. I—I grew up watching your films.

Liang Yue: But what are you doing here in L.A.? Um, I mean, if it's okay to ask?

Qi Xing: Sure, not a problem at all. I'm here to see an old friend.

Though she was once a star known across the nation, Qí Xīng speaks warmly and without airs. It's like she's chatting with an old friend.

Liang Yue: Is it Ms. Noire? I heard she's planning a new film.

Qi Xing: Oh, so you heard the news? It's been a long time since I last saw her. You're right, though, kid. I've got something I need to talk to her about.

Liang Yue: Um, of course. That's great.

Liang Yue: Oh, and the Dùshuò Festival is coming soon. I hope you'll go to the Shèhuǒ Parade in Chinatown. It'd be so much fun to see you there.

Poitier: ...?

The quiet, reserved Liáng has suddenly turned chatty. Poitier stares at her. She's like an entirely different person.

Qi Xing: Shèhuǒ ... Is it really that time of year again?

Liang Yue: You don't like the parade?

Qi Xing: Of course I do.

Qi Xing: I like every bit of it—watching people eat, perform, and come together to celebrate the end of the year and to pray for peace and good luck in the next.

Qi Xing: I like the pure and simple wish that the Shèhuǒ Parade carries.

Qi Xing: But it always reminds me of the ending.

Poitier: What ending?

Qí Xīng falls silent, shaking her head. But no more explanation is needed. Liáng's memories have come back to her.

Liang Yue: You mean the ending of the last film in the Co7 series?

She must have guessed correctly. Qí Xīng's eyes widen a little. Then, she gives a small nod.

Qi Xing: Yes.

Qi Xing: I know lots of people like that ending. "A reflection of reality," they say, "Tragedy leaves people with a deeper impression than comedy."

Qi Xing: But as for me, I hated it. The good guys failed, and the bad guys won? Ha. What kind of an ending is that?

Qi Xing: Maybe we don't get a say in how things work in reality, but in stories we can. We should.

Qi Xing: Reality itself is tragic enough already. Why should a movie remind us of how absurd things really are? "What goes around comes around." That's what people want to see in the movies.

Her tone has turned unusually serious for a discussion about film, but these words strike a chord with Liáng.

Liang Yue: I-I agree with you. When I was little, I also didn't like how it ended.

Liang Yue: Maybe it's true that reality can't guarantee us true justice, but I still want to see justice being served, at least in fiction.

This response seems to earn Qí Xīng's approval.

Qi Xing: I feel the same way. Pardon me for asking.

Qi Xing: That beast you summoned was something else. It reminded me of a certain creature, a legendary beast from the north of China.

Qi Xing: *"Arise Qiángliáng, swift and fierce! Banish all evil and cleanse this place!"*

Qi Xing: That must make you a descendant of the Liáng family, right?

Something in Qí Xīng's gaze makes Liáng feel as though she's standing too close to an open flame. But even so, she answers truthfully.

Liang Yue: Yes. I'm Liáng Yuè, from the Liáng family of the Twelve Zhènzǐ.

Qi Xing: Liáng Yuè ... Liáng Yuè.

Qi Xing: It's a good name, little vigil. I'll keep it in mind.

Outsider · 1/2

SC-05

Liang Yue: I read an article about the conflicts between Ms. Qí Xīng and the other two producers of the C07 series.

Liang Yue: Before, I thought it was only rumors. But now, thinking over what she said, what if it's true?

Liang Yue: What am I saying? It's ridiculous.

Poitier: Then stop pouting over it, princess. We've got work to do.

Liang Yue: Urgh!

The hallway of the Laplace Rehabilitation Center Cooperative Hospital is bustling with people. Lost in thought, Liáng is jolted back to reality by a firm clap on the back.

Poitier: You wanna bet on how many people in L.A. have similar arcane skills? Come on. It's a total coincidence.

Poitier: You don't really think they're the same person, do you? That'd be nuts!

Poitier: I mean it's the Detective C07 we're talking about. Sure, she's been retired from acting for a while, but she's like super famous.

Poitier: If she was gonna go all kooky and start taking out crooks like she was the real C07, why wait all this time? It's been years since her last movie, and we're only just dealing with this Nightpiercer guy now.

Poitier: Besides, it's not like it's a crazy, unusual type of arcane skill. Who knows? Maybe this Nightpiercer guy is a fan of Detective C07's films too? Can't rule out anything yet.

Poitier: Hey, you okay in there? Did I knock the wind out of you?

Liang Yue: *cough* It's okay. I'm fine.

Liáng shakes her head.

Poitier, still bewildered and perhaps feeling a little guilty, insists that she didn't mean to hit her so hard. Not that it matters. At least the sudden smack did the trick in pulling Liáng out of her spiraling thoughts.

Neither the test results nor the suspect's family has arrived yet. Liáng makes her way to the vending machine at the far end of the hallway with the coins Poitier dropped in her hand as a half-hearted apology and buys herself an orange juice.

But that absurd thought, that ridiculous guess from earlier, still refuses to leave her mind.

Liang Yue: Forget it. Just like you said, it doesn't make any sense.

All attempts to push the thought from her mind are failing. That is, until a frantic voice cuts through the air.

Doctor: But you're injured, ma'am. You can't just leave.

???: I'm totally fine. It's just a tiny smidge of damage. I can fix it myself.

Doctor: You call a broken arm a smidge? You need to let us treat it immediately.

Liang Yue: What's going on here?

The doctor recognizes her uniform immediately.

Doctor: Are you a vigil? Could you help me stop this girl? She's trying to leave with a broken arm.

Doctor: She was in an accident. But since she's woken up, she's refused to let us examine anything.

Doctor: She might not be our normal kind of patient, but we're doctors. We can't let someone leave when they need immediate medical attention.

???: A vigil?

???: I-I-I-I-I-I'm in a hurry now. I'm gonna miss my bus.

Beneath the girl's clothing, the exposed skin has a cold, metallic sheen. That must be what the doctor meant by "not our normal kind of patient."

Liáng notices the emblem on her chest, marking her as an employee of the St. Pavlov Foundation. How odd that she'd have such a panicked reaction at the sight of a vigil.

Liang Yue: There'll be another bus, but you only have one body. You should listen to the doctor, sit down, and wait, until you're cleared to leave.

Liang Yue: Please show us your ID so that the doctor can give you treatment.

For a few stiff seconds, the girl's mechanical head freezes in place. Then, in a movement almost too fast to follow, it snaps up.

???: Look. A hamster riding a stethoscope.

Liang Yue: A hamster what?

The bizarreness of these words leaves Liáng no choice but to glance in the pointed direction, only to confirm, of course, that there is no hamster nor stethoscope in sight.

???: Now!

Liang Yue: Hey, wait!

Voices on the Street

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

> It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.
>
> And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

> Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Street Interviews

Last night, the Nightpiercer struck again, attacking the convoy transporting the infamous Johnny Three-Times. Two officers were knocked unconscious during the attack; however, Johnny Three-Times was seriously injured and is remains in critical condition.

Insiders say citizens clashed with the convoy earlier that day due to dissatisfaction over Johnny Three-Times's light sentencing. Later that night, the Nightpiercer struck, seemingly enacting vigilante justice on behalf of Johnny Three-Times's victims. Public support for the Nightpiercer has grown since.

And although it's already been a day since the attack, crowds still gather at the scene. We're here to hear what the people on the street have to say.

...

"Serves him right! That scumbag deserves a prickly end!"

...

"I think following the law is important, but honestly, the way Johnny Three-Times got such a light sentencing feels off ..."

...

"Who me? Are you asking me? Oh, sorry, miss, but you haven't happened to see C07, have you?"

"Oh, no reason, I thought this was one of those prank interviews they've been doing lately. Um, how should I put this ... Sorry, but someone in my position isn't really allowed to comment on politics."

Saving Lives

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

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And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

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Shared continuation

Shared continuation

The Laplace Rehab Center Welcomes You!

Welcome to the Laplace Rehabilitation Center!

We are the world's leading hospital specializing in arcanum, whether you are:

· Suffering from arcanum-related injuries.

· Cursed with bad luck after an argument with your neighbor.

· Transforming more and more into a beetle with each passing morning.

· Suddenly recalling your past life as a Pharaoh, causing you great distress at your office job.

The Laplace Rehabilitation Center is committed to giving you the best treatment available!

Don't worry about whether your rare condition is covered by health insurance. To thank you for contributing to medical advancements, we offer discounts and subsidies based on the rarity of your condition. Each rare condition gets you a flat 60% discount! If you're simultaneously bitten by a vampire and a dragon while dissolving into an oil painting, but you're somehow still alive, then that's right—your treatment will be free, AND we'll even pay you 80% of the treatment cost as a bonus!

Thank you for supporting the Laplace Rehabilitation Center, helping you helps us help everyone.

Outsider · 2/2

SC-05

Medical Staff: Watch out!

Liang Yue: Sorry, I'm after a—

The hospital's narrow hallways are hardly suitable for a chase, and Liáng quickly finds her path blocked by a supply cart. By the time she's made it past, the mechanical-headed girl has disappeared.

Her metal chameleon communication device, issued by the Division of Arcane Affairs, gives off its distinctive chime.

Poitier: Hey, rookie. Where did you go? Get back here. The medical report is ready, and Mr. Wong's family just arrived.

Liang Yue: I ... Understood. How's Mr. Wong doing?

There's a long pause on the other end of the line.

Poitier: It's not pretty.

Ward

Enraged Man: ...

Mr. Wong is lying unconscious on the hospital bed, looking haggard. His breathing is labored and raspy, like wind rattling through a hollowed-out log.

Woman: How ... What happened to him? He seems completely normal this morning.

Her legs go weak. Were it not for the man supporting her, she might have collapsed entirely.

???: Please relax, Ms. Wong. We have to wait and see what the doctor says.

Poitier: You again?

Poitier instantly recognizes him—one of the Division of Arcane Affairs's least welcome and regular visitors.

Poitier: Right, right. You're the local arcane private eye, aren't you, Zhōu? Are you commissioned by the victim?

Private Investigator: What?

The man's eyes widen in surprise before shooting Poitier a venomous glare.

Private Investigator: Ha. Unlike some tax leeches out there, I actually help people in need.

Private Investigator: And I don't charge a fee when it comes to my neighbors.

Poitier: Sorry.

He clearly has no interest in arguing at a time like this. He lets out a cold snort and turns to the doctor with a questioning look.

ER Doctor: Ms. Liáng has cleared the unknown arcane skill that was afflicting him. His physical condition is stable, but I fear there may be some long-term effects on his mind.

ER Doctor: He seems to be suffering from a severe thought and memory disorder. It would be best to keep him asleep.

Woman: Doctor, when will he wake up? Can I speak to him?

ER Doctor: For now, we suggest against it. It may cause him additional distress to see someone familiar to him. We fear there might be memory loss.

Woman: What? How?

Woman: What should I do now? With his mother gone, I can't take any more of this.

Liang Yue: Madam ...

The woman looks as though all the strength has been drained from her body as she slumps into a nearby chair. Liáng opens her mouth to offer comfort but can't seem to find the right words.

Zhōu's gaze sweeps past Poitier before settling on Liáng.

Private Investigator: So, who's the little Chinese kid? Did the DAA give you a sidekick to do your job for you?

Private Investigator: Forget it lah. Listen, if you're not going to do your best to help these people, then it's better you just stay out of my way.

Liang Yue: ...

Liáng looks to Poitier with a questioning gaze. Poitier shakes her head and sighs, gesturing for her to come closer before handing over the hospital's diagnosis.

Poitier: When they first brought him in, there were remnants of the arcanum riddled through his body. It might have gone a long way to proving he wasn't in control of himself.

Poitier: But I guess anything definitive has already faded away. The doctors couldn't isolate a cause.

Poitier: Worse-case scenario, they might not believe us and have this poor guy shoved off to the funny farm.

Liáng clenches her fists and looks toward the woman curled up in the hospital chair, quietly sobbing. She looks so small against the oversized seat.

Finally, Liáng steps forward and crouches beside the chair.

After a brief hesitation, she reaches out and places a hand over the woman's. Zhōu looks surprised.

Liang Yue: Madam, please, you need to stay strong for your husband.

Liang Yue: They've brought in some of the best doctors from the Laplace Rehab Center. If there is anyone that can help him, it'll be them.

In a way, it is a promise with no real guarantee—a statement that could almost be considered a lie. But even lies have value when a person needs to hear them.

The woman hastily wipes her tear-streaked face and lifts her head.

Woman: He said that he was going to buy produce from the wholesalers, but I couldn't reach him. And then, the police called.

Woman: My husband is a good man. Everyone knows that. He would never do something like this.

Woman: Please, Miss, you have to help us.

Liang Yue: ...!

The woman grasps Liáng's hand tightly in hers, her fingers trembling.

Her hands are gentle, yet rough, etched with years of hard work—the kind of hands earned through long days and nights of striving for a better life.

Liang Yue: I ...

In her palm, she can feel the woman's desperate, burning warmth. It is so hot. She feels it could scorch her.

Liáng takes a deep breath.

Liang Yue: You can rely on us, ma'am.

Liang Yue: We'll find out the truth behind this. I promise you.

She gives the woman's hand a firm, reassuring squeeze.

Woman: Thank you. Thank you so much!

Woman: You are our only hope, please!

Sometimes, a lie can become the truth. All it takes is someone willing to make it so.

Private Investigator: ...

The door to the ward is shut behind them. After a moment of silence, Poitier tilts her head.

Poitier: Rookie mistake, princess. Never make a promise about something you don't get to decide on.

Liang Yue: I'm sorry, Ms. Poitier. But I only meant—

Poitier: Hold it.

Poitier: I didn't say we weren't gonna do our best.

Liang Yue: ...

The words she was about to say no longer serve any purpose. Instead, Liáng does something Poitier has never seen her do before. She smiles.

Liang Yue: Thank you, ma'am.

Poitier: Not so fast. We still need some solid evidence if we're gonna crack this case.

Liang Yue: But where to begin? It seems like there are no obvious clues beyond what we've seen. Mr. Wong had no enemies and was well-loved in his community.

Liang Yue: If that's the case, then it can't be a simple motivation. Still, something sticks out to me. When I asked about any recent events or happenings, it wasn't Mrs. Wong that answered. It was ...

Poitier already knows where this is going.

Poitier: Zhōu. Our private eye with a chip on his shoulder against the DAA.

Liang Yue: Yes. He mentioned that there have been strange things going on around L.A.'s Chinatown recently.

Liang Yue: According to my notes, he mentioned there were children that suddenly became distant and unresponsive, young men that began showing signs of memory loss, and an otherwise healthy elder that rapidly developed signs of dementia.

Liang Yue: Absent-mindedness, empty despondence towards family and friends, memory loss. It all sounds very familiar to Mr. Wong's condition. But no one thought to bring the matter to the police.

Liang Yue: I also spoke with the nurses here. They said they've also noticed an increase in patients from Chinatown, complaining of confusion and memory loss.

Liang Yue: I guess, once again, no one thought it was serious enough for our attention.

Poitier's expression darkens.

Poitier: Well, whatcha thinking, cadet? Are all these cases related?

Poitier: If it's as widespread as you're making it out to be, we might be in over our heads.

Liang Yue: Even so, I think we can't overlook it as a possibility.

Liang Yue: Arcane skills that directly affect the mind are rare, but they do exist. I've read of similar cases in the Vigiles Archive.

Liang Yue: One of them, as I recall, had very similar symptoms to what we're seeing here.

Liáng's brow furrows.

Liang Yue: However, if there were some criminal intention behind all of these symptoms, what could it be?

Liang Yue: Or could it be an accident? Maybe a child with a powerful arcane skill who can't control it? Or some unregulated and dangerous arcane objects?

Liang Yue: We can't draw any conclusions without more evidence.

The two officers look troubled. Then, as if something has clicked in her mind, Poitier's face lights up.

Poitier: Arcane objects ... Isn't there a department in the Foundation that stores and records dangerous arcane materials?

Liang Yue: Yes, at the headquarters of the Foundation. And its official name is ...

Liang Yue: The Arcanum Containment Department.

Matilda: Ah. Voilà. I believe I am here.

Matilda: Hmm, it is much brighter and more spacious than I expected.

Secret Warrant

SC-06

Matilda: Cabinets, cabinets, and more cabinets.

Matilda: Who is in charge here? I was under the impression this was an important department, no? Where is the security?

The ever-curious Matilda weaves her way through the rows of filing cabinets. She has read about this department in books detailing the Foundation's history.

Matilda: "The department contains all known objects which have produced dangerous or mysterious arcane phenomenon."

Matilda: Some even say it contains "Every arcane mystery—solved and unsolved—that has ever been recorded."

Matilda: But of course, the biggest mystery of all time, the "Storm," still defies them.

Matilda: As it does for us all. It seems, with every department turned to the study of the "Storm," there is little time to spare for these more trivial puzzles.

Her footsteps echo through the empty department, and the odd sense that she's being watched settles over her.

Silence can be comforting, but it can also be unsettling—a breeding ground for loneliness, dredging up long-buried unease.

Matilda: ...

Matilda: I wonder how Mama is doing. Madam Z said she would keep an eye on her, but still no updates.

She finds herself pausing, her gaze lowering to the ground.

But only for a moment.

Matilda: No, bring yourself together, Matilda Bouanich. This is your mama, the greatest mother of all time. What could possibly have gone wrong?

With renewed confidence, she picks up her pace, her pale ponytail bouncing behind her.

Matilda: Now her most outstanding daughter runs an important errand for the Foundation, unlike some others who have dedicated their valuable time to a vacation in the name of "reviving the Uluru Games."

Matilda: Still, one must hope they will succeed in making the games as grand and sublime as they say they were in the distant past, or else ...

Matilda: Hmm?

Just as she passes another set of shelves, something catches her eye.

???: Everything's fine here. Now, on to the next row.

???: Oh. This is one of my favorites.

Matilda: What is it?

???: An excellent question, Miss. See that serial number on it?

???: AN-003, a water sample from the Pèilín River. Number 003.

???: There are hundreds of thousands of samples, collections, and records here, but no matter who you ask, this particular one will always make their top list.

???: Collected in a remote city in China. When the investigators arrived, they found that it had been isolated in time. All its inhabitants dressed and lived as if they were from the late Táng Dynasty.

???: They were completely unaware of the state of the world beyond their lands, as if trapped in a time capsule from the forgotten past.

Matilda: Oh ...

The liquid inside the vial is clear and pristine—less like river water and more like a perfectly liquefied gemstone. Matilda can't help but stare in fascination.

Matilda: But how is that possible? Did no one ever leave the city? Not even to travel or do business?

???: You're a clever one, Miss. Yes, it seems the investigators were confused, too. In the end, they realized that an arcane skill was affecting the Pèilín River.

???: Sadly, it seems the arcane energy was dissipating by the time they arrived, and they weren't able to figure out its cause.

???: This is the only sample they were able to recover. Laplace has been begging for access to it. They're eager to unravel the mystery.

Matilda: Wow. That is indeed a most intriguing claim.

???: It's not just a claim, Miss. It's real. Wait.

???: Ms. Matilda Bouanich?

The careless young staff member only now seems to have fully recognized Matilda's presence.

Matilda: You've heard of me?

???: Yeah, of course. Who hasn't heard of the Bouaniches and their star investigator daughter. Didn't you know that everyone's been talking about you since you joined the Foundation?

???: Actually, my mother and I went to visit you. Oh. But I haven't introduced myself.

Scott: Constance Scott, I'm a fellow graduate from SPDM.

Scott: Of course, now, I'm just a record keeper here.

It doesn't seem like false modesty. Every top student of the SPDM was granted the honor of having their name inscribed in the school's hall of fame, but Matilda has never once come across the name Scott.

Matilda: Actually, I've been looking for you as well, Ms. Scott. Commissioner Pedra asked me to give this to you.

Scott: A letter? What's it about?

Matilda: I couldn't say. But he had a most unpleasant look about him as he gave it to me. Then he asked me to review my report on the events in San Francisco.

Matilda: Are you alright? Your face has grown quite pale.

Scott: I'm fine. I just have a bad feeling I know what I'm about to read.

Having bid farewell to Matilda, Scott makes her way to a secluded room within the department, the letter clutched in her hand.

She carefully closes the door behind her, and, with one last glance around the room, opens the envelope. A single sheet of paper floats out from within, one carrying a heavy message.

Pedra: The investigation has been concluded. Unfortunately, their findings were exactly as we feared.

Pedra: The suspect must be apprehended ASAP, and all efforts must be made to retrieve this arcane object before either cause further trouble.

Pedra: You must leave immediately. Her last reported sighting was in Chinatown, Los Angeles.

Chinatown Street, Day

Vendor: Oranges! Fresh oranges!

Tourist: Sorry, could you say that again? Zhǐ Mǎ Wǔ? And that means paper horse dance? Okay. I got it.

Chinatown Resident: Hey, shopkeeper! Got any Siu Yuk left? No? Then give me a piece of Char Siu and some Bak Chit Gai, please.

Child: Wow! Daddy, look! There's a dragon on the floor. That's totally cool!

People speaking many languages meet and weave around each other on the crowded avenue. Liáng wanders among them, stopping every now and then to take it all in.

Poitier: Welcome to Chinatown. How do you like it?

Liang Yue: Yes. It does give me a certain sense of nostalgia. Do you come here often, Ms. Poitier?

Poitier: Yeah, I guess so. I mean, outside of work, it's been a while. Three years or so.

Liang Yue: Only once in three years? I don't think you can consider that "often."

Poitier waves a hand, glancing down the lively streets on either side.

Poitier: Yeah, well, it's a fun place for a day trip, sure, but things are different when you put on the uniform.

Poitier: Remember that private eye back at the hospital, Zhōu? You can get an impression about how people see the police around here from him.

Liang Yue: You mean that the residents here don't cooperate with the Arcane Affairs division?

Poitier: Well, it's complicated. There's a lot of language and cultural barriers. Folks here just don't turn to the police to solve their problems. Even when they do, we feel like we have no idea where to start.

Poitier: The thing that surprised me the most was how arcanists of all kinds and humans live so closely together here. I guess it's the same in China, isn't it?

Poitier: I remember this one time, we had a call about a break-in. When we got there, it turned out the shopkeeper was a big white bird as tall as I am.

Poitier: And this other time, we're chasing down a lost puppet for some lame-ass puppeteer. Anyways, so I ask an old lady if she'd seen a doll nearby. You know what she said?

Poitier: Well, I don't know what she said, but she started going off about me being a Lǎowài.

Poitier: Now, give me some credit. I might not speak Chinese, but I do know Lǎowài means foreigner. So, excuse me? Like I'm American, baby—born and raised.

Liang Yue: Heh heh. Sorry.

Liáng knows she should remain serious, but she can't help but be tickled by Poitier's indignation.

Poitier shoots her a glare, but then heaves a quiet sigh.

Poitier: That's not even the half of it.

Poitier: The thing is, I don't hate it here, although I can't say I love Chinatown very much either. To be honest, most of us on the force haven't found a way to make inroads with the people here.

Liang Yue: If that's the problem, why don't we try to understand things step by step? Maybe then we can start fresh? We're here anyway.

Liáng turns back and examines the archway at the beginning of the road. They have already been in this "other world" for a while.

Poitier: Yeah, it's worth a shot.

Poitier: If we're gonna get anywhere, then we'll have to start here.

Poitier: But we need to check another task off our list first.

Chinatown Alley, Day

They cross the street and turn into a narrow alleyway.

Poitier: Should be right there, down the alley. Feeling excited, rookie?

Poitier: We're about to pay a visit to your favorite director, Noire.

Liang Yue: Favorite? What? No. I just like the movies, that's all. I've got no specific feelings for the director.

Liáng can't hold back her rebuttal, but under Poitier's teasing gaze, she stops herself.

Liang Yue: Maybe just a little. I am curious about the mind of the director behind such great movies.

Liang Yue: But this is strictly a police matter, so I will act with professional self-restraint.

Liang Yue: Actually, I've made a request with the Vigiles Intelligence branch for a file on Director Noire and any related events. We should get it soon.

Poitier: You've got a file on her already? Feels like you're going a bit overboard, rookie.

Poitier: It wasn't actually the director that called us. Her assistant did. Later on, Noire herself contacted us and said the so-called threat was just a misunderstanding.

Poitier: Normally, we'd leave it at that. There's too much real crime out there to bother with a case where the victim doesn't think anything happened.

Poitier: Still, according to Dispatch, the assistant was real spooked over it. The operator got the feeling we should give it a second look, so they kept the file open.

Poitier: But look, this is just a follow-up and an excuse to come down here. So, keep your mind on the real mission.

Liang Yue: Got it, ma'am.

The scene from the Division of Arcane Affairs yesterday flashes across Liáng's mind.

After leaving the hospital, they immediately returned to report their findings and highlight the dangers lurking behind Chinatown's strange events.

But the higher-ups had a different take on things.

Poitier: It's been reassigned to the local precinct.

Poitier stands in the doorway to the Deputy Chief's Office and shakes her head. Liáng immediately catches the subtle shift in her expression.

Liang Yue: What's wrong? What does that mean?

Poitier: Nothing, kid. It's just most of the force aren't trained to deal with arcane crimes. Don't get me wrong. They're good, capable officers, but I'm worried.

Poitier: If this was any other case, I'd keep my mouth shut, but come on, this is clearly our department. This case has arcanum all over it.

Poitier: I don't think they know what they're getting into.

Liang Yue: ...

For a brief moment, neither speaks. Then, Liáng's eyes light up.

Liang Yue: Ms. Poitier, I have an idea. What if we ...

Poitier: We prioritize Noire's case, which just happens to put us in Chinatown. So, there's no harm in asking a few questions about our other investigation.

Poitier: I knew there was a little rebel in you, Liáng. You like to bend the rules, just not break 'em, am I right?

Liang Yue: Um, not too often.

Liang Yue: Actually, I think we're obliged to take Ms. Noire's case seriously, even if it wouldn't help us with the other case.

Liang Yue: Please wait a minute. It's my communication device.

Liáng pulls out the communication device often criticized by Foundation employees for being too bulky. Poitier leans in to get a better look. Her chameleon comm perched on her chest stretches its neck in curiosity.

Notification: SPF-I Portable Contact Device activated. You've received a new message. Downloading attachment.

Notification: Download complete. Please check your mailbox.

Poitier: Message? What's it about?

Liang Yue: It's from the Intelligence Department. They've found her records.

Liang Yue: Ms. Noire is registered with the Foundation. There might be something in her files that can provide us some clues.

She opens the pinned email and scans through the attached files. Her expression turns serious.

Liang Yue: Wait. Is this ...

Pieced Together

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.

And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Reconstructing Idealized Memories

Although I don't usually keep a journal, I had to record today's encounter—I met the great Miss Matilda Bouanich!

I still remember that summer. My mother lectured me for an hour before we left and then another hour during our journey. I thought I was following her instructions perfectly: I was dressed perfectly neat; my greetings were memorized word-for-word. But the moment I met the Bouanichs, I froze solid, too nervous to say anything. Even adults can get stage fright, so how was it fair to give her own daughter the cold shoulder for it? A smile or a pat on the back from mother was all I needed to finish my greeting without fumbling.

Thank goodness for Lady Beryl. She saw what happened, and her gracious words salvaged the situation. I didn't disappoint my mother after that. I'm sure of it because the rest of my memories of that visit were pleasant—Lady Beryl's warm smile and Matilda's energetic chatter. Matilda could be as noisy as she liked and still win her mother's approval, how I envied that so much.

But Lady Beryl ... for some reason, I can't remember what she looked like. Now I understand Latham's frustration. Being Matilda's mother, I could imagine a matured, refined version of Matilda—minus the childish energy and, oh right, without the hooked nose, that's my mother's trait.

Rookie Actor's Guide

SC-07

Noire's Set

Crew Member: Whose is this? It's blocking the camera's sightlines. Get it out of the way!

Extra: When are we coming in? We've been waiting forever. I wish I brought a chair.

Crowd: What's going on? Are they filming another movie? Do you see anyone famous?

At the end of the alley, in an old abandoned house filled with camera equipment, crew members and actors go about their business, drawing curious glances from passersby.

One particular figure catches Liáng's attention—someone strangely familiar.

???: Oh! Is that today's lunch? Mind if I take a look?

???: Not now? Fine.

Liang Yue: That's that odd person I saw at the hospital. She works for the Foundation.

Poitier: Who? You mean camera-head over there? What do you mean by odd? You think she could be a fake?

Liang Yue: No, she's a real Foundation member. I checked her information as well when I inquired about Ms. Noire's file.

Liang Yue: Her name is Latham, an Awakened arcanist, currently working in the Arcanum Containment Department.

Liang Yue: I wasn't given any access to her details. But based on our encounter, we should have no problem with her.

Poitier: Good, fine. I'm happy enough leaving the Awakened to their quirkiness.

She isn't their top priority—Liáng knows that. She pushes aside that odd feeling for now, following Poitier through the crowd and onto the set.

Assistant: What do you mean she hasn't eaten yet? Director Noire's doctor was explicit that she is not allowed to skip any meals.

Assistant: Oh, hello, officers. How can I help you?

The well-dressed woman walks over to them.

Poitier: We received a call from a Lin Wang. Did you make a report about some unknown person making physical threats and stalking Ms. Noire?

Assistant: Yes. That's right. I'm Lin, but ...

Upon hearing their purpose, Lin hesitates, glancing uncertainly over at one end of the set.

Actor I: We did it!

Actor II: Abby?! You're here!

Noire: Cut.

At this single command, the actors freeze in place.

Noire: No. I'm afraid we'll have to roll that again.

Actor II: I-I'm sorry, director.

The young actor's body stiffens instantly. Based on where he's standing, it's clear that he is only a background character in this scene.

But Noire, seated on her throne-like wheelchair—the overseer of everything—didn't miss his mistake, no matter how minor it was.

Noire: Not at all. I just want more emotion this time. She's your true love, but you have been apart for a long time. Things are different now. She is, you are.

Noire: Your reunion must be more complex. It isn't simply happiness you feel. You must mix that emotion with worry and guilt.

Noire: She doesn't know anything about what happened to you. You can't help but worry that she will never be able to understand you. You wonder if she has got herself into any troubles.

Noire: I know this is a short scene, but the audience must see your full range of emotions. You are capable of more, so be more.

Noire: I know you attended drama school, so let's see that training shine. I know you can do it.

Actor II: Yes, director. I'll try my best.

Simply being noticed by the famous director is enough to leave him visibly flustered. He immediately straightens up, shedding his nervous stance from moments before.

Noire: Good. Let's roll it again.

Assistant: Ahem, excuse me, Director Noire?

Seizing this moment before the next take, the assistant swoops in and whispers something to Noire.

Noire: ...

Noire glances toward the two officers, her face betraying no emotion. It's impossible to tell what she's thinking.

Poitier: Huh, for someone that famous, you'd think I'd have known she uses a wheelchair.

Poitier: How you feeling? Finally getting a chance to meet your favorite director. Thrilled?

Poitier nudges Liáng with her elbow, tilting forward a little as she teases her. But when she sees Liáng's face, she pauses.

Poitier: What's with the long face, kid? Where'd all your excitement go?

Poitier: Oh. Is it about the message you got?

Liang Yue: Yes. It's just something that's bothering me.

Before Liáng can explain, the subject of their discussion rolls toward them in her wheelchair.

Noire: Thanks for coming, officers. But I believe I've already explained that this was all just a misunderstanding.

Noire: As you can see, I'm in perfect health, well, ignoring these two.

She pats her legs with a cheerful laugh. It seems the director has no qualms about her physical condition, though it's hardly the kind of joke anyone else can comfortably laugh along to.

Poitier: But according to your assistant, there's been someone stalking you for months, and they've recently sent you a threatening letter.

Poitier: So what—that all just "misunderstandings" too?

Noire: I'm terribly sorry for inconveniencing you, officers. Lin is a very dedicated assistant, always looking out for me. She may have just overreacted to my situation.

Noire: I don't mean to brag, but I've been in the limelight for long enough that I've seen my share of crazy fans.

Noire: I'm used to it.

Poitier: Sure, I get that. But about that letter you received, do you still have it?

Noire lets out a wry chuckle and shakes her head.

Noire: I'm afraid I don't have it anymore.

Noire: I receive so many letters, most of them friendly, some of them not-so-much friendly.

Noire: I've made a name in this industry, and a few enemies too. If I paid any attention to the negativity, it'd only drag me down. I tend not to keep the bad ones around.

Noire: While I'm sure you would do a fine job keeping me safe, officers, I can't let myself worry over it. Besides, what are they going to do? Break my kneecaps?

Noire: Frankly, the only thing I am worried about is that your presence is another distraction for my crew.

She casts a grateful, and perhaps apologetic, look around the set.

Noire: So, it's very much appreciated that you went out of your way to check in on me, but I have a movie to make. I can't disappoint my fans.

Noire: Now, if you'll excuse me, we're burning daylight, and I still have four more scenes to film.

Noire: These Hollywood producers may have opened doors for me, but they also give me so many problems lately.

She smiles at the officers, as if to signal the conversation's end.

Liang Yue: Is this really just because of your movie?

Noire has already begun to turn her wheelchair away, but Liáng stops her in her tracks.

Noire: Pardon me?

Liang Yue: You seem to be refusing our assistance because you've decided this threat is only a harmless prank.

Liang Yue: You've decided that it's worth the risk to focus on your film.

Liang Yue: I don't mean to judge your decision. It may be understandable in some cases.

She moves closer, lowering her voice as she leans in to deliver the next sentence in a hushed voice.

Liang Yue: But if this threat is not just a prank, if it is serious ...

Noire: Am I sensing disapproval?

Noire narrows her eyes a little and raises a hand to halt her approaching assistant.

This is a good sign. Liáng has earned the chance to talk for at least a little longer. She pushes aside her conflicting emotions and carries on in a voice only the two of them can hear.

Liang Yue: There has been an increase in patients coming from Chinatown showing signs of mental instability.

Liang Yue: Their symptoms include confusion, amnesia, drowsiness, and volatile anger. None of the patients seem to have anything in common. No prior history, all without clear cause.

Liang Yue: Does that sound familiar?

Noire: Sorry, is this leading somewhere?

After a moment of thought, Noire shakes her head, her calm face carrying a perfectly measured hint of confusion.

Liang Yue: A case, eight years ago.

Liang Yue: Hé Rìjūn, the scriptwriter for your first big hit, Detective Co7. She burned to death in her own house.

Liang Yue: However, the cleaners found a film reel in the debris, surprisingly intact after the fire.

Noire: ...

Liáng has been watching Noire's every expression. She doesn't miss the fleeting shift in her eyes at the mention of the film reel.

Liang Yue: Strange, isn't it? Every other item was burned to ash, yet this one 8mm reel was as good as new.

Liang Yue: The cleaners felt the same way, so, being curious, they played the reel.

Liang Yue: Three of the five who watched it ended up in an asylum, one jumped from a building, and the last, according to the reports, became like an empty shell of a person.

Noire: And what's happening here reminds you of that?

Liang Yue: There are some commonalities between the cases. I can't ignore the possibility that they're related.

Liang Yue: Two in particular stand out to me, the similar symptoms of those affected, and you.

Liang Yue: Hard to shake the thought that these are not coincidences.

Whispers spark among the crew as they eye this secret conversation.

Extra: What are the police still here for? Are we gonna get back to filming?

Crew Member: Who knows, but it doesn't seem good. We're losing light here. Can these guys wrap it up already?

These murmurs, of course, don't escape Noire's and Liáng's notice. When she speaks again, Noire's tone is far more direct.

Noire: Is that an accusation?

Liang Yue: No, not at all. I'm just hoping you might be able to shed some light on our case.

Liang Yue: After our initial investigation, we officially recorded it as an ominous arcanum incident, and determined that the cause was that 8mm film reel, which contained a film titled Reunion of the Three Swallows.

Liang Yue: To this day, however, the exact nature of the arcanum hasn't been conclusively determined. We still aren't sure why it has this strange effect on people's minds, nor why the damage appears to be irreversible.

Liang Yue: Perhaps more importantly, we still don't know the origin behind the arcanum on the reel. There are many possible causes that might create such an effect.

Liang Yue: One of the most common thoughts is from absorbing powerful emotions from an arcanist.

Liang Yue: The darkest emotions possess the strongest power, anger, hatred ...

Liang Yue: Emotions so strong that they can outlast their bearer's death, like a curse from beyond the grave carrying out their last will as an obsession.

Liang Yue: And in such cases, these objects are sure to lead to disaster.

Liang Yue: I believe that this film is, undoubtedly, one such cursed item.

Liang Yue: If it is the case that this film was involved in these new incidents, then we must find out what obsession it's carrying out, and find a countermeasure.

Noire: I assume you're already on the case.

Liang Yue: Indeed, I am, Ms. Noire. I've been studying the report on the original case, including some of the theories of the original investigator.

Liang Yue: One of those theories suggests that despite your collaboration on the C07 series, there were many points of conflict between you and Ms. Hé.

Liang Yue: In fact, the reports mention you had a violent quarrel with her on the day of the fire. There was even a question about whether you might have been responsible for her death.

Liang Yue: So, as you can see, I have more than a strong reason to believe you are connected. And if this cursed reel is behind these recent incidents ...

Liang Yue: I'm afraid that you may be the intended target of this curse.

Post-lunch Questioning · 1/2

SC-08

Guangfu Restaurant

Poitier: Hot damn, rookie. Who coulda guessed the famous director would be a part of her own real-life thriller.

Poitier: After talking to her, we still got nothing useful to go on. I can't read anything behind that smiling face of hers.

Poitier: But if your little theory has got any truth to it, then Noire is in real danger. So, why not talk? Isn't she worried about her own life?

Poitier channels her frustration into her food, devouring most of the meal in the blink of an eye. As she swallows the last shrimp dumpling, she turns to look at Liáng, who is busy chatting with the restaurant owner.

Liang Yue: You mean the grocer's daughter has also ...

Female Storekeeper: Yes. So many, many things happening around the neighborhood. Crazy!

Female Storekeeper: But the Lu's are lucky. They took their daughter to a good local doctor, and she got better.

Female Storekeeper: But the other family down the road aren't so lucky. Their grandma was already so weak from arthritis, and now she's gone crazy. She's probably gonna drive them crazy too.

Female Storekeeper: You know what? Another girl, she asked around about this too. *sigh* If I had to guess, it's because of those evil spirits. Things are never easy before the Dùshuò Festival.

Liang Yue: Another girl? Do you know who she is?

Female Storekeeper: She said she's an exorcist from the neo-science ... neo-science something ... exorcism office ... and is new here in Chinatown.

Female Storekeeper: She gave me a fancy business card. But I don't know where it is now.

Liang Yue: I see. Thank you very much.

As Liáng returns to her seat, Poitier shoots her a questioning look.

Poitier: So, any progress?

Liang Yue: I have some bad news. First, there are more victims than we expected; second, we're not the only ones who've noticed.

Liang Yue: We need to hurry if we don't want this case to attract wider attention.

Poitier: Why don't we start with the director, then? She seems like our best lead.

Having cleared the dishes closest to her, Poitier pulls the char siu buns from the other side of the table.

Poitier: I've got a hunch her case is connected with this one.

Poitier: Just like you said, there are too many coincidences to not dig deeper.

Poitier: That writer, what was it, Hé Rìjūn? She's an arcanist, right? No surprise that she'd imbue that film with all of her final bits of hatred. I've seen a dozen cases like it.

Poitier: Cursed objects are weird as heck. It's definitely possible that it could've chased Noire all the way here.

Liang Yue: But there isn't any evidence that corroborates the rivalry between Ms. Noire and Ms. Hé.

Poitier: Hold on. Didn't you read that in a report by another vigil? Maybe it's only hearsay, but that's something.

Poitier: Not only that. Get this—I did some digging of my own. The night that cleaner leaped off that roof was the exact same night that Noire was in the car accident that left her legs paralyzed.

Poitier: It gets freakier. According to the reports, they happened within minutes of each other, and the building was less than a block away from the scene of the accident. How's that for evidence?

Poitier: We've got a saying in the DAA, cadet. "When it comes to arcanum, there's no such thing as coincidences."

With this declaration, Poitier pops the last char siu bun into her mouth.

Liang Yue: Whether coincidence or not, it isn't much to go on. We need evidence.

Poitier: Of course. We can't just leap to accusations without proof. But when it comes to arcane crime, you've gotta follow your hunches. So, keep your nose to the ground.

Poitier notices the dejection on Liáng's face and sheepishly sets down her chopsticks.

Poitier: I get you. This isn't just about evidence. You don't wanna point the finger at someone you admire.

Poitier: But you've gotta pursue this, even if that means you have to separate the artist from their work.

Liáng remains silent for a moment, picks up the chilled lemon soda from the table, and takes a sip.

Liang Yue: Actually, there is another reason that I'm not entirely convinced that Ms. Noire, the "film incident," and the events in Chinatown are connected.

Liang Yue: In fact, it's quite a substantial reason. If our records are correct, the cursed reel was found and contained by the Foundation six months after the initial incident.

Liang Yue: Which means, unless something has gone horribly wrong, it should still be safely stored within the Arcanum Containment Depart—

A sharp crash interrupts her words. The two turn toward the sound.

Scott: Oops! I'm sorry. I'm so sorry.

A bespectacled girl fumbles with a napkin as she hurriedly tries to clean up the shattered dish she just knocked over.

But her sneaking glances toward the two officers don't escape their attention, and the shiny emblem on her chest tells them exactly where she's from.

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: Well ...

They exchange a puzzled look.

Poitier: If I remember it right, you mentioned earlier that you saw someone from the Foundation acting suspicious yesterday.

Liang Yue: Yes, like the lady over there, she also works for the ACD.

Poitier: Guess we'll have a talk with her.

Liang Yue: I agree, Ms. Poitier.

They rise from the table and approach the girl.

Confidential Record

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.

And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Investigation Record: Noire

Noire, female, arcanist. Her arcane skill allows her to manipulate inanimate objects within a defined range, designating them as "actors."

Born in Hong Kong, in 1950.

Graduated from USC School of Cinematic Arts in 1972. Later worked at what would eventually become known as TVB.

In 1978, she began collaborating with independent production companies to produce low-budget films.

Released her debut film, Muddle, in 1979.

Established New Art Company in 1980 and began working on the film Detective C07.

In 1983, a car accident left her paralyzed from the waist down, allegedly tied to the Film Incident1.

...

1 For more details on the "Film Incident," please refer to the attached documentation.

Post-lunch Questioning · 2/2

SC-08

Under Liáng and Poitier's relentless questioning, the suspicious Foundation member ultimately surrenders.

Scott: Alright, alright. I'll tell.

Scott: But only to you, since you're a vigil, but she isn't, right? Sorry, I should really only disclose this info to other Foundation members.

She shoots a cautious glance at Poitier.

Poitier: Hmph.

Poitier says nothing, simply raising her chin at Liáng in approval.

Liáng follows the girl out into the empty alley. After verifying Liáng's identity with her communication device, the girl gives a final glance up and down the alley before talking.

Scott: There's no one I would trust more than a vigil, Ms. Liáng.

Scott: I'm here on a mission for the Foundation, and you might be able to help me with it.

Pedra: September 1990, a female arcanist committed a serious assault and caused a number of casualties. She appeared at an illegal gathering held by the Order of Enlightenment, a subordinate organization of Manus Vindictae.

Pedra: The Timekeeper encountered her and confirmed her identity: Anjo Nala, a Beyond arcanist.

Pedra: Born sometime in the 19th century, she was sealed inside a wind-up toy in the year 1968. Since then, she has become a lethal weapon that must obey whoever possesses her toy.

Pedra: But back in 1985, I mean, the real 1985 ...

Pedra: That toy had been safely stored in our Arcanum Containment Department as a "dangerous item."

Scott: Until it was stolen.

Pedra: You were involved in that particular inventory check. There are four additional items that are now lost aside from No. 066.

Pedra: The circumstances of the last "Storm" and that devastating "spell" threw our whole organization into chaos. However, there's no excuse for failing to uphold our department's most crucial mission.

Pedra: Fortunately, it appears that our "break-in" was committed by a single culprit.

Scott: I heard what you and your partner just said. It's about all the weird things happening in Chinatown, right?

Scott: It was my mission to catch Latham and retrieve all the arcane objects she'd stolen before they caused more damage.

Scott: But I guess it's already too late for that.

The meaning behind these words is crystal clear. There is no room for Liáng to feign ignorance.

Liang Yue: Then you're saying that ...

Scott: Yes, the cursed reel from the incident you mentioned was among the stolen items. And you said that you have some clue about its current whereabouts?

The cursed film reel, Reunion of the Three Swallows, is in Chinatown—The weight of this revelation sinks heavily in Liáng's chest.

Scott: I was told to operate under strict secrecy, but at this point, the faster they're retrieved, the better. So, shall we work together?

Scott takes a notebook from her pocket and pulls out a photo tucked inside.

Scott: Our main suspect is Latham, an Awakened arcanist.

Liáng can't help but look surprised when she recognizes the other girl in the photograph.

But Scott seems to misinterpret her reaction.

Scott: It's hard for me to believe she'd do this. We were colleagues and close friends. I used to call her Loggerhead, because she's the most forgetful person I know.

Scott: At first, I refused to believe she could do such a thing. I still don't understand why. She's not the kind to be greedy.

Scott: But the Vigiles investigated the theft thoroughly, and the Vigiles are not the kind to make mistakes.

Scott: You've been here a few days already, right? Have you had any word about where she might be?

Scott's brow furrows, her expression torn between hope and fear. It's as if she wants confirmation while equally dreading to hear the truth.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: Sorry, I haven't.

She shakes her head.

Scott's expression visibly relaxes.

Scott: Oh. What a pity.

A Name Deserved

SC-09

Female Storekeeper: Have a good day!

Before the owner can even say goodbye, Liáng has yanked Poitier out the front door.

Poitier: What's the rush? I haven't even finished my noodles.

Liang Yue: We can eat later, but we need to find Ms. Latham, now!

Poitier: Wait, wait. Hold on. I'm all for chasing down a crook. But why do I get the feeling you didn't tell your Foundation friend about your run-in with Latham?

Poitier: What's up? Why you keeping her in the dark?

Liang Yue: I think that something isn't right about her.

Liang Yue: I've been to the ACD before. To most, it might seem defenseless, but it's actually heavily protected by arcane rituals.

Liang Yue: According to Ms. Scott, Latham acted alone.

Liang Yue: But there's nothing in her file that would suggest she's capable of that. Her arcane skill level is frankly far from remarkable.

Liang Yue: Even with insider knowledge, I don't believe it's possible she could have bypassed the security system and escaped on her own.

Liang Yue: Either Ms. Latham has playing the Foundation for fools, or she has more powerful accomplices. That leads me to another thing. This mission is not something a typical Foundation staff member would be assigned to—as Ms. Scott claimed to be.

Liang Yue: There's something we don't know.

Poitier: You're saying that girl with glasses lied to you?

Liang Yue: Maybe, or that she was being lied to herself.

Liáng pulls her SPF-I contact device from beneath her cloak. After a few simple taps, she turns it around for Poitier to see.

Liang Yue: There was another thing I found while searching through Ms. Latham's files, or rather, what I didn't find—there were no warnings or notices on her employee records.

Poitier: You mean, she's not actually wanted?

Liang Yue: No, I don't think so.

Liang Yue: Ms. Scott said that their department wanted to solve this problem in secret, so I thought that might explain the reason Ms. Latham's warrant wasn't on her file.

Liang Yue: However, when I tried to access more of their records to double-check my findings, I ran into a block on Ms. Scott's records.

Notification: Access denied. You do not have permission to view this information. If you need access, please contact your supervisor.

A warning symbol flashes on the screen.

Liang Yue: It could just be because I'm only a cadet. There are some files that I don't have access to yet. I contacted my supervisor, but I haven't heard anything back.

Liang Yue: I don't mean to distrust her, but I can't hold anyone above suspicion.

Poitier shifts her gaze from the device's screen back to Liáng.

Poitier: And what about me? You're putting a lot of trust in me, Liáng. Is it really alright that you're telling me all this?

Poitier: A dangerous item stolen from the Foundation and possibly an inside job at that. That's a scandal in the making.

Poitier: You could've just lied to me, make up some kind of story. It's not hard for a smart kid like you.

Liáng gives Poitier a puzzled look.

Liang Yue: Why would I? We're partners, Ms. Poitier. Hiding information from you wouldn't be right. You told me that yourself, didn't you?

Poitier: Me?

Liang Yue: Yes, the first day we were on duty together, you said you "need to know what makes me tick."

Poitier: Hmm, I did, didn't I?

Poitier seems a little dazed. Liáng looks at her, sincerity behind her eyes.

Liang Yue: I've reconsidered it, and you're right.

Liang Yue: During my training as a vigil, our instructor emphasized many times that trusting in our partner was of vital importance.

Liang Yue: And you, Ms. Poitier, have proven to be capable, decisive, and compassionate. I have developed a deep respect for your work.

Liang Yue: We share the same goal: to discover the truth behind the incidents happening in Chinatown. I can't think of any reason why I shouldn't cooperate with you.

Poitier: Alright, alright, alright. Enough. I'm blushing already.

Poitier cuts Liáng off, almost flustered.

Poitier: Damn, girl! I didn't expect my meek little mouse to turn into this.

Liang Yue: This what?

Poitier: Forget it. You've made your point. Now, stop it.

Poitier waves a hand, signaling the conversation's end.

Poitier: But you kinda missed my point. I'm worrying that the Foundation is gonna punish you for leaking classified information. Won't you get in trouble?

Liang Yue: Though I may be a vigil of the Foundation, before that, I am a descendant of the Liáng family. I'm obliged to do all that is necessary to fulfill my destiny.

Liang Yue: And given the circumstances, I think providing all relevant information that might assist us in catching the thief and retrieving these threatening arcane objects is worth bending the rules ... just a little.

Despite her conviction, Liáng can't help but hesitate a little.

Liang Yue: Besides, I'm not under any orders to keep this a secret. So ...

Poitier: Haha. Cheeky, and you say you don't like bending the rules. I see you, boo.

Poitier: And I like it. Come on. Let's work this out together, partner.

Hotel Room

Loggerhead: Which one is my room again? Oh, right, I wrote it down. Let me see. There it is. I almost went too far again.

Loggerhead: Now, the key card. Where did I put it—oh, here.

Loggerhead: Home, sweet home. Oh, I'm exhaust—

The camera-headed girl freezes in place.

Two officers are standing in her sweet home.

Poitier: Latham, right? It's been a while.

Liang Yue: We have some questions for you. Please try to cooperate.

Liáng steps forward and closes the door on her behalf.

When an unsuspecting prey steps into a carefully laid trap, the outcome is already decided.

Loggerhead: Alright. Fine. I'll tell you everything.

Loggerhead: It was me, okay? They said I stole those arcane objects and sold them for money, well, maybe I did—Ouch!

As she speaks, she backs closer and closer to the wall behind her, until she smacks her oversized head into the window ledge.

A particular word in her statement makes Liáng tilt her head.

Liang Yue: What do you mean "maybe"?

Loggerhead: Because, actually, I can't remember it.

Loggerhead: I can't find my memory film for that time, so really, I just don't know.

Liang Yue: Memory film?

This so-called Loggerhead girl, an Awakened, isn't exactly a tough one. Within thirty minutes, she has spilled everything.

Yet, despite this seemingly ideal result, neither of the officers looks pleased.

Poitier: *sigh* So, to summarize what you just said, Latham:

Poitier: You're an Awakened piece of a movie projector, which forms a Latham loop.

Poitier: You were designed to play movies, not record them, and that's why you suffer from severe amnesia.

Poitier: You can only recall things that happened within the last three days, and after that, you'll forget almost everything, do I got that right?

Loggerhead: I guess so.

Poitier: You guess so?

Loggerhead: Eek!

Poitier's sudden questioning startles the girl. She shrinks further into the corner, wedging herself between the window and a nearby chair.

Poitier: I can see why that friend of yours calls you Loggerhead. You deserve the name. What is going on here?

Liang Yue: It's understandable. Awakened arcanists often suffer side effects related to their origins and materials, but still, this is quite unusual, to say the least.

Liang Yue: So, she has no memory of what happened three days ago, or even any of the cases she was involved in. So then, she's basically useless to our investigation.

Liang Yue: I can only imagine what a disaster it would be if you showed up in a Detective Co7 movie.

Loggerhead: Hey! That's rude! How come I'm a disaster?

The girl, mustering what little courage she has left, waves her metal fists in defiance.

But her feeble resistance has no effect on the officers. After sighing in unison, they exchange a glance.

Poitier: What do you think?

Liang Yue: I've made a request for Ms. Latham's detailed records. But, I don't think she's lying.

Liang Yue: Back at the hospital, the best lie she could come up with was "a hamster riding a stethoscope." I kind of doubt she's a master manipulator.

Unraveling the Mystery

SC-10

Liang Yue: Let me sort things out.

Liang Yue: Ms. Loggerhead, you said you could record and save your memories using a special type of film developed by Laplace.

Liang Yue: Which means that, even if you don't recall taking anything from the Arcanum Containment Department, your film should show whether you did or not.

Liang Yue: But the fact is, the films are gone. Isn't that right?

Loggerhead: Yeah. I usually carry my most important memories with me and leave the others in my room.

Loggerhead: The Foundation staff checked the visitor log after the stuff was stolen. Turns out I was the only one who visited the office that day, so they sent people to my room and checked all my film, but they didn't find anything.

Loggerhead: Then they said they already had other evidence, so ...

Loggerhead's voice trails off, and someone else completes her words.

Scott: So they just declared Loggerhead guilty.

Scott: But that doesn't make any sense to me. Something must be wrong.

The Foundation employee, who claimed to be hunting Loggerhead, received a call from Liáng just ten minutes ago.

But the moment she stepped into the "clue-filled" hotel room and laid eyes on Loggerhead, she blurted out, "You're still here?" And just like that, the final piece of Loggerhead's testimony was confirmed.

Liang Yue: *sigh*

The two girls sitting on the bed lower their heads in silent understanding.

Liang Yue: So, when you found Ms. Latham, you bought her a train ticket instead of putting her under arrest.

Scott: I know I've gone against orders, but I'm sure Loggerhead didn't do this. She's my friend. I can't just arrest her and have the Foundation lock her up.

Scott: I'm sorry for keeping all this from you, but you're a vigil. I had to be careful.

Scott: So, if it's not crossing a line, Ms. Liáng, Ms. Poitier, can I ask you to keep this between us? You can report it after we find out who's really done this.

Loggerhead: Could you? Please?

Scott's eyes gleam pleadingly, and Loggerhead's lens gleams as she stares at the officers in expectation.

The pitiful expressions on both their faces would tug at anyone's heartstrings. Liáng almost feels as though she's tormenting some kind of harmless creature. But this unofficial interrogation isn't over yet.

Poitier: We'll talk about that once we figure out what the hell's going on.

Poitier: Back to the case. You said she gave you a train ticket. What're you still doing here?

Loggerhead lets out an awkward laugh.

Loggerhead: Actually, while I was on my way to the train station, a car on the other side of the street lost control and hit my cab.

Loggerhead: Thankfully, it crashed into the passenger seat where I was sitting. My metal's much stronger than human flesh.

Liáng searches her memory for a moment.

Liang Yue: That's right. There was a car accident yesterday morning. The driver suffered some kind of unknown mental abnormality while he was on the road. Maybe he's fallen victim, too.

Liang Yue: What happened next?

Loggerhead: I was sent to the hospital, and you showed up. I thought you were gonna arrest me, so I ran as fast as I could.

Loggerhead: I threw away my cell phone and contact device as soon as I left the Foundation. Scott said they could use them to track me down. I couldn't get ahold of anyone and didn't know what to do.

Loggerhead: And, even though I don't know for sure, I really don't think I'm guilty. It's super weird to be on the run when you feel like you're innocent.

Loggerhead: So, I went back to Chinatown to ask Director Noire for help. She was the only one I could contact directly.

A crucial name.

Liang Yue: Noire ... Could you tell me how you got to know her?

Loggerhead: Of course.

Loggerhead: Let me see. Walk of Fame ... Walk of Fame ... Okay. Now I just need to turn left.

Loggerhead: Wait, which way is left again? It changes every time I turn, right? Gosh, how the heck do people read maps?

Noire: Are you alright? It seems you could use some help.

Loggerhead: Noire stopped to help me. She was really interested in my head, so we had a little chat, and I found out she was a director.

Loggerhead: She offered to take me to the Walk of Fame. We talked a lot about movies on our way there. Then, I told her I was traveling alone, so she invited me to join her movie shoot in Chinatown.

Loggerhead: How could I say no? I mean, she's a famous director. There's no way I'd miss a chance like that.

Liang Yue: Interesting. That was the same day that odd things started happening in Chinatown.

The head that was bobbing excitedly comes to a hesitant stop.

Loggerhead: Hmm. Well, I'm not sure about that.

Liang Yue: Did anything strange happen that day?

Loggerhead's lens flickers. It seems something has surfaced in her mind.

Loggerhead: Let me see. I did find a strange film reel when I was unpacking that night.

Liang Yue: A strange film reel?

Poitier: Wait. Could that be ...?

All three of the others immediately perk up at the mention of those words.

But perhaps due to the limited field of vision of her camera lens, Loggerhead remains oblivious to their gazes.

Instead, she pulls her backpack toward her, muttering to herself as she leisurely rummages through it.

Loggerhead: Yeah, a strange film reel. I've gotten into the habit of labeling my films, like "Check every day" or "Check from time to time," so that I know what to watch to keep important things in my mind.

Loggerhead: I was gonna do a review that night, but when I looked through my film, there was a roll without a label on it.

Loggerhead: It couldn't have been mine, cause it was made of a different material. I was so curious about it, you know? So I played it.

Liang Yue: What did you see?

Loggerhead: It was a movie, I guess. But it was pretty short, more like a demo or a trailer or something.

Loggerhead: But it was so weird. Like a jumble of pictures and sounds. It didn't make any sense to me. I dunno. Maybe it was a prank or something. Hm?

She halts her search and looks up blankly.

Scott: What's wrong?

Loggerhead: The film. It's gone.

Poitier: What?

Loggerhead shrinks nervously once again.

Loggerhead: I can't find it. It was right here, in my bag.

Poitier: Give it to me.

In one swift motion, Poitier snatches Loggerhead's backpack and upends its contents onto the bed.

Poitier: Damn, first time I've seen a bag messier than my sister's. Do you ever organize your stuff?

Like a whirlwind, Poitier tears through Loggerhead's things, ignoring her shrieks of "I just forgot to throw that away!" and "I still need that!" as she ransacks not only the backpack but the entire room.

Finally, she has no choice but to accept a rather disheartening conclusion.

Poitier: Nope. Nothing.

Poitier: You didn't take it out and lose it somewhere, did you? Mistake it for a tip for your pizza guy or something?

Loggerhead: I forget things, but I'm not an idiot. I didn't lose it. Check my film if you wanna prove it. It just disappeared into thin air.

Liang Yue: But your film only records what you saw. Someone might have taken it when you weren't looking.

Liang Yue: Does anyone else know about this film reel? Did you have any visitors or notice anything suspicious after you played it?

Loggerhead: Suspicious? I don't think so. At least I didn't see anything.

Loggerhead: The only person who visited me afterwards was Scott. She came to tell me I was wanted by the Foundation.

Loggerhead: Oh. But actually, I wasn't alone when I played it. Noire was with me. She said she was interested in my memories, so she came and ...

The others stare at Loggerhead as if she's grown a second head. She nervously swallows the rest of her sentence.

Loggerhead: What's wrong?

Scott: So, it was Noire who took the film?

Actor: What are you—Ugh!

A solid punch sends the man flying.

At least, that's what was supposed to happen.

Actor: Sorry, director. I'll try again.

Noire: Don't bother. Clearly, your martial arts skills are severely lacking. I don't want you to hit your head when you fall to the ground.

Noire: Go. Take a break.

The disheveled actor still wants to argue his case, but everyone knows that once this director makes a decision, she won't change her mind easily.

In the end, he simply sighs and steps aside.

Assistant: That was the last one, director.

Assistant: There are far fewer stunt performers with martial arts experience here than in Hong Kong. Master Lau and his men will arrive in a few days. Perhaps we could shoot this scene then?

Noire: Nicolas is on a tight schedule. I doubt he'll change it. Let me see what I can do.

A single sentence is far from enough to capture the many difficulties the famous Hong Kong director has faced since working overseas.

Leaning back in her wheelchair, she discreetly scans the set, searching for the missing piece of the puzzle.

Noire: Hm? Her again?

Lin follows Noire's gaze.

Assistant: Oh, that young officer?

Extra: What do you want? Listen, I don't know what you're trying to do, but can't you just leave us alone?

Crew Member: Sorry, ma'am, this is a closed set. If you don't have a warrant, please leave.

Loggerhead: Guys, guys, relax. Liáng isn't as mean as she seems.

Clearly, the arrival of a certain vigil cadet is unwelcome. So much so, that even Loggerhead is being eyed with suspicion.

But Liáng ignores them. She locked onto her target the moment she scanned the set and is already striding straight toward her.

She stops a few paces in front of the person in question.

Noire: I must say I didn't expect to see you so soon, officer. Is there something else you wanted to ask me?

Noire: I think I made myself perfectly clear this morning. I know nothing about your case.

Liang Yue: No, madam. I'm here to help.

Noire: Help with what?

Liang Yue: Ms. Latham mentioned that you're looking for a qualified stunt performer for your movie.

Liang Yue: I'd like to help with that, if you don't mind, as an apology.

Noire blinks.

Noire: Hmm. You surprise me again.

Double Check

小径

A bullet is among us, right under this roof. It serves no army, no country, only peace.

The heavy rain at the end of the century dissolved and washed away many of its comrades, but it was lucky enough to survive. Its pointy end still shines silver, ready to drill a hole into its enemy.

Sadly, its bulky colleague stole its thunder in this war. One push of the button, one big explosion. There was no need for the rest of the ammunition.

Choices

1. Good, we saved a lot of bullets.

2. Good for them. They don't have to work for a while.

Branch 1

It seems someone has become more budget-conscious after working with the mathematicians.

Saving ten bullets is better than saving one. Saving a hundred bullets is better than saving ten. It's simple math.

Branch 2

Certainly, who doesn't want a life without the need to work? Few would hesitate to choose a life of freedom over the achievement and satisfaction of a job.

Given the short lifespan of a bullet, why would it choose anything else?

But its boss, the general, has more to think about. What are they going to do next time? Will this bullet be put to use when the rain comes again?

Choices

1. The general? Who's that?

A big shot, dear. A wise man of the most insightful kind. You should talk to him if you have the chance.

But he's been in a gloomy mood lately. Be careful not to mention anything related to the conservative battle tactics used in 1999, the missile that would have been launched, and especially anything about the bullets lost in that battle.

He has paid a great price for the future, but you see, the future is sneaky.

Every time you think you can grasp it, it takes a step away from you, nullifying every effort you've made to get near it. Even a bullet isn't fast enough to catch up.

Choices

1. Then we must keep pursuing.

2. Perhaps bullets won't be needed in the future?

Branch 2.1

Pursuing the future. How romantic, dear. As long as we continue to close the gap between us and the future, it will eventually be reduced to zero.

But know that, as time goes by, we are only moving slower and slower in the race. Technology is regressing, and we have switched from AKs to Mosin-Nagants. The bullets won't be as fast as they used to be. The future is drifting away from us, and the past is catching up.

Branch 2.2

Shhhh ... Don't say such things out loud. Especially not near the general, sweetheart.

The bullets have paid a great price in order to find their way back to the future. If they hear you say they won't be needed anymore, you'll end up with quite the ammunition bill.

Alright, let's leave this bullet to itself. Solitude may help alleviate its anxiety about the future.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Hey, Kelefe!

SC-11

Noire: You mean to say that you're a stuntwoman? Seriously?

Noire chuckles and shakes her head before turning her wheelchair in disinterest.

Noire: Thank you, officer. Well, judging by your uniform, you're from the Vigiles Bureau, aren't you?

Noire: I appreciate the gesture. It's true that we may be able to attract more viewers if we have a vigil on the cast list.

Noire: But filmmaking isn't as easy as you think. Maybe I can fit you in next time.

Rejection. But refusal is not an option in this operation.

Liang Yue: I'm familiar with movies, especially yours. I'm actually a big fan.

Liang Yue: And I saw the performance just now. Not to be rude or anything, but I think I can handle the stunt.

Liang Yue: "For the betterment of the movie." That's what Ms. Latham said you were after. Is that right?

Her words stir up a storm.

Actor: What? Does she even know what she's talking about?

Crew Member: Hmph. That's some pretty big talk.

Even Noire can't help but let out an amused chuckle at Liáng's words. Even so, her wheelchair comes to a stop.

Noire: That's true, but are you certain that you'll make my movie better?

Liang Yue: Yes.

To be honest, no.

Liáng knows that filmmaking is far more complex than it appears. Her answer is far from the truth.

But if she's going to uncover the truth, she has to act the part.

Noire: Hmm. Interesting.

Noire: Since you insist, let's give it a try. Show me what a vigil can do.

It isn't a particularly clever trick, but fortunately, Latham's words weren't false.

Noire would never turn down an opportunity to improve her films.

Noire: Excellent! Bravo!

Noire: Exactly as you claimed, no, even better. Really spectacular work, a perfect take.

Liang Yue: I'm flattered, director.

Noire's eyes glisten as she watches the playback of the shot. Meanwhile, after nearly twenty failed takes, Liáng returns to the dressing room, her costume drenched in sweat.

When she emerges back in her Vigiles uniform, a bottle of water is handed to her.

Actor I: Here. It's not open.

Liang Yue: Thank you.

Actor I: Didn't expect you to pull it off. That was a dangerous stunt. Scared the crap outta me.

Actor I: Alright, alright, so you did a good job one time. But let me tell you, it takes a lot more than that to win recognition in this industry.

Actor II: You've really gotta hone in on the dramatic scenes if you wanna move out of the stuntwoman box. You're good-looking, and you took that scene pretty seriously. You interested in doing that?

Actor II: If you are, then I'll suggest you be a little more humble. There's always room for improvement, you know.

Liang Yue: I ... You're right. I'm sorry.

Liang Yue: But I'm not even a stuntwoman, let alone an actress. This is all just a bit of fun for me.

Noire: Is that so? Oh, what a shame.

The queen of the set rolls over in her chariot, stopping beside Liáng.

Noire: I appreciate your sincerity, but I'd be even more appreciative if you were willing to do a few more scenes.

Liang Yue: If it's just for a short time, I'd like to help in any way I can.

Noire: Fantastic! Follow me. We can have dinner and look at the script together. I have a few changes I want to make to the story.

Noire: Trust me, the audience will be more than happy to hear a line or two from you.

Liang Yue: Lines? Okay.

Things seem to be taking an unexpected turn.

Noire: That's all. Well? Have you memorized them?

Liang Yue: Yes, every word. But ...

Liang Yue: Aren't there too many?

The blank spaces in the script spread out on the table are filled with Noire's flamboyant pen strokes.

Assistant: She's got a point, director. The investors might not approve them. They already told us not to change the script like we did in Hong Kong.

Noire: Relax. We've done this before. They never read the script anyway.

Noire: Besides, I'm not exactly asking for a monologue here. It's only three lines. Just what's needed to make the character complete.

Lin gives a helpless sigh. She knows all too well how pointless it is to try and change Noire's mind.

Liang Yue: I'll keep practicing until filming starts.

Noire: I look forward to your performance.

Liang Yue: By the way, I saw some deity dolls and sedan chairs on the set. The Dùshuò Festival is coming up, right? Is the crew joining the Shèhuǒ Parade?

Noire: Those are our props.

Noire: Our final scene is set at the Shèhuǒ Parade. I already spoke with the organizers in Chinatown. They've allowed us to shoot during it.

Liang Yue: Really? The last Co7 movie ended with a Shèhuǒ Parade, too.

Noire's eyes light up. She smiles.

Noire: Good memory. Looks like you meant it when you said you were a big fan.

The restaurant owner serves their meal, pausing their script discussion for the time being.

Noire and her assistant pick up their chopsticks, but Loggerhead remains still.

Loggerhead: So, did you find anything?

Loggerhead: You said that your beastie friend could detect things tainted with evil, right? So did it sense anything wrong with the director?

While Loggerhead speaks in a hushed tone, the conspicuousness of her head makes talking in secret a near impossible task.

Feeling Noire and Lin's subtle glances, Liáng squirms in her seat.

Liang Yue: No, but that doesn't mean—

Loggerhead: Yes! I told you she'd never do that.

Liang Yue: Hey! She can hear you, you know.

The situation is already beyond repair.

Noire: I'd never do what?

Liang Yue: ...

For a brief moment, Liáng feels a splitting headache. She shoots a mildly accusatory glance at Loggerhead, causing her to visibly shrink.

Loggerhead: Sorry, I don't like skirting around things.

Loggerhead: Can't we just ask her straight up?

Liang Yue: Not really. If every criminal just confessed to their crimes, the Vigiles wouldn't exist.

No clumsy cover-up will fool the director now. There is nothing for it but to be upfront.

Perhaps this is for the best anyway.

Liang Yue: Actually, I didn't just come here to apologize. There's something I want to ask you about.

Noire: What is it?

A perfectly measured balance of curiosity and confusion, yet no real surprise.

A renowned director having a knack for acting isn't exactly shocking. In fact, it's about as surprising as an amateur failing miserably to do the same thing.

Liang Yue: It's about the strange things happening in Chinatown these days.

Assistant: Wait, so all this was just to butter us up so you could investigate your case?

The assistant, who was all smiles moments ago, suddenly falls silent. Despite her careful preparation, the situation is difficult for Liáng.

Liang Yue: Sorry, madam, but it's my job.

Liang Yue: As I said, strange things have been happening in Chinatown—things that bear a striking resemblance to the "film incident" that you were involved in eight years ago, Ms. Noire.

Liang Yue: The case document stated that the origin of these events is a film reel titled Reunion of the Three Swallows—a movie created by your friend, Hé Rìjūn.

Liang Yue: Ms. Latham said you watched a film with her in her room a few days ago. Do you have any idea where that film reel is now?

Noire: That film reel?

Liang Yue: Did you not know what it was?

Noire: I had no idea.

Noire's expression darkens. Clearly, she's realized why Liáng has brought up that film reel.

Noire: That film we watched together ... Well, to put it mildly, it had nothing of interest. It didn't seem to have any semblance of a story, even.

Noire: It couldn't have been one of Teresa's.

Liáng recalls that the archive on Reunion of the Three Swallows cited "Teresa" as the English name of its creator, Hé Rìjūn.

Noire and Hé Rìjūn had been friends since their days studying abroad, and it seems Noire still uses that name even now.

Rumors, investigation reports, and speculations flicker through Liáng's mind. But seeing the somber look on the woman before her, she decides to set them aside for now.

Liang Yue: Maybe the original content has been contaminated. According to the Foundation's records, the film reel has two abilities: play and record.

Liang Yue: The play ability allows it to conjure its contents into reality in a form similar to a movie image, which accounts for the hallucinations and phantoms the victims mentioned.

Liang Yue: The record ability captures the souls of those in the same effective range as play, and the victims lose a part of themselves, like their sanity or their memories.

Liang Yue: The case document doesn't mention anything about contamination, but my guess is that the souls recorded by the film have polluted the original content of the film.

Noire: Shame on them—whoever's behind this.

Noire mutters a curse, and both she and Liáng fall into silence. Meanwhile, Lin and Loggerhead look utterly lost.

Loggerhead: Wait, wait. What are you talking about? Can you explain it to me simply, please?

Liang Yue: Ms. Noire didn't know that that film was Reunion of the Three Swallows, so naturally, she didn't take it.

Liang Yue: I think she's telling the truth.

Loggerhead: Really? That's great news.

No one responds. Loggerhead looks around and slowly lowers the arm she raised in premature celebration.

Loggerhead: Oh, right. The film's still missing, so it's not great news.

Loggerhead: But, at least, Noire wasn't up to something when she made friends with me, right? That's definitely good news for me.

She turns to Noire.

Loggerhead: That means we're still friends. And friends help each other. Liáng said that the film reel could cause some problems for you. Let me help you find it.

Loggerhead: I'll catch that thief and take the film back to the ACD.

Loggerhead: Then you'll be safe, I'll clear my name, and the problems in Chinatown will be solved. That's three birds with one stone. Genius, right?

Noire: You know, Ms. Latham, this is what I like about you. You always speak your mind.

Her eyes squint a little as she curves her mouth into an unexpectedly gentle smile.

Noire: Our relationships are so complex, aren't they? That's what makes them so intriguing, captivating, really. A constant source of inspiration.

Noire: But sometimes I feel that life is better kept simple. Wouldn't you agree, Ms. Vigil?

Liang Yue: Agreed.

There are certainly simpler ways to say "I'm suspicious of you" and "I have no intention of cooperating."

Liang Yue: May I ask you another question?

Noire: Please.

Liang Yue: The rumors about C07, which ones are true?

Noire: I don't think a few old stories will help you solve the case.

Liang Yue: It's not only for the case, but for my own curiosity.

Liang Yue: I wasn't lying when I said I was familiar with your works. I really like them.

Liang Yue: And this question matters a lot to me as a fan.

Noire: Oh. I see.

Noire ponders for a moment.

Noire: In that case, I really don't think you should know the truth, for your own good.

Noire: I appreciate your love for my works, but it's not a good idea to dig too deep into what went on behind the scenes.

Noire: Just enjoy the stories for what they are. Otherwise, the magic will be ruined.

She gives a slight shake of her head, but a flicker of contemplation passes through her downcast eyes.

Noire: Well, I can tell you one thing that might interest you, though.

Mousetrap

SC-12

Night has deepened, and the little restaurant on the corner outside of Chinatown is almost empty. The doorbell chimes, and two people walk in.

Loggerhead: Scott, and Tall Officer, over here.

Poitier: Again, it's Poitier. Have you seriously already forgotten my name? It's only been three hours.

At Loggerhead's call, the two newcomers take a seat at her and Liáng's table.

Liang Yue: What's your status?

Scott: Couldn't find anything useful. Sorry.

Scott: I already asked the investigators who came with me to track down the other missing items, you know, to cover up for Loggerhead, but so far, they haven't found anything.

Scott: As for the person who stole the item, I haven't a clue.

Loggerhead: Well ...

Loggerhead: At least there haven't been any reports of arcane explosions or earthquakes. No news is good news, right?

Poitier: What about you? Any leads?

Liang Yue: Ms. Noire didn't take the film, but she refused to tell us anything about its curse or the former owner, Hé Rìjūn.

She lets out a deliberately dejected sigh, withholding the final message Noire gave her.

Poitier: Looks like I'm the only one who has good news.

Liang Yue: You do? What about?

Poitier tilts her head, gesturing past Scott to the darkened street outside the window.

Poitier: The illegal trade of arcane items. You told me to keep an eye on it.

Poitier: I contacted my guy who tracks all that stuff. Told me about this trader called Pug Dog, a middleman in the black market.

Poitier: He was pulled over for speeding this morning, but he actually paid the ticket right away. Can you believe that? I wouldn't be surprised if he shot the police car and ran away there.

Liang Yue: An outlaw suddenly behaving himself ...

Liang Yue: He must be up to something important. Something big enough to make him avoid getting into trouble over a speeding ticket.

Poitier: The officers thought the same, so they tracked him to this stolen car, right? Well, guess where it's headed—here, Chinatown.

Pug Dog: ...

A man with a deep, jagged scar across his brow saunters under the moonlight.

At last, he stops, slipping into a darkened alleyway. He has no idea that four silent pursuers are lurking nearby, hidden under a rookie vigil's Silent Shadow arcane skill.

Loggerhead: What's he doing?

Poitier: Waiting for someone's my guess.

Scott: A middleman for the arcane black market. So, he probably has the cursed film, and now he's planning to sell it to someone.

Scott: We should get him now, before the film's sold off. Come on, this is our chance.

Scott: Hm? Mmm.

Liáng clamps a hand over her mouth just in time, muffling her outburst.

Liang Yue: Shh. Someone's coming.

From the depths of the shadows, a figure emerges.

Not walking toward Pug Dog, but riding something. Perhaps—a wheelchair.

Noire: Good evening, sir. I hope I didn't keep you too long.

Pug Dog: You got the dough?

Noire: Of course.

Noire pulls a rectangular object from her coat.

Poitier: It's an envelope. Looks pretty thick.

Poitier is right. Pug Dog takes the envelope and pulls a handful of bills from it before nodding in satisfaction.

Pug Dog: All here. Dontcha worry, alright? You can trust me. Everyone in L.A. knows Pug Dog.

He stuffs the bulging envelope into his pocket before pulling an item from his jacket.

Pug Dog: Here's your stuff.

The item cuts an arc through the darkness, landing precisely in Noire's waiting hands.

Pug Dog: Heh. I like customers like you, generous and to the point. Alright, I'm outta here. Pleasure doin' business with ya. And hey, feel free to call me again.

He scans the area before turning back to Noire, lowering his voice.

Pug Dog: Seein' as you're a good customer o' mine, here's a bit of advice: Watch your back on the way outta here.

Noire: What do you mean?

But Noire doesn't get the chance to press further.

The moment has come. Liáng strides out from the shadows.

Liang Yue: Sorry to interrupt, but neither one of you will be making your own way home. Ms. Noire, Pug Dog.

Liang Yue: I'm afraid you'll be coming to the Arcane Affairs office with me.

Pug Dog: F**kin' cop!

Pug Dog: Ow! Easy, easy.

Poitier: Shut up and stay down!

Pug Dog's attempts to fight back have been utterly useless.

Liang Yue: Ms. Noire, could you show me what he gave you?

Noire: Go ahead.

She hands a dusty gray box to Liáng.

Inside is an ordinary-looking film reel. But Liáng can feel the vessel containing Qiángliáng growing warm against her skin.

Liang Yue: Super 8 mm. This must be it. Reunion of the Three Swallows. Hé Rìjūn's final work.

Liang Yue: The culprit behind the strange happenings in Chinatown.

Yet for now, it lies quietly in her grasp, docile and unthreatening.

Poitier: Well, that was easier than expected. Half a day, and we've already tracked it down.

Poitier: Now all we gotta do is stop it from doing its arcanum-y thing. But how? Smash it?

Before Liáng can respond, Noire voices a polite opposition.

Noire: I don't think that's a good idea.

Liang Yue: I have to admit, Ms. Noire's right.

Liang Yue: Arcane items need to be handled with the utmost care. No one knows what will happen once it's broken. We could make things worse.

Poitier: Fine. Let's take these two back to the office first.

Poitier: On your feet, tough guy! We gotta go.

Pug Dog: Ugh. Damn it. How'd ya find me? Some asshole sell me out?

Pug Dog is yanked up from the ground. He reluctantly follows Poitier, grumbling and cursing under his breath.

But as he passes Liáng, he stops.

Pug Dog: Wait. You!

He stares.

Not at her, precisely, but at the figure cowering behind her.

Pug Dog: It was you! You f**kin' traitor! I shoulda known you were workin' with the cops.

Loggerhead tilts her head in confusion.

Loggerhead: Huh? What are you talking about?

Scott: Uh, wait, let me explain. This is just a misunderstanding.

Liang Yue: Don't worry, Ms. Scott. You're right. There has been a misunderstanding between you and him. Allow me to explain.

Scott heaves a sigh of relief, only for Liáng's next words to hit her like a thunderclap.

Liang Yue: You never had the intention of betraying him, nor were you working with us.

Liang Yue: You simply gave him the item you wanted to sell. That's it.

A Project Gone Awry · 1/2

SC-13

Loggerhead: What? What do you mean?

Loggerhead turns to her friend, then to Pug Dog, then back to Liáng. She remains totally expressionless.

Liang Yue: The truth was always there—hidden beneath the lies and distractions. All you have to do is whittle them down, one by one.

Liang Yue: The probable cause of the events in Chinatown is the Reunion of the Three Swallows film reel, and apparently, Ms. Noire has a history with it.

And yet, the specifics of this history remain unclear. Liáng glances at Noire, only to be met with her signature unreadable smile.

Liang Yue: But Ms. Noire doesn't have anything to do with the Foundation. There's no way she could sneak into the ACD and steal the film. The same goes for this gentleman or any other outsider.

Liang Yue: So, the thief who wants Ms. Latham to take the fall must work for the Foundation.

Liang Yue: In fact, since they stole the item without being noticed, they probably work for the ACD.

Liang Yue: And they must be close to Ms. Latham to know enough about her amnesia to be able to take advantage of it.

Loggerhead: But loads of people at the ACD know about my condition. You can't pin it on Scott just from that.

For the first time, the ever-cheerful Loggerhead takes on a harsh, indignant tone.

She stamps her foot and turns to her friend.

Loggerhead: That's way too harsh, right, Scott? Right?

Loggerhead: Scott? Say something, will you?

Scott: ...

Scott only stares at the floor as she tries to calm her quivering breath.

Scott: How long have you known?

Scott has finally managed to force out a few words.

Liang Yue: Since Ms. Latham said you were good friends. With all due respect, your plan was far from perfect.

Scott: Ugh, I knew it. You brought me along so this guy would call me out.

After a long sigh, Scott lifts her head, speaking with a resigned kind of ease.

Scott: You're right. I messed up. My plan was far from perfect because, well, I couldn't stick to the so-called plan since the very beginning.

Scott: I didn't know the Foundation was already investigating the theft until after I'd hidden the items in Loggerhead's room.

Scott: Then I had no choice but to use this idiot as the scapegoat. I never thought she'd accidentally bring the film to L.A., or that I'd be ordered to investigate the case.

Scott: I got in touch with this guy a long time ago, and the trade site happened to be in L.A. too. So, my plan was to get the film back and sell it right afterwards.

Scott: But things didn't go as smoothly as I thought. I shouldn't have gotten greedy, or been so nice to this dummy.

She shoots a piercing glare at Loggerhead before quickly looking away—whether out of disdain or avoidance is unclear.

Loggerhead: But, but ...

Loggerhead: We're friends, aren't we?

Her voice is as fragile as brittle glass. Scott shatters it with a scoff.

Scott: Friends? Don't be ridiculous. I don't know how you can act like nothing's wrong when literally everyone is laughing at you. And the fact that they thought that I was one of your kind.

Scott: Ugh! What an insult! I only hung out with you because ... because I had no choice.

Scott: You're an idiot who forgets everything every three days. It's your own damn fault. Anyone looking for a scapegoat would immediately think of you.

Poitier: Quit it! I don't wanna hear any more of your BS.

Scott scoffs once more, refusing to look at her "friend" for even a second.

Liang Yue: Hands up, Ms. Scott. Anything you say can and will be used against you in a court of law.

Liang Yue: Wait, you're still going to fight?

Calculated Maneuver

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.

And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

A Vigile's Correspondence

This letter was tucked inside a folder of interrogation records, it appears to have been exchanged silently between two Vigiles agents during an interrogation. The two distinct handwritings reflect their unspoken dialogue:

"She's tight-lipped about it."

"But she seems unaware that we've already figured out everything."

"Fascinating, like a mouse in a lab experiment—arrogant yet clueless."

"There's still one thing left to figure out: how exactly did she learn to crack the anti-theft arcane seal?"

"All her lies and disguises fall apart under scrutiny, but she hasn't given up a single clue about this. Even our artificial somnambulism couldn't uncover anything ..."

"Could it just be sheer dumb luck?"

"Disappointing. I've taught you better—never rely on million-to-one coincidences. Always consider the more plausible scenario."

"You mean ... she's being controlled by someone else? And they've erased her memory, so she can't betray them?"

"Exactly. That slippery merchant gave up Scott, but there's no way a minor employee could pull off something like this. Rejoice, we've hooked a big fish."

"So ... we're letting her go?"

"Yes, but not without loosening her strings first."

"Understood. I'll notify Mr. Pedra. I trust he'll ensure Miss Scott feels completely at ease after some ... subtle adjustments."

"Good. You're a reliable assistant, Billy."

The second writer seemed about to reply but left only a hesitant pen stroke.

A Project Gone Awry · 2/2

SC-13

At last, Scott gives up her resistance. Liáng pushes her toward Poitier's patrol car parked around the corner.

As they're about to step out of the alley, Loggerhead calls out.

Loggerhead: Wait. Scott!

Loggerhead: I have to know, why did you steal from the Foundation?

Scott: Does it matter?

Scott turns back, laughing coldly in disbelief.

Scott: Would you feel better if I had a reason? Oh, please! Your ignorant, stupid little brain makes me sick.

Scott: It was for the money, of course. And to prove to the others that I'm not a bloody fool like you.

Scott: Imagine the shock on their faces when they discover that I did what none of them could. Those so-called unbreakable arcane security skills were easy to deal with as long as I ...

Scott: I ...

Her words trail off, and a puzzled expression crosses her face.

Liang Yue: You what? How did you bypass the Foundation's security?

Scott: I don't remember. That's weird. How could I forget? All I remember is that an office lady talked to me in the corridor.

Liang Yue: An office lady? When? What did you talk about?

Scott: She ... She showed me something. It was a bit dazzling, but very beautiful. It was ...

Scott: Oh, oh, right. It was a ...

A razor-sharp silver needle slices through the air, cutting her off in an instant.

Scott: Ahhhh—?

She raises a dazed hand, her fingertips touching the foreign object lodged in her throat, not understanding why her voice has suddenly vanished.

By the time she's realized she can no longer breathe, her eyes roll back, and she falls to the ground.

Silence falls in the starlit alley. Then, another flash of silver whistles by.

Liang Yue: What?

A sharp pain blooms in her palm. She looks down to see a sharp silver needle pierced in it. The film slips from her grasp.

The reel rolls across the ground, clicking as it hurtles into the darkness, until a gloved hand picks it up and brushes it off.

???: Phew! Still intact. You've got no idea how long I've been looking for this.

Liang Yue: You're ...

Qi Xing: Hey there, kid. We meet again.

The once-famous star smiles at Liáng with an easy, friendly charm.

Loggerhead: Scott! Scott!

Pug Dog: No f**king way. She dead?

Poitier: Not yet, but I doubt she can hold on much longer. I'll call an ambulance, and we're gonna need backup.

Liang Yue: ...

Loggerhead's scream, Pug Dog's cry, and Poitier's tense voice all ring in Liáng's mind.

Liáng's rationality has already grasped the reality of the situation, but her emotions are refusing to let her shape the conclusion into clear words.

Liang Yue: Why are you doing this?

When Loggerhead posed a similar question to Scott, Liáng had questioned the inquiry.

There is no need to ask why evil chooses to do evil. What's wrong is wrong. Evil must be eradicated. Ghost plagues must be purged. That was the doctrine drilled into Liáng since childhood.

But now, she finds herself forced to ask the same thing.

Liang Yue: Tell me. I need a reason.

Qi Xing: It's my old friend that you should be asking.

Liáng watches as Qí Xīng's smile fades and her face turns steely.

Qi Xing: Long time no see, Noire.

Noire: Yeah, it's been a while.

Noire: The last time we saw each other was in front of her grave, if memory serves? We really should keep in touch more often.

The air in the alley is sharp as a needle. Noire continues to smile, but a wariness lurks behind her eyes.

Noire: But you've gone too far this time, my friend.

She glances at Scott's fallen body and gently shakes her head.

Noire: This isn't part of our story.

Qi Xing: This isn't a set, director. It's not your call.

She raises a hand, and a flash of silver pierces through the darkness.

Liang Yue: Careful!

She leaps forward, deflects the needles, and stands firm in front of the wheelchair.

Qí Xīng shows no surprise. She narrows her eyes a little, as if she foresaw this outcome.

Qi Xing: That's the spirit. This should be fun with you here, little vigil.

Qi Xing: Let's all play our roles, shall we?

Lit Screen, Lit Eyes

SC-14

Poitier: The hell?! I thought movie stars were just empty suits.

Another volley of silver needles streaks through the air, forcing Liáng and Poitier back.

Qí Xīng stands at the center of the alley. Though seemingly trapped between Liáng and Poitier, she skillfully uses their positioning to her advantage.

Neither officer can risk injuring the other by firing their gun or using an arcane skill, leaving the battle at a deadlock.

Liang Yue: We're not going to last much longer. I have to do something. Poitier, cover me.

Liang Yue: Arise Qiángliáng, swift and fierce!

With the ritual vessel of Qiángliáng in her hand, Liáng recites the ancient incantation, each syllable clear and deliberate.

Qi Xing: ...!

Qí Xīng looks momentarily stunned.

This is the beginning of an incantation. Liáng knows that more silver needles could come flying at her at any moment.

Liang Yue: Banish all evil ...

For a brief moment, hesitation creeps over her.

As a child, she sat before the screen and watched this figure over and over again, her eyes filled with admiration. She had mimicked her arcane skill countless times.

But she never imagined that, one day, those dazzling silver needles would be aimed at her.

Liang Yue: ... and cleanse this place!

Yet, she still speaks the final words of the incantation.

With these words, an ancient contract will be upheld, and the Xiǎndào Beast will be called upon to devour all evil. As is her right as a descendant of the Liáng family.

At least, that's what's supposed to happen.

Liang Yue: What?

But the alley remains as empty as it was before.

Qi Xing: Hey!

Poitier: Rookie, watch out!

Someone pushes her aside. She hits the ground hard. A flash of silver. The sound of shouting.

Then, blood. A body falling. A sticky sensation. Warmth. Chaos ...

...

The events that follow are hazy in Liáng's memory.

Enraged Man: Training isn't over! Stand firm!

A sharp reprimand shatters her haze, pulling her back to focus.

Liang Yue: That's ...

A familiar courtyard. A man with a familiar face.

In front of him, a little girl stands in horse stance, sweat rolling down her forehead. Her legs are trembling.

Yet, the man's ebony ruler comes down mercilessly on the girl's shoulder.

Enraged Man: Wrong! Shoulders and elbows down! Relax your body and mind. How many times do I have to repeat myself?

Two small heads peek over the courtyard wall, giggling and whispering to each other.

Boy: Shh. Look, she's gonna fall any second.

Girl: Heh heh, that's what she gets for saying that to the teacher.

The boy makes a goofy face at the girl holding the stance. The girl, already exhausted, finally loses her balance and collapses to the ground.

Enraged Man: You don't come to training, you're distracted, and you're lazy. How could Qiángliáng obey such an undisciplined master?

Enraged Man: Get up. I'll come back later. If you can't do it by sundown, there will be no dinner tonight.

The man, her father, shakes his head in disappointment and walks away, leaving the girl gasping for breath on the ground.

Girl: Let's go. She's gonna be there all day. Wanna go to the theater?

Boy: Sure! The one on the corner's playing Detective C07 today.

The children hop down from the wall, laughing as they scurry off.

Liang Yue: The theater? I want to go, too.

No one hears her voice.

No one but herself.

Liang Yue: I remember it now. I hated Qiángliáng when I was little.

Liang Yue: Father was always trying to teach me something, about the Twelve Zhènzǐ, the Master of Qiángliáng, fighting the wicked and dispelling evil, fulfilling the duty of my inheritance. I was only a child. It was all too difficult for me to understand.

Liang Yue: The other kids hated me. I was a traitor, a class president who took the side of the adults and enforced the rules. They'd all hang out and have fun together while I was left alone. I envied them.

Liang Yue: Their lives were simple. I wanted that.

Liang Yue: One cent, two cents ... five ...

Her piggy bank lies smashed on the ground as she picks through the shards to count every coin.

Amidst the broken porcelain, half of a shattered face stares up at her innocently.

Liang Yue: I'm sorry, Piggy.

She gently brushes her fingers over its face in a gesture of comfort—or farewell.

Liang Yue: That day, I disobeyed Father, gathered up all my savings, and headed to the theater.

Liang Yue: That was the first time I watched Detective C07. It was amazing.

Liang Yue: But I knew. It was just fiction. Just an escape.

Liang Yue: It wouldn't change anything in my real life. Once the movie was over, I'd have to go back to the same home I had just left.

Liang Yue: I didn't want to leave, so I stayed in my seat for the closing credits.

Liang Yue: But the lights didn't come on when the credits ended. Rather, the silver screen lit up again and played something.

Liang Yue: It was an interview with Ms. Qí Xīng.

Reporter: Ms. Qí Xīng, many children love your work and see you as their hero.

Reporter: Yet some adults say that the story of Detective C07 is too unrealistic because she always beats the villain.

Reporter: What's your opinion on this subject? Is it a flaw of the movie?

Qi Xing: The real world's already a cruel and unfair place. Our movie's idealistic, yes, but it shows us a world where good is rewarded and evil is punished. We need that.

Qi Xing: If we can't accept justice and truth even in a fictional world, then what hope do we have for reality?

Qí Xīng gazes into the camera, but also beyond it, her smile carefree, her eyes shining even brighter than the stars.

Qi Xing: C07 is justice, a hero who fights evil and cares for the weak. She'll always bring a happy ending, no matter what she's faced with.

Qi Xing: One of our goals with this movie, and with the character, was to inspire and encourage our viewers.

Qi Xing: We know that most people can't become a C07 in the real world. After all, it's an incredibly difficult path to take.

Qi Xing: But we hope that we can at least inspire people to become heroes in their own lives, to create happy endings for themselves and the people around them.

Liang Yue: It was just a short interview like any other, but I still remember every word she said.

Liang Yue: "As the master of Qiángliáng, you must use your power to fight the wicked and dispel evil. It is your duty to maintain the peace of the world."

Liang Yue: Qiángliáng, the powerful being that had always been a blur to me, suddenly became clear.

Liang Yue: I realized that I could be more than just a hero who creates happy endings for herself and the people around her. I could be the hero who creates happy endings for everyone, just like C07.

Liang Yue: She was right. Not everyone can do that, but I could, because I was Yuè of the Liáng family, the master of Qiángliáng. On that day, the burden that had been crushing me suddenly became a blessing.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: So, what went wrong?

The image fades as another silver flash brings her back to reality.

Sirens. An ambulance. Blood. Blood. Endless blood. It seeps through the fabric of her uniform, drenching her hands.

She hears someone shouting.

Liang Yue: Stay with me, Poitier. Please!

Liang Yue: Why? Why did you do that?

Liang Yue: I-I thought you hated me.

Liang Yue: People always hate me.

Now she can hear clearly, she realizes it's her own voice, hoarse with desperation.

What did Poitier say to her back then?

Blood bubbles from her mouth and nose with each painful breath.

Poitier: *cough* You could tell, huh?

Poitier: But that's—*cough*—that's in the past. Forget it.

Poitier: We just didn't know you yet.

A bloodstained hand weakly pats Liáng's cheek before falling limp.

Liang Yue: Poitier?

Liang Yue: No! No!! Please! Poitier!

Poitier: Ugh, will you shut up? I'm not dead yet.

Liang Yue: Ugh!

A thunderous smack, unbelievable from someone confined to a hospital bed, jerks Liáng awake from her nightmare.

Liáng's head throbs. Dazed, she looks around, taking in the sterile white of the hospital room and the irritated face of her instructor.

Poitier: The hell you doing sleeping on my thigh, huh? Ugh, my leg's gone numb. And clean up the drool on your chin.

Liang Yue: What? Ah. I'm sorry.

Poitier: Just kidding, boo. You're not drooling.

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: Alright, turn on the TV for me. I was bored out of my mind waiting for you to wake up.

Syncing Up
小径

My dear child, look at you, you're exhausted. I couldn't be of help then, but it's ok, the "party" is over now. At least let me brush your hair, darling.

Or your hair will get all knotted, and it will hurt you when you try to untangle them.

Choices

1. Indeed. It happened more than once.

I'm not surprised. An old friend of ours, "knot." Often we learn our knots before we even know how to read and write.

A knot could be an obstacle that breaks the consistency of a flow, and also a reminder of forgotten things.

You can use just about anything on hand to make a knot: leaves of grass, the fur of an animal, even fallen hair ... But the sturdiest knots are tied with rope.

Knots are to be found in many stories. Signify promises, counting and measuring, an instrument of salvation and one of execution.

Choices

1. What else can these knots really do?

Oh, I could go on all day! The influence and power of knots can't be overstated...

It is said that it was in the cutting of the Gordian Knot that Alexander became "the Great"; just touching the meters-long rope provides blessings to the faithful in Belem; and tiny knots on strings can carry the history of an entire people.

The ancient Inca called it "Quipu." The intricate variations of hundreds of fabrics, colors, and lengths of strings were used to record their stories through the ages. And to think, Shakespeare only had 26 letters to create his masterpieces.

Choices

1. Isn't there something a bit more practical?

Just look around you: don't sailors use knots to mark depths and mend sails; or coachmen tying knots to rein their horses; and any respectable lady or gentleman knows the knots they must tie about their necks to stay in fashion.

Or consider the knot-like helix structure of DNA, and the changes in states of matter ... Invisible to the naked eye, these knots carry some hint at a universal law.

That there might be a string, like the Quipu, an endless rope that records in its knots everything in the world. One that can't be seen, yet there it is, everywhere, all at once.

Maybe you can tie this knot yourself. Use your hair, then form a loop, pass the end through it, and tighten it up. There you go.

I hope you keep this knot as a record of the words we shared here.

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

This Just In

SC-15

Loggerhead: Tall Officer, are you up? I got you guys Chinese food. You must be hungry.

Poitier: Shh.

The two officers are both staring intently at the television screen.

The paper cups in their hands are crumpled tight.

Reporter: Almost 20 suspects in the holding cell were injured. Most were found unconscious at the scene and are now in critical condition at the hospital.

Reporter: The victims include arcane black market dealer Caster and Chicago gang leader Jason the Coyote, both of whom have since been acquitted of their crimes.

Behind the reporter, thick black smoke billows from the scene of a car accident. Flames lick at the oil spilled on the road, sending waves of searing heat into the air.

Medical Staff: Cameras, out of the way, out of the way! The ambulance needs to come through. We need banana bags stat, or these people could go into shock.

Injured Suspect I: Ah. My skin. It burns. Help, help!

Injured Suspect II: Whoever you are who did this, just wait and see. I'll, I'll tear you apart, you asshole!

Medical personnel shove past the journalist as they hurry over with a stretcher.

The cursing and wailing of the deranged man behind the reporter echo in the background. It sends a chill down their spines.

Reporter: The fire is speculated to have been started by a victim of a Nightpiercer attack who displayed signs of mental instability.

Reporter: At the same time, similar incidents have occurred at the Liber Street Detention Center and the Chinatown Police Station. The situations at both sites are similarly concerning.

Reporter: It has been reported that the Division of Arcane Affairs is considering the potential connections between these incidents. The mysterious figure behind the unresolved Nightpiercer attacks remains their top suspect.

Reporter: As with the previous attacks attributed to the Nightpiercer, the victims of these incidents are once again notorious criminals with extensive records.

Reporter: However, in light of the Nightpiercer's escalating criminal activities, support for the figure is dwindling as concerns for safety rise.

Reporter: In response to ongoing skepticism regarding the lack of resolution in the Nightpiercer case, Deputy Chief Elden of the Division of Arcane Affairs stated during the press conference that—

Poitier slams the power button on the remote before flicking it aside.

She yanks the IV needle from her hand and grabs her uniform from the bedside.

Poitier: F**k! I pass out for half a day, and Qí Xīng's already turned the city into her personal playground?

Poitier: Grab your stuff, rookie. We're hitting the road. Gotta find this b**ch before she kills someone.

Poitier: What, your feet stuck to the floor or something?

Poitier stops only when she notices Liáng still sitting motionless. Liáng purses her lips, struggling to speak under Poitier's skeptical gaze.

Liang Yue: Deputy Chief Elden took us off the case. It was an official order.

A few hours earlier, the L.A. office for the Division of Arcane Affairs fell into an eerie silence.

Deputy Chief Elden: Early this morning, Constance Scott, a staff member of the Foundation's Arcanum Containment Department, was assaulted during an illegal arcane object trade. She's still in critical condition.

Deputy Chief Elden: Forensic Services has confirmed that the arcane skill traces found at the scene of the attack match those left by the suspect in the ongoing Nightpiercer case.

Deputy Chief Elden: Thanks to Noire and our Vigiles cadet Liáng Yuè, who were both at the scene of the attack, we've been able to confirm the identity of the Nightpiercer.

Deputy Chief Elden: Name's Qí Xīng, a 29-year-old former movie actress from Hong Kong. She played the lead role in the Detective C07 series, where she gained a reasonable amount of fame.

Deputy Chief Elden: She was in a few more movies after that, but no big hits. She officially retired from acting a few years ago.

Deputy Chief Elden: The BAU's come to the conclusion that she's confused herself with her movie character—possibly a result of a mental imbalance caused by the setbacks in her career.

Deputy Chief Elden: She thinks she's the real-life C07, the hero who fights evil and cares for the weak. In short, we have a "vigilante" on our hands.

Deputy Chief Elden: Thanks to a minor mistake from the Foundation's Arcanum Containment Department, we also have a dangerous arcane item, a cursed film reel called Reunion of the Three Swallows, somewhere in the city.

Deputy Chief Elden: Liáng has confirmed that Constance Scott, the staff member who was assaulted by Qí Xīng yesterday, is the perpetrator of the theft.

Deputy Chief Elden: As you're all aware, there's been an explosion in mental disorders in Chinatown. We now know that their source is the cursed film reel.

Deputy Chief Elden: It's currently in Qí Xīng's possession, which makes her even more dangerous.

Deputy Chief Elden: Having learned about the history behind this arcane film, we have reason to believe that obtaining it was one of her motives.

Deputy Chief Elden: Since the film's been in her possession, there have been multiple assaults around the city, all matching the patterns of the Nightpiercer.

Deputy Chief Elden: But there's one key difference. This time, the victims all showed the same mental disorder as the victims of the film.

Deputy Chief Elden: We believe that the suspect is able to control the film's power to some extent, and she's using it to commit escalating crimes at a much higher frequency.

Deputy Chief Elden: We need to act before the situation gets out of control.

Deputy Chief Elden: Reinforcements from the Foundation and the Vigiles Bureau are already on the way. We will do whatever we can to protect our city before they arrive.

He pauses for a moment as he sweeps his gaze over the officers before him.

Deputy Chief Elden: James, Carter, I'm putting you on the case. You'll be taking direct orders from me. The rest of you stick to your posts.

Liang Yue: Excuse me, Deputy Chief Elden. I need to ask you something.

Deputy Chief Elden: I already know what it is.

Before Liáng can speak, Elden cuts her off. His tone is calmer than she expected.

Deputy Chief Elden: You and Poitier saw that something was going on in Chinatown and started an investigation yourselves.

Deputy Chief Elden: You found the culprit behind the ACD theft and stopped an assault that could've ended much worse.

Deputy Chief Elden: You've done a great job.

But then his tone shifts.

Deputy Chief Elden: But there's one key thing you failed to do. You had a chance to apprehend the Nightpiercer right then and there, but somehow she slipped through your fingers.

Deputy Chief Elden: According to your report and the witnesses' statements, you failed to summon your legendary beast when you confronted the suspect.

Deputy Chief Elden: As a result, not only did the suspect get away, but your partner sustained an avoidable injury. I need my best, most reliable officers on this case.

After a brief pause, he delivers his final verdict.

Deputy Chief Elden: Sorry, Liáng, but you don't make the cut. The two of you will be excluded from the operation.

Poitier: This is bulls**t! He can't cut us out. This is our case!

Poitier: No. We're doing this.

Loggerhead: Calm down, Ms. Po ... Ms. Potty! Even if you feel fine, the doctor said you had to stay in bed for at least a few days.

Poitier: The name's Poitier. And I'm fine, okay? Stop trying to—

Poitier: *cough*

Facts speak louder than words. Liáng gently leads Poitier back down onto the bed. This time, Poitier doesn't resist.

Poitier: Damn it. So what went wrong? How come your friend, Tángláng, was it?—didn't show up?

Liang Yue: Qiángliáng must've sensed my hesitation and refused my summon. You see, if its master can't overcome their selfish desires with an unwavering heart, it can turn on them. Father used to warn me about it.

Liang Yue: But that won't happen again, I promise.

Poitier narrows her eyes as she studies Liáng for a moment.

Poitier: Heh heh. If you say so, what're you gonna do now?

Liáng takes a deep breath.

Liang Yue: I'll continue with the investigation. I need to find Qí Xīng.

Loggerhead: What? But that angry grandpa already pulled you off the case.

Liang Yue: I have to do this.

Poitier: What for? Because of your duty to fight evil as the master of Qiángliáng?

Poitier furrows her brow. But to her surprise, Liáng shakes her head.

Liang Yue: I've always had two things guiding me: my duty as a member of the Liáng family and the spirit of Co7.

Liang Yue: But now, Qiángliáng has ignored my summon, and Qí Xīng has turned out to be anything but a hero. They were once the beacons of my life, but not anymore.

Liang Yue: This could be a setback, yes, or, it could be an opportunity.

Liang Yue: For the first time in my life, I can think about what I really want without having to consider anything else.

After a brief moment of surprise, Poitier lets out a laugh.

Poitier: You know what, rookie, it always grinds my gears when you talk about your duty and all that stuff.

Poitier: But what you're saying now? I like it.

Liang Yue: Aren't you going to stop me?

Poitier: Why would I? It's our case, isn't it? There's nothing wrong with doing our job.

Poitier: If Elden b**ches about it, just tell him you bumped into the crook when you were strolling around the city.

Liang Yue: Seriously?

Poitier: Yeah. Nothing wrong with that, is there?

Poitier: So what's the game plan, huh? What're you gonna do?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: This scene again? They must've done a dozen takes already, right?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Yeah. I'm no movie expert, but even I can tell the actor's nervous as hell.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Of course, he is. Anyone would be nervous if they knew a wanted criminal could show up at any time and mess you up with arcanum.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Elden tried to keep the details of the case a secret, but that director from Hong Kong told her crew about it as soon as she came back.

The two uniformed figures stand in a narrow alley in Chinatown.

They came to protect the potential target of an attack, Noire, but were politely turned away on the grounds of "disrupting filming." Now, they can only confirm the situation inside the set by peering through the slightly ajar door.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: I mean, I guess they have the right to know, and to run. Half of the extras got the hell out as fast as they could, and look at the other half. They're too nervous to work.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: I know. Hey, that's the Vigiles cadet, isn't it? What's she doing here?

Noire: The officers said you're here to help. Is that right?

Noire: Excellent. We could really use a hand right now. Come, let's get you in costume.

Noire greets her guest with her usual amiable smile.

Having reached an agreement with Liáng to cooperate in an arrest, Noire has not been charged for her illegal trading of the arcane object.

After being released from custody this morning, she immediately returned to filming.

Liang Yue: I'm more than happy to help, but first, I have something important to ask you.

Noire pauses.

Noire: Right to the point this time, I see.

Liang Yue: I don't think there's any need to tiptoe around each other anymore. Could you answer me directly this time?

Liang Yue: What happened between you, Qí Xīng, and Hé Rìjūn, the creator of Reunion of the Three Swallows?

Liang Yue: How did she die? Why do you and Ms. Qí Xīng both want that film? And why is she doing this?

Noire looks at Liáng, her usual smile fading slightly.

Noire: What do you plan to do with my answers?

Liang Yue: To Qí Xīng, I'm probably just another fan.

Liang Yue: But to me, she and her character mean something.

Liang Yue: I need to know why. I have to arrest her and find out the truth.

Liang Yue: Maybe I can still fix things, but, Ms. Noire, I need your help if I'm going to do it.

This time, Liáng says exactly what she's thinking. She holds her breath as she awaits Noire's response.

Noire: You mean, you want to know more about her.

Noire: To peek behind the scenes—learn what really happened behind all the movie magic. I told you it's not a good idea.

Noire: We create works not just to express ourselves, but to entertain. And when we release them to the public, we open ourselves to all kinds of commentary, whether they be sweet or bitter.

Noire: But the people behind the characters, behind the production, they are not for entertainment. Their lives are not fiction.

Liang Yue: Is that a no?

Noire: I haven't finished.

She raises an eyebrow, a hint of mischief growing behind her smile.

Noire: Though I don't advocate trying to cross the line between on and off screen, if we cast aside your relationship as fan and actress and treat you simply as individuals ...

Noire: Saying "I want to know more about you" sounds rather beautiful. It's touching, really.

Noire: I'll answer your questions, Ms. Liáng. Follow me.

L.A. Efficiency

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.

And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Guidelines from the Vigiles Bureau on Recent Arcane Violence

Based on the latest Vigiles Bureau guidelines on recent arcanum-related violence, modifications and updates have been made to warrants and relayed to enforcement departments.

Details are as follows:

Wanted: Qi Xing, code name "Nightpiercer."
Threat level raised to "A."
Last seen in Los Angeles and surrounding areas. Any local institutions encountering this individual must notify the Vigiles Bureau immediately.

Wanted: Arcana, leader of Manus Vindictae.
Threat level: Maximum.
Any arcanist who encounters this individual must avoid engagement and immediately report to the Foundation and request military assistance.
(Revoked, confirmed deceased)

Wanted: Kimberly, "Ms. Kimberly."
Threat level: B.
Capture and detain upon encounter, then await Vigiles Bureau support.
(Revoked)

Wanted: Forget Me Not, officer of Manus Vindictae.
Threat level: A+.
Capture and detain upon encounter, then immediately contact the Vigiles Bureau for support. Additionally, submit a report to the local Foundation office when reporting to the Bureau.

Before the Spotlight

SC-16

Noire: Our story began 11 years ago. Life was tough, as it is for all young artists.

Noire: But, like the beginning of many stories, there was a kind of beauty in it.

Guangfu Restaurant

Noire: "Another New Wave director has made a splash with her debut movie. Nitwit boasts an excellent foundation, but it may have reached a little too far with its bizarre and unconventional story ..."

Noire: "While some have praised its daring approach, it has proven too much for the general audience to appreciate, leading to a disappointing box office performance and living up to its title, Nitwit."

Noire: Hah, what can I say? They've got no taste.

She casually tosses the newspaper onto the table, the loud thud drawing surprised glances from the nearby diners.

Noire: Okay. I guess compromise is inevitable if I want to sell more tickets, but that's not exactly my strong suit.

???: Noire? Is that you?

He Rijun: What a surprise! It's so good to see you again.

Noire: Teresa?! What are you doing here? When did you come back to Hong Kong?

Noire: Teresa, or as you know her by, Hé Rìjūn ...

Noire: ... was a dear friend of mine, the scriptwriter of Detective C07, and the creator of the cursed film—Reunion of the Three Swallows.

Noire: Hmm. This is a pretty good script. Interesting.

Noire: Teresa and I met while we were studying abroad at a film academy. We took the same scriptwriting class.

Noire: We didn't talk much at first. She always sat in the corner on her own.

Noire: I only got to know her after our teacher showed a script to the class as an example of excellent work.

Noire: The writer's name: Teresa.

Noire: Her stories could strike a balance between the details and the big picture. They were engaging, lighthearted, and warm.

Noire: So, in that moment, when we met again at the restaurant, I realized she was the one I'd been looking for.

Noire: At that time, she was an editor at a small press. I invited her to join my studio, and three months later, she put the first edition of Detective C07 on my table.

He Rijun: So? What do you think? Just tell me if you want to change anything. I can—

Noire: I'm thinking about who should play the heroine.

He Rijun: Hmm?

Noire: Your script is remarkable—even better than I expected. Let's shoot it.

Noire: So we had the script, but we couldn't decide who would play the heroine. We held endless auditions, even considered some famous actresses, but none of them fit.

Noire: Until that night.

He Rijun: What did you think of today's candidates? The last one seems okay to me.

Noire: No. She's missing that edge. You can see it too, right?

Noire: We're not making lemonade from lemons. At least I'm not.

He Rijun: But what if she doesn't even exist? What if our perfect actress only lives in our imaginations?

Noire: Then we'll keep looking until she's born.

Hooligan I: Agh!

Hooligan II: Y-You—What're you doing?

???: I'm kicking your ass. Got a problem with that, perverts?

???: F**k off!

Hooligan I: J-Just you wait! We'll come back! You'll see!

After throwing out a few uninspired threats, the hooligans flee in disgrace. Behind the door, a worried face peeks out.

Restaurant Owner: You really shouldn't have done that. Those guys live in the neighborhood. They won't just let you off the hook after this.

Restaurant Owner: I know you just wanted to help that girl, but she didn't say anything. Why did you have to make such a scene? What if they come back and tear up the restaurant?

Restaurant Owner: *sigh* You've gotten me into big trouble, Ā Xīng.

Qi Xing: Don't worry, boss. I'll quit. If they come again, tell them to come find me.

Qi Xing: Here's my key. Remember to open early. Your regulars don't like to wait.

Restaurant Owner: Ā Xīng, what are you ... *sigh*

The restaurant owner resigns to taking the key in silence. Without a backward glance, the girl steps down from the door—only to be quickly stopped.

Noire: Looks like you just lost your job.

Qi Xing: Yeah, and what's it to you? What do you want?

Noire: To offer you a new one. Are you interested in acting?

Noire: Ā Xīng was surprised when I made the offer. She said she needed to think about it, so Teresa gave her a copy of the script.

Noire: The next day, she knocked on our door and took the offer.

Noire: Later, we learned that Ā Xīng was born into a poor family. Her father was in prison, and her mother had mental issues. She'd been the breadwinner for the family since she was a kid.

Noire: Her father's reputation would often get her into trouble. So, usually, she was either on the way to a job or to a fight.

As memories surface, Noire lets out a sentimental smile.

Noire: The C07 you saw always had a confident smile on her face, but in actual fact, Ā Xīng almost never smiled at the beginning.

Noire: An actor should learn to commit to the moment in front of the camera and come back to reality behind it. But Ā Xīng didn't.

Noire: She didn't come back to reality. She's never once stopped playing the role of C07 since then, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

Noire: She started to smile the way Co7 smiled. She went from brash and reckless to sly and methodical—just like Co7.

Noire: The Deputy Chief and the BAU made a mistake. Ā Xīng has not confused herself with her character.

Noire: After all these years in the movie industry, I've seen a lot of actors get carried away by the glitz and glamor of their characters.

Noire: But Ā Xīng is different. She values Co7 even more than herself.

Noire: So much so that, ultimately, it eclipsed her own consciousness.

Noire: Ms. Liáng, you asked me which rumors about Co7 and the three of us were true. Now I can give you an answer.

Noire: Most of them were.

Noire maneuvers her wheelchair to the desk, pulls out a file from the bottom drawer, and hands it to Liáng.

The file is heavy. Liáng opens it up to find an aged photograph.

Liang Yue: Is this ...?

Three women pose together. Their identities are obvious.

Noire: We drew a lot of attention after the release of Co7. Put a magnifying glass up to anyone, and you'll always find imperfections. We were no exception.

Noire: Ā Xīng was as stubborn and uncompromising as I was. When we disagreed, it would blow up into a huge argument, neither one of us giving in to the other. Poor Teresa was always caught in the middle.

Noire: I was too young, too bullheaded, to realize the consequences that this might cause. I tore a path forward, often ignoring the people around me.

Noire: Teresa, on the other hand, was kindhearted, perhaps too much so. She never got angry, no matter what people said. She just bottled it up inside and let it eat away at her.

Noire gazes at the smiling faces in the photo, her expression tinged with nostalgia and the faintest hint of sorrow.

Noire: She didn't like taking photos. She was self-conscious about her appearance, so we only have a few together.

Noire: This one was taken when we were shooting Co7 II. We were so close back then. Of course, we knew we'd have to part ways eventually, but we didn't concern ourselves with that.

Noire: Even then, our shortcomings had started to hurt our relationship. But by the time we realized it, the damage had been done.

Qi Xing: No! This ending makes no sense. Co7 would never do that.

Noire: When we were making Co7 III, Ā Xīng was up in arms about the ending.

Noire: In the sequence, Co7 tracks a criminal through a Shèhuǒ Parade, hoping to finish him off herself. But when she finds him sitting at home with his family, she changes her mind.

Noire: Ā Xīng didn't like it.

Noire: She said that Co7 would punish the villain for what he's done, that she would never change her mind. We had countless arguments over this ending, and, of course, we never reached a conclusion.

Noire: Alright, alright! Enough! We're not getting anywhere with this.

Noire: I have an idea.

Noire: So I cheated.

Noire: Were I in the same position now, I'd solve the problem more delicately.

Noire: But I was a jerk back then. The only thing that mattered was the movie. I couldn't care less about what people thought, including my heroine.

Noire: I asked Teresa to write an alternative ending and told Ā Xīng that we'd shoot both endings and pick the better one together.

Noire: She agreed.

Liang Yue: But you didn't keep your word. You released the movie with the original ending.

Noire: It turned out to be very popular, but Ā Xīng saw it as a betrayal. At the premiere, she announced she was quitting the New Art Company that the three of us had founded together.

Noire: I didn't stop her.

Noire: Teresa tried to mend our relationship, like she always did.

He Rijun: I wrote a new story, not for C07—a completely new one. If you're interested, maybe we can use it for our next movie.

He Rijun: I made a sizzle reel. It's pretty short, probably not as good as the ones we usually make, but shall we watch it together?

Noire: It was her proof of concept for Reunion of the Three Swallows.

Noire: I knew Teresa had always wanted to put an end to the C07 series and write something she was really passionate about.

Noire: Perhaps she thought a new story would help Ā Xīng move away from C07 and become herself again.

Noire: Unfortunately, when she came to show us the script, Ā Xīng and I were in the middle of a fight.

Qi Xing: No! I'm not acting in any more of your movies.

He Rijun: Ā Xīng, wait! Ugh!

Noire: Ā Xīng had always been kind to Teresa, but on that day, she pushed her out of the doorway and stormed off.

Noire: While I ... Well, as I said, I was a jerk. I flipped through her script, and a flurry of harsh words left my mouth.

Noire: Really? This type of story again?

Noire: I told you this isn't your strong suit.

He Rijun: ...!

The script, along with the reel, is shoved back into Hé Rìjūn's hands without a second glance.

Noire: In the end, neither Ā Xīng nor I cared enough to watch Teresa's sizzle reel, even though she tried so hard to present it to us.

Noire: That was the last time we saw Teresa.

Liang Yue: That fire ...

Noire: Yes. That's why I'd pay any price to get that film.

Noire: Her script was burned to ashes in the fire. I need to know what story she was trying to tell.

Noire: I suppose Ā Xīng feels the same.

Noire gestures toward the file.

Noire: This is what you wanted to see last time you and your officer friend visited me.

Liang Yue: You mean the threatening letter?

Noire: It's not a letter, actually.

Liáng sets down the photo and pulls out the remaining contents of the file. It's an aged script, its cover yellowed by time.

As she flips through, familiar lines of dialogue meet her eyes. In an instant, she understands the significance of what she's holding.

Liang Yue: It's the script of Detective C07 I.

Noire: The original—the one Teresa handed to Ā Xīng all those years ago.

Liang Yue: ...

Liáng never imagined that, one day, she would be holding the origin of the very film that inspired her as a child.

There is no doubt. Qí Xīng must have returned it to Noire. But why? What does this mean?

She continues to flip through until her fingers meet an object tucked between the pages.

Liang Yue: Is this a poster of the Shèhuǒ Parade?

Liang Yue: Oh, right. It's almost time for the Dùshuò Festival. With everything going on these days, I almost forgot.

Liáng's expression suddenly shifts.

Liang Yue: Wait. Is Ms. Qí Xīng going to ...?

Noire: Your guess is as good as mine.

They exchange a glance, then both turn their gaze to the image of the Shèhuǒ Parade printed on the poster in front of them.

The Joy of Dushuo

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.

And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Chinese TV News Segment: Shehuo Parade

Our reporter brings you an exclusive frontline update:

"As the Dushuo Festival begins, Los Angeles's Chinatown is once again alive with the excitement of the Shehuo Parade. Humans and arcanists will soon come together to pray for a year of peace and prosperity."

"We are currently at the Chinatown Community Center, which houses 12 sacred arcane idols, marking the starting point of the parade."

"We're fortunate to be interviewing Principal Huang, who is this year's 'Summoning Official.' Principal Huang, could you tell us about your role in the festival?"

"Ah, the summoning official is responsible for reciting the summoning rites and inviting the idols. After lunch, the rotating God of Shèti, 'Xieqia,' will be placed on the palanquin. Some of the parade members have already gathered outside."

"That's right, we can see people carrying lanterns and flags preparing for the parade. Principal Huang, what's that large animal lantern over there?"

"That's a Lùshǔ, a Xiángruì. Later, it will join the Beast Lantern Team. The parade will be led by the Five-Colored Banners and the Yingge Troupe, followed by the Xiandao Beasts and Xiángruì creatures—quite the spectacle!"

"The Xiandao Beasts, are those the legendary creatures said to ward off evil plagues?"

"Exactly. During the 'Plague-Banishing' segment, General Qianmo will shout the command, and three young men wearing Xiandao Beast masks will sing the Plague-Banishing Song, imitating the beasts to drive out evil."

"The musicians will accompany them with gongs and drums. The parade will go on until late at night—quite the festivity!"

"Thank you, Principal Huang. Though the parade has yet to start, we can see crowds waiting already. Stay tuned as we bring you live coverage of the Shehuo Parade."

Watchers, Protectors, Defenders

SC-17

Enraged Man: Wow, look at all these people! We should've come earlier. I can hardly see a thing from here.

Woman: And whose fault is that? You're the one who took ages to get ready. Anyway, at least we haven't missed much. Looks like it just started.

Woman: I heard there's a new event this year. I wonder what it is.

Enraged Man: Not an event. A film crew's shooting a scene during the parade. Apparently, they already talked to Mr. Zhōu and said they wouldn't cause any trouble.

Enraged Man: Let's go check it out. Maybe we can get into one of the shots.

This is the busiest time of year in Chinatown. The streets are filled to the brim.

But for those with keen eyes, some outliers can be spotted among the crowd.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: This is C2. All clear.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Copy. Group C, all clear. No sign of target. All units stay in position.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: I wonder how the vigil girl and Elden are doing.

Having ended the transmission, the officer glances toward a Chinese restaurant at the street corner.

Despite the bustling crowd, the sign on its door reads "CLOSED."

Deputy Chief Elden?: ...

Deputy Chief Elden?: Do I really have to go outside like this?

Deputy Chief Elden stands awkwardly in front of the mirror as he stares at the brightly colored traditional outfit he's adorned in.

The man across from him sneers, shattering his last shred of hope to be saved from it.

Private Investigator: No, you need to paint your face, too. I'm not gonna let you join the parade looking like a weirdo.

Private Investigator: You're the one who said that the parade needed guards in case there was an attack. Have you changed your mind? I'd be more than happy to kick you outta here.

Private Investigator: Sorry, but your profiling and BAU report seemed like a load of crap to me. If someone does attack the parade, I'm sure we can handle it ourselves.

Deputy Chief Elden: Listen, I won't pretend to understand the meaning behind all this. But what I do understand is that this is one of the most important events of the year for the people of Chinatown.

Deputy Chief Elden: The target could strike at any time, so we need to be prepared. No one wants to see a celebration turn into a nightmare.

Private Investigator: Why didn't you say that to your men? They are the ones who've ignored the Chinatown all this time.

Private Investigator: What a hypocrite.

He glares at the officers with clear distrust in his eyes. But before tensions can rise anymore, the girl beside him cuts in with a smile.

An-an Lee: Aiyah, Uncle Zhōu, today's our big day. That sour face of yours is gonna scare these guys straight off.

An-an Lee: Leave the past in the past lah. They are doing this for the right reasons. What've we got to lose?

An-an Lee: Besides, we could really use a hand right now. They can make up for our manpower shortage.

An-an Lee: Now, give me a biiig smile lah, before your long face scares off our good fortune.

Private Investigator: You. Always a sweet talker, aren't you, An-an?

He huffs and glares but eventually waves it off.

Private Investigator: Fine, but you've got to look the part if you're gonna be in the parade. I don't care what your mission is.

Private Investigator: Wai, you, Blondie! Tighten your belt, or your pants will fall down when you dance. And big guy over there! The lining should be under your coat.

The famed Chinatown investigator yells corrections to the officers as they do their best to don the traditional attire. His tone is sharp but surprisingly patient.

Seeing his "old friend" much mellowed from before, Elden removes his garish headpiece and turns to An-an.

Deputy Chief Elden: Thanks for all your help, Ms. Lee.

Deputy Chief Elden: We never would've been able to join the parade unnoticed if you hadn't persuaded the residents to cooperate with us.

An-an Lee: You're welcome lah, Ā sir.

An-an Lee: Even though I only came here a few months ago, I've already gotten pretty close to the residents, so it was pretty easy to convince everyone. Don't worry about it lah.

An-an Lee: Besides, the Shèhuǒ Parade is for everyone. Whether they are here to watch or dance, we are always happy to have more people join the celebration.

An-an Lee: Uncle Zhōu might be a little stubborn, but, you know gah-lah, that's just what he's like. Don't take it personally.

She turns her head, gesturing toward a few unfamiliar faces at the other end of the restaurant.

An-an Lee: These guys are arcane detectives and influential people around Chinatown. I told them to all keep an eye out too.

An-an Lee: There's a saying in Hong Kong, "As stupid as the God of Longevity who hangs himself!" Hahah! That will be Nightpiercer if she comes anywhere near Chinatown.

Elden nods before gently shaking his head with a complex expression.

Deputy Chief Elden: I know everyone here will be grateful if Nightpiercer doesn't show up, but then we'll still have a dangerous criminal with an equally dangerous arcane item on the loose.

Deputy Chief Elden: Nothing's more dangerous than an unexploded bomb. I want to eliminate the threat once and for all.

Deputy Chief Elden: The question is, will she come? Was the little vigil right?

Late last night, Liáng knocked on Elden's office door. She had returned from her morning rejection with renewed determination.

Liang Yue: The Shèhuǒ Parade, sir.

At that time, the Division of Arcane Affairs was still brightly lit, with most officers racking their brains to track down Qí Xīng without success.

That was when Liáng had stormed in with her "important collaborator," ignoring the puzzled glances from her colleagues, and slammed a thick stack of reports onto his desk.

Liang Yue: Ms. Noire isn't like any of Qí Xīng's previous targets. She's much more important.

Liang Yue: Ms. Qí Xīng still can't accept the way Ms. Noire ended Detective Co7 III. That's her motive.

Liang Yue: The ending consists of two major elements: the Shèhuǒ Parade and a villain who should've been punished.

Liang Yue: She now sees Noire as that villain, and she's going to attack her at the coming Shèhuǒ Parade.

Liang Yue: That will be our chance to arrest her.

Deputy Chief Elden: The Shèhuǒ Parade? Do you have any idea what you're suggesting?

The sheer thickness of the report is intimidating. Elden skims through it before casting a questioning look at the unexpected visitor Liáng had dragged in.

The visitor nods.

Noire: Don't worry, sir.

Noire: I'd be happy to cooperate as bait.

Noire: Ā Xīng will come. I promise.

The sound of the back door opening breaks Elden's thoughts. He looks up to see Poitier pushing Noire's wheelchair inside, Loggerhead following closely behind.

Noire: As far as I can remember, she's never been late to anything.

Poitier: Chief, why aren't you dressed up? I've been looking forward to it all day.

Loggerhead: Wow! So many people! I'll make sure I capture some great memories of this.

Noire remains her usual unruffled self, while Poitier teases her colleagues, and Loggerhead eagerly looks around.

Elden sighs and rubs his forehead.

Deputy Chief Elden: I understand that the festival atmosphere is exciting, but you ladies need to remember that we're not here to celebrate. There's a tough fight ahead of us.

Deputy Chief Elden: Poitier, you sure you're healed up?

Poitier: Of course, Chief. You've approved my participation in this operation. It's too late to take it back now.

Elden looks her over. Clearly she's alive and well, but he still carries concern on his face. Eventually, he sighs and nods.

Deputy Chief Elden: What about Ms. Latham?

Deputy Chief Elden: You've been proven innocent, and I heard the Foundation told you to await orders. There's no reason for you to be here.

Elden's words draw everyone's attention to Loggerhead. Her head twitches slightly.

Loggerhead: Yeah, but it'd be weird to stay in my room alone when everyone's out here, don't you think?

Loggerhead: Anyway, I'm waiting for Scott to wake up from her coma. I wanna ask her why she stole from the Foundation and pinned it on me.

Loggerhead: I need to know what she thinks about me and our friendship.

Loggerhead: If I let you guys do all the work while I just wait in my room, I won't be able to question her without feeling insecure.

Loggerhead: I know I might not be all that helpful, but I'll do everything I can.

The camera lens almost seems to flash with something resembling a plea.

Noire: Ms. Latham's being modest.

Noire: As a staff member of the Arcanum Containment Department, she knows how to deal with that film reel better than any of us.

Noire: She may forget things, but she still has a wealth of knowledge. Her experience might just make the difference between failure and success.

Deputy Chief Elden: Alright, you've got a point. Ms. Latham, thanks for lending us your expertise.

Elden finally nods. Loggerhead lights up.

Loggerhead: Great! Just leave it to me. I can deal with the film.

Loggerhead: I've rewatched all my related memories, so I remember every detail, even down to the scratches on its surface.

With Loggerhead officially permitted to join, the final member of the operation team is the last to arrive.

Liang Yue: There you are.

Liang Yue: Everyone was gone when I left the changing room. I thought something was ...

Liang Yue: What's wrong?

An-an Lee: Waaah! The costume fits you so well. Fancy wor. It doesn't even look like a costume. Much fancier than that.

An-an Lee: You're like the best parade dancer I've ever seen. There's no way the Nightpiercer will spot you.

An-an Lee: Look at her, Uncle Zhōu. So cool ah-hor?

The Chinatown investigator scrutinizes Liáng from head to toe before letting out a derisive snort.

Private Investigator: Is that the Liáng's family ritual dress? Let me see. Hmm. Good, you're wearing it right. Nice to know that at least some kids remember their traditions. You better not dishonor your family wearing this, kid.

Deputy Chief Elden: My thoughts exactly.

Deputy Chief Elden: Everything's in place. You sure you can perform this time, vigil? I don't want a repeat of last time.

Deputy Chief Elden: The alley out back's empty. Show us what you've got.

He gestures to the officers, motioning them to line up before Liáng.

Each officer stands tall and imposing, forming what feels like a solid wall before Liáng. Refusing to shy away, she squares her shoulders and meets their gazes head-on.

Liang Yue: Yes, sir. I will prove myself to you.

After several rounds of trials, Liáng remains standing, her expression firm and determined, her gaze burning with resolve. Satisfied, Elden nods.

Deputy Chief Elden: Looks like I've got nothing to worry about. You're ready, kid.

He rolls up his sleeve and checks the time on his watch.

Deputy Chief Elden: Parade's starting soon. I'll go get dressed. The rest of you—

Noire: I need to talk to Ms. Liáng. Could you give us a moment?

Poitier: Don't be late.

Poitier glances at them before following the others back inside.

The alley suddenly feels empty.

Liáng waits quietly for Noire to speak, but she never does. She simply stares at the distant lights, as if the revelry and noise belonged to another world.

Eventually, Liáng can wait no longer.

Liang Yue: Why me, Ms. Noire?

The Law of Causation · 1/2

SC-18

The cheers and laughter of the Shèhuǒ Parade echo through the alley, muffled and distant.

Liang Yue: You could've just told Elden about what happened between the three of you. You could've shown him the threatening letter.

Liang Yue: Maybe then he wouldn't have made the order to shoot the target if necessary. Yes, Ms. Qí Xīng has committed multiple assaults, but she hasn't killed anyone.

Liang Yue: I don't think she deserves to die. So, as I promised, I will do my best to catch her alive.

Liang Yue: That being said, if, and I mean if ...

She takes a deep breath.

Liang Yue: If drastic measures have to be taken, I will not hesitate.

Liáng's final words are anything but polite. She holds her breath as she awaits Noire's response. After a brief silence, Noire speaks.

Noire: Ā Xīng was a good actress.

Liáng anticipated all kinds of responses from Noire, but not this one.

Liang Yue: ...?

Noire: Yes, she was a skilled martial artist with remarkable control over her arcane skill, but that's not what makes a successful actress.

Noire: Before we'd even start shooting, she'd have everything memorized—her lines, her movements, even the details of her expression. She'd take as many shots as were necessary to get the scene right.

Noire: As you know, I was a perfectionist, always taking it too far. Many of my crew quit halfway through my projects.

Noire: Even Teresa struggled sometimes. She told me more than once that she couldn't do it anymore.

Noire: Only Ā Xīng could keep up with my pace. In fact, she'd often be a few steps ahead.

Noire: Because she shared my vision—that drive for something better, no matter the cost.

Noire: She was a good actress indeed.

Noire: I know that we'll probably never be partners again, but I still don't want her to be treated like this.

In Liáng's memories, Noire was always smiling.

Sometimes friendly, sometimes distant, with the mischievousness of a child, or the cunning and unyielding pride of a woman totally in control.

But at this moment, when she turns her head, there is no smile. What burns quietly in her eyes is something akin to rage.

Noire: You said you were going to figure out the truth. Well, it seems you and I agree that things aren't as simple as they appear.

Noire: The Arcanum Containment Department's security system should be almost unbreakable. So how is it that Ms. Scott, a regular staff member with no special skills, managed to break through it?

Noire: And why was she selected to go after Ms. Latham? What was she about to say before that needle pierced her neck?

Noire: Ā Xīng's actions don't make sense either. After all these years, why has she decided to take revenge now? Is it because she found the film?

Noire: There are simply far too many coincidences. If one of my writers wrote a script like this, they'd be fired on the spot.

Liang Yue: You mean there's something else going on behind all this.

Noire gives her a look of approval.

Noire: The scene has been staged. I can feel it.

Noire: The lights, the cameras, the cast, they're all in position, and when the clapperboard claps, the movie will begin.

Noire: And this time, I'm not sitting behind the camera, but in front of it.

Noire: Ms. Liáng, I've been holding back. I apologize for that.

Noire: I hadn't figured out which role you'd play in this movie.

Liang Yue: If you're saying this to try to get me to talk about the "behind the scenes" of my life, I'm afraid you'll be disappointed.

Noire: No, of course not. You got me wrong.

She waves a hand dismissively, her expression light, but her eyes still blazing.

Noire: I'm a director. I don't act in movies made by others.

Noire: Ā Xīng, Ms. Latham, Ms. Scott—the camera's focused on them, too. But none of us know where the story will go.

Something stirs in Liáng's chest.

Liang Yue: You mean, Ms. Qí Xīng's being manipulated?

Liang Yue: I've considered that possibility, but who's the one behind the camera? What do they want?

Noire: All I know is that if Ā Xīng continues down this path, there will be no happy ending for her.

Noire: I understand that she's trying to reach something she's always strived for, but whoever's orchestrating this won't let her get it.

Noire: I've done that to her before, and it was a huge mistake. I won't let that happen again.

Liang Yue: What are you going to do?

Noire smiles.

Noire: Since coming to Hollywood, there's one thing I've found difficult to accept.

Noire: The producers always stick to the script. They're obsessed with it. Changes are incredibly rare.

Noire: But that's not how we do it in Hong Kong. The script's finished? And so what? Things will always come up during shooting. You have to be flexible if you want to make truly great art.

Noire: If a moment of inspiration were to strike me and I weren't allowed to add it to the movie, then you may as well just kill me there.

Liáng takes a moment to understand all this.

Liang Yue: You want to change the script.

Noire: Precisely. But we have a small issue.

Noire gestures to her legs resting on the wheelchair.

Noire: As you can see, I'm not exactly ready to jump to my feet and into the action. I'm better at working behind the camera than I am in front of it.

Noire: So, I need a protagonist.

Noire: One who's as eager as I am to change the script and find that perfect ending. Are you interested?

She reaches a hand out to Liáng.

Liang Yue: It would be an honor.

And Liáng takes it in her own.

Deputy Chief Elden: Attention! Attention, please! Noire will be shooting her movie during the Shèhuǒ Parade as planned.

Deputy Chief Elden: Let's go over the plan one more time. Group A will hide among the cast; group B, cameramen, and group C—you're in the crowd. Once Qí Xīng appears, close in and arrest her as soon as possible.

Private Investigator: Got it. We're all set, too.

Deputy Chief Elden: Good. Everyone, take your positions.

Qi Xing: Alright, Noire. The time has come.

Qi Xing: This will be our final scene.

Tourist: Huh? What's going on? That light's so bright.

Chinatown Resident: Woah. I'm feeling kinda dizzy.

Child: Mommy, I-I'm scared.

Liang Yue: That arcane fluctuation—it's from Reunion of the Three Swallows.

Liang Yue: But, how did she ...?

Truthful Exchange

小径

So, things went sideways. That's what happens when you put guns in the hands of amateurs.

But you handled the water better this time. You controlled your breathing, kept your airways clear, and this time you remembered to lie back and float.

Choices

1. Who are you?

Does it matter? I'm all you've got. We're at war—bullets flying, wounds festering, typhoid, cholera, and all the worst of it. It's a living hell, and only fools think there's any honor in it.

You never expect to see a familiar face again, not in times like these.

Now I need you to listen. There's something you should know.

Choices

1. What things?

The raid on the river was a ploy, and its mastermind is an old acquaintance. As for the ones who carried it out—you already heard about them this morning.

They promised their followers they'd push south, and they did. With their supplies secured by a mysterious third party, they paraded through every town along the way, playing as "liberators" and taking out anyone they decided were their enemies.

They swelled in numbers, larger than any local gang or cult had ever gotten before.

Now they swarm across the land like a school of red-bellied piranhas. Always hungry, ready to tear apart anything that crosses their path.

Choices

1. What happened to the others?

Chances are they're doing fine, just like you.

Would've been nice if you caught what that little executioner and that "gold-hearted" gambler were talking about during their dice game. Guess you'll have to ask her later.

Choices

1. Why don't *you* tell me instead?

Listen, I'm not here to run your errands or play your messenger boy, so ask nicely.

There's nothing more I need to tell you. For now.

Excerpt from the New York Times

> Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
> The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.
>
> The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
> On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.
>
> Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

The Law of Causation · 2/2

SC-18

The lights on either side of the street blur, polluting the night sky, turning it into a swirling mess.

It's as if everything in sight has been tossed onto a painter's palette and smeared and blended. All definitions have been lost.

Chinatown Resident: What's happening?

Tourist: I-Is this part of the parade? How'd they do that?

???: #$%&*(@!

Chinatown Resident: Whoa, wait, what's this?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Stand back!

A young officer rushes forward, positioning herself between the unknown monster and the Chinatown residents.

An-an Lee: Officer, head down!

???: #$%&*(@!!!

An-an Lee: Ha! Easy.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Phew. Thank you. They teach you that in Hong Kong?

Private Investigator: That thing's nothing like the critters you're used to dealing with. What were you thinking rushing in like that?

Private Investigator: Hmph! You're totally out of your league.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: It was about to attack. What else was I supposed to do?

Private Investigator: *tut*

He swallows whatever snarky remark he had planned, instead looking around at the eerie figures shifting in the shadows.

Private Investigator: They look like ghosts, but there's something different about them.

Private Investigator: So, little ghost hunter, can that machine of yours tell us what they are?

An-an Lee: One second, Uncle Zhōu. Lily's working on it.

Under the bewildered gazes of the officers, the young ghost hunter's human-headed lily lets out a chilling, eerie laugh.

An-an's expression changes.

An-an Lee: What?! You mean, that was a living man's soul?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Just got confirmation that this thing's covering the whole of Chinatown. Comms are down, and we can't seem to leave either.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Arcane humanoids spotted in all directions. Don't seem to be critters or the Beyond. Must be some kind of arcane creation.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: They're everywhere and immune to regular bullets. Arcane skills and specialized bullets break them apart for a while, but then their bodies just morph back together.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: No casualties so far, but people are panicking. What do we do, Chief?

???: #$%&*(@!

Deputy Chief Elden: Sorry, not my type.

The specialized bullets successfully repel the shadowy beings, but their supply is limited. Elden has to fall back, yelling into his chameleon comm as he does so.

Deputy Chief Elden: Everyone, keep calm. Groups A and C, protecting the public is your top priority. These things seem to follow anything that moves. Lure them away.

Deputy Chief Elden: Ms. Lee, Mr. Zhōu. Gather as many civilians as you can and guide them to a safe place.

He expected the private investigator to fire back with his usual sarcasm, but to his surprise, his response is immediate and to the point.

Private Investigator: No problem. They know us. I'm sure we'll be able to calm them down.

Private Investigator: I'll tell them they're special effects. They all know that a movie was being shot here. That should help. At least long enough to get them to safety.

Private Investigator: That means you guys are gonna have to figure this out yourselves. Show me what you've got, Arcane Affairs.

Deputy Chief Elden: We won't let you down.

He takes another deep breath, filling his body with renewed strength.

Deputy Chief Elden: Group B, hold your positions. Target's probably trying to distract us with these monsters. What's your status? Report immediately.

Poitier: This is Poitier. Same thing's happening at the rear of the parade. Noire's fine though.

Deputy Chief Elden: Keep it that way. The rest of you, keep your eyes peeled. The target could appear at any time.

Deputy Chief Elden: Camera-head, any idea what's going on?

The Arcanum Containment Department employee is the person most likely to understand the current anomaly.

Loggerhead: I think Chinatown's been sealed inside an arcane barrier created by the film.

Loggerhead: There's nothing in the records about this, but these arcane fluctuations are definitely from the film.

Deputy Chief Elden: What about those ghost things? I don't remember the file saying it could spawn spirits out of thin air.

Loggerhead: Well, I don't know. Reunion of the Three Swallows can play and record, that's for sure.

Loggerhead: But even if its power has been enhanced somehow, it probably wouldn't develop a completely unrelated ability.

An-an Lee: You're right, because it's not unrelated.

An-an's voice crackles through the communicator. Even the usually carefree ghost hunter sounds a little tense.

An-an Lee: Remember the film's victims? Part of them was taken away by its record ability.

An-an Lee: What they lost was part of their spiritual energy and memories—their Saam Wan Chat Paak, or "three souls and seven spirits."

An-an Lee: These monsters are actually the Saam Wan Chat Paak of the victims.

Loggerhead: They're the victims' spiritual energy? But how did the film do that?

The chilling appearance of the phantoms makes it difficult to connect them with what An-an has declared them to be.

An-an Lee: Hmm. I'm not sure, but Lily's never wrong. So let's not try to eliminate these things.

An-an Lee: Or the victims will never get their Saam Wan Chat Paak back.

An-an's voice, transmitted through the DAA communicator, reaches Liáng's ears.

Liang Yue: Essentially, she's holding everyone in Chinatown hostage.

Liang Yue: We certainly weren't expecting that.

Liáng looks at the figure standing just a few meters ahead.

The frightened crowd clings to their family and friends, frantic and scared.

And those who are alone gather with others near the dim glow of the shopfronts in search of any semblance of warmth and reassurance.

They have no way of knowing that the one responsible for all this is standing just a few steps away.

Qi Xing: I didn't want it to come to this.

Qi Xing: This was between me and Noire. But you just couldn't leave it alone, could you? So here we are.

Qi Xing: Sounds like you already know what this film reel is capable of. Good. Saves me the trouble of explaining it.

Qi Xing: Now, bring me Noire.

False Dilemma · 1/2

SC-19

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Target spotted. I repeat, target spotted.

Within moments of the plainclothes officer's words, the arriving police evacuate the crowd and seal off the street.

The officers form an impenetrable barrier, trapping both the target and Liáng inside. They stand in a face-off.

Chinatown Resident: What's going on? Who are they?

The bystanders erupt into fervent speculation. Deputy Chief Elden steps into the containment zone.

Deputy Chief Elden: Impressive, Nightpiercer. This is a whole new level, even for you.

Deputy Chief Elden: Tell me, what did you pull to take control of that film reel?

Qi Xing: I didn't pull anything, officer.

Qi Xing: It chose to fulfill my wish. That's all.

Liang Yue: Urgh ...

Without warning, an excruciatingly sharp noise tears through her skull, sending waves of vertigo crashing over her.

For several agonizing seconds, she can hear nothing but the distant groans of the officers and bystanders suffering alongside her. It's a fight just to stay upright.

When the assault on her senses finally subsides, the first thing she registers is a voice coming from her communicator.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Chief! Something bad's happening.

The urgency in the officer's voice sets Liáng's nerves on edge, but then her tone shifts.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Wait, maybe it's good.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Those things! Th-They've stopped moving. They're not attacking anymore.

Deputy Chief Elden: You kidding?

Liáng and Elden exchange a puzzled glance before scanning their surroundings. The shifting shadows have indeed stopped moving, and the reason is obvious.

Their wary gazes turn to their target. She's standing calmly in the middle of the street, unfazed by the array of loaded firearms aimed directly at her.

Qi Xing: I never wanted to get innocent people involved. As I said before, this is between me and Noire. Now, may I see my dear old friend?

Qi Xing: Heh, if you're worried about her safety, the little vigil can tag along.

Liáng and Elden exchange a look.

Deputy Chief Elden: It's too dangerous.

Deputy Chief Elden: We've already put Noire at considerable risk, but pushing her right into the hands of a criminal? I don't think so.

Deputy Chief Elden: We can't put a civilian in danger like that. Besides, why would Qí Xīng let you go with her? You're walking right into a trap.

Noire: Trap or not, I'm afraid we don't have much choice.

Her voice isn't loud, but in this high-tension standoff, its slow and measured cadence feels completely out of place.

Poitier pushes Noire's wheelchair forward, placing her squarely in the spotlight.

Deputy Chief Elden: Poitier? What are you doing? I told you to hold position.

Noire raises a hand, smiling as she cuts off Elden's rising fury.

Noire: Please don't blame Officer Poitier, sir. I forced her to bring me here.

Deputy Chief Elden: What? What the hell are you thinking?

Noire: It's time I put an end to all of this.

Noire: No need to worry, officer. Our reliable vigil will keep me safe, isn't that right?

Liang Yue: Yes, of course. I will ensure Ms. Noire's safety, Chief. Leave it to me.

Elden studies Liáng's face for a moment before shifting his gaze to Qí Xīng. At last, he relents.

Deputy Chief Elden: Keep the target in check, Liáng.

Keeping his eyes on the target, he leans in close to Liáng's ear and issues a low warning.

Deputy Chief Elden: James and the others are working on how to break this barrier we're in. Camera-head and that ghost hunter are helping them.

Deputy Chief Elden: Stay calm. We want to resolve this peacefully, if possible. Haven't forgotten what you learned in negotiation class, have you?

Liang Yue: Of course not, sir. I got straight A's.

Poitier takes Liáng's other side and rests a firm hand on her shoulder.

Poitier: Guard up, rookie, and straighten your back.

Poitier: I get why you wanna wear this outfit, but you can get things done with or without it. Isn't that right, partner?

Liang Yue: Right, ma'am. I won't fail.

Before pulling away, Poitier gives Liáng her usual rough pat on the back, but somehow, it causes Liáng's stiffness to melt away.

Taking a steadying breath, she moves to Noire's side.

Liang Yue: Let's go, director. Time for the final scene.

Accompanied by Liáng, Noire wheels into the distorted world before them.

It's as if a surreal nightmare is unfolding before their eyes.

Qi Xing: Look around you, Noire. Look at what we've done.

Qí Xīng's gaze wanders over the bleeding lights and flickering shadows around her as she scrutinizes the cracks and distortions in this twisted realm unleashed by the cursed film reel.

But her expression holds no trace of admiration.

Qi Xing: This is what her film, the very last work of our dearest friend, looks like now—tainted, twisted, and wicked.

Qi Xing: All this is proof of our guilt—the blood on our hands.

Noire: So, what are you going to do about it?

Noire: Teresa's never coming back.

Noire: She's dead.

Noire doesn't shy away from the word. Though a note of sorrow lingers in her tone, she says it with a certain cold detachment.

Noire: And you, playing hero, punishing those you deem evil. Does that make you feel better? You kill me, and then, what, kill yourself?

Noire: That's how you'll atone for your failures? Forgive my bluntness, but how laughably naive you are.

Noire's voice has an uncharacteristic sharpness to it, but Qí Xīng shows no sign of wavering under her scrutiny.

Instead, she smiles.

Qi Xing: Atone for my failures? Heh, you're way off.

Qi Xing: You're right about one thing, though. She is gone. The person who cared for me more than anyone in the world ... dead.

Qi Xing: When she gave me a shoulder to lean on, I pushed her away. I left her to die alone and in pain. How could I ever atone for that?

Qi Xing: How could I ever expect her to forgive me? How selfish of me to even ask for that.

Liáng furrows her brow in suspicion.

Liang Yue: Then why can't you let it go?

Liang Yue: C07 is the hero who brings a happy ending, no matter what she's faced with. What you're doing now is anything but that.

Qi Xing: "The hero who brings a happy ending, no matter what she's faced with." That's what I said in the behind-the-scenes interview of C07 II. I'm surprised you even remember that.

After a brief pause, she smiles again.

Qi Xing: But there'll be no happy ending for me.

Qi Xing: You probably heard that, after she died, I starred in a few movies with other directors.

Qi Xing: But they all went south, not because they weren't commercially successful or popular, but because I couldn't shake that feeling of disgust. I'd never felt that playing C07.

Qi Xing: The cameras, the boom mics, the spotlights—the sight of them made me want to throw up, scream, do anything to run away from it all.

Qi Xing: Eventually, I retired from acting. But that sense of disgust never left me. It haunted me wherever I went, whatever I did.

Qi Xing: I kept asking myself, "Why is this happening to me?" "Why can't I just act?" "Why?!"

Qi Xing: Day and night, I wrestled with these questions. Until, one day, I found the answer.

Her gaze burns with intensity, and yet, it carries a bone-chilling coldness. It is fixed firmly upon Noire.

Qi Xing: It all began with a dire mistake, one that needs to be corrected.

Silver needles streak through the air in a sudden downpour.

Liang Yue: Ms. Noire, get back!

Inside the Film

小径

Let's rewind the time to a few years ago.

Choices

1. Why a few years ago?

2. I want to move to the future.

Branch 1

It's for your own good. Lying in front of you is a girl full of mysteries. She makes your mind spin like a top. You scratch your ears, trying to understand what happened exactly.

And all these damn things can be traced back to a long, long time ago, when the monkeys decided to stand on their feet ...

Branch 2

Awesome! Your lofty ambition that a boxer would have is exactly what we need. But unfortunately, I can't take you to the future. Oops, I could, but now I can't.

Now, another person is going to do this. But before we solve this big mystery, I think it's necessary for us to sort out the principal contradiction—

Trust me, you won't regret listening to this story.

Choices

1. Fine. Let's start the bullshit.

2. No. I'm tired of you.

Branch 2.1

I will never be offended by your humor. Okay. The past is waiting for us to look back.

It's winter in the early 20th century. The gloomy rain never stops. The square on West Jackson Avenue is alive with people. There is an Italian Renaissance-styled basilica. You rarely see so many people get together without making a sound.

This is a black requiem mass. The priest is chanting the requiem, and the people mark a cross on their chests.

Choices

1. He must be respectable.

2. He might be powerful.

Branch 2.1.1

"He was a father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace." A woman in a black robe turns to you and whispers.

Branch 2.1.2

"What is power?" A solemn lady shakes her head at you, "Only Lord can forgive us for our sins and judge the right and the wrong, but he does not want power."

"Neither does the father." "He was our father. He dedicated to a sinner of ... Lord shall give him eternal peace."

She turns back. Explaining this makes her unpleased. More and more people are queuing for the funeral. The square is alive with chants here and there.

The Grecos are among them. They're covered by the dark cloud of long-handled umbrellas. Soon, their voices are replaced by whimpers. You can hardly tell whether they are pleased or sorrowful. But you can't find Schneider.

Choices

1. Where is she?

Look in the direction of Mr. Greco's broken left palm. Yes. Look from the bandage-wrapped end at his cuff.

3390 feet away from the crowd, in the shadow of the church, stands the girl you want to see.

She is pale and thin, as if she has just recovered from a serious, long illness.

But her fist clenches, her eyes burn, and her figure is an open defiance of the ubiquitous chants. You don't know why she looks so—so furious. Is she ... what, 11 years old?

And the mass is about to usher in the ultimate climax. It rains heavier. The priest opens his arms to embrace the sky, "The Lord be with you."

"And also with you." Schneider responds in a voice that could hardly be heard. She puts her hand on her heart. This is the first time she responds to the Lord. And it will be the last.

Shared continuation

Branch 2.2

But I will never be tired of you, baby.

I respect your decision. When you're ready for a story, go find your friends. They will tell you exactly what happened.

... While I will wait for you at the next destination, humbly and patiently.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Within the Film Reel: A New Born Consciousness

Reel 1 – Scene 24 – Shot 9 – Take 3

Writer – He Rijun

Scene Description: An old house contested by sworn sisters is reduced to ruins in a fire. Covered in ash, the three lie amidst the rubble, drinking beer bought from a convenience store, and gazing out at the sunrise.

...

I must finish this film ... The film must be finished. Only then can I be whole.

...

Added Scene: An old woman drops her cane, crying tears of joy: "I'm cured! My family won't need to spend money anymore!" A classic technique—blending social issues with sentimentality.

...

Added Scene: A man kneels, crying out: "I'll kill that con artist! I'll avenge my mom!" A perfect emotional outburst for the film's midpoint.

...

Added Scene: A woman paces in her room after watching the film's teaser. She mutters, "This isn't your usual work. The reel has absorbed your hatred—it reeks of malice ... I'm not like the others, I believe sinners must be punished. This time, I'll ensure your film has a perfect ending. Purging sin with death? That's perfect—just right for the finale."

False Dilemma · 2/2

SC-19

Arcane Affairs Officer: Ammo's running low, sir.

Deputy Chief Elden: They must be gaining power from this barrier we're in.

Qi Xing: I hate you, Noire.

Qi Xing: You were born with a silver spoon and exceptional talent. You took everything for granted. You looked down on everyone else.

Qi Xing: I've always hated you.

Liang Yue: Ms. Noire, hold on!

Noire: That was close.

Liang Yue: Ms. Qí Xīng, is this really what you want to do? Are you really going to kill Ms. Noire?

Liang Yue: You have to stop. This is completely meaningless.

Qi Xing: Hah. Meaningless? No, this is exactly what needs to happen. Every story must have an ending, after all.

Qi Xing: The past has held me prisoner for far too long.

Qi Xing: I need an ending, a conclusion, so I can finally leave it behind me. Only then ...

Qi Xing: ... can I reach my perfect grand finale.

Qi Xing: Qiángliáng?

Qi Xing: Impossible! You didn't chant the incantation.

Liang Yue: This time, I won't hesitate.

Liang Yue: You were my inspiration, Ms. Qí Xīng. Like the countless kids who were once lost, I found myself in C07.

Liang Yue: And that's exactly why I have to stop you.

Liang Yue: Arise Qiángliáng, swift and fierce! Banish all evil and cleanse this place!

Qi Xing: ...!

Until the Light Fades

SC-20

A brilliant flash splits the darkened sky in two, and a thunderous roar scatters the shadows. All fear and unease are forgotten in an instant.

Every head turns to the place where the lightning struck to see a colossal beast standing in solemn majesty. The crowd falls silent. Then, a single young voice cries out.

Child: Mommy, look, it's Qiángliáng!

The child raises a lantern excitedly.

Child: It's just like the painting on my lantern.

The paper-crafted beast bears little resemblance to the mighty guardian towering in the distance.

Yet something in its stern, round-eyed face carries something of its righteous spirit. As the crowd shifts their gaze between the small paper lanterns and the guardian, their voices finally return.

Enraged Man: You're right. It's the legendary Xiǎndào Beast. Look, it has the tail of a snake and the head of a tiger, just like the illustrations.

Old Man: Has the legendary Qiángliáng come to save us? Does that mean that girl is its Zhènzǐ?

Woman: What are you two yapping about? Xiǎndào Beast? Zhènzǐ? Those are just fairytales. Didn't Mr. Zhōu say this was all part of a film shoot?

Private Investigator: Th-That's right. I told you this was all for a movie. Why don't you guys believe me?

Chinatown Resident: Come on, you're always full of hot air. That said, there's no way this is real. It must just be some fancy special effects. So I'll believe you this once.

Tourist: Wait, so all those things were fake? I almost freaked out when those ghosts came out. Their costumes and makeup were so real-looking.

Tourist: Man, am I glad I came to Chinatown. This parade's been insane. I gotta take more photos.

The fear that once filled their hearts gradually fades. Those who understand the truth exchange knowing smiles.

An-an Lee: Whoa! That's Qiángliáng, huh? Looks totally awesome.

An-an Lee: I heard that a descendant of the Twelve Zhènzǐ joined the Vigiles Bureau, but this is the first time I've ever seen Qiángliáng in action.

Loggerhead: Phew, looks like they've got that actor lady under control.

Loggerhead: Now all we need to do is grab that cursed film reel and break the barrier, and the victims will be sane again. It'll be happily ever after for everyone—

Before she can finish speaking, her optimistic prediction is ruthlessly overturned.

An-an Lee: What the ...? This again?!

Loggerhead: Wh-What's going on? Didn't they finish the job?

An anomaly even greater than the last crashes down upon them. Startled cries rise from the crowd.

Chinatown Resident: Look!

Chinatown Resident: Páifāng. Something's wrong with it.

Something is very wrong indeed. What was assumed to be a mere optical distortion is now starting to seep into tangible reality.

It is undeniably interfering with the physical world.

Loggerhead: I-Is that archway melting?

An-an Lee: It kinda looks like a burning piece of film.

They look at each other, finding the same alarm in each other's faces.

An-an Lee: Wait, the barrier was created by that spooky film reel, right? Then, this means it's—

Loggerhead: It's falling apart. We need to get outta here.

Deputy Chief Elden: Get everyone away from the edges of the barrier. The further they are from those twisting buildings, the better.

Private Investigator: Understood! But what the hell's going on? I thought you had the target locked down?

Deputy Chief Elden: We do. But clearly, this isn't over yet. Ms. Latham, anything you can do?

Loggerhead: Yes, sir! But I'll need a few of your men.

Loggerhead: I can use the containment incantation they taught me at work, but I don't think it'll hold for long.

Deputy Chief Elden: Just do your best. In the meantime, we'll eliminate the problem at the source.

Elden's furious gaze lands on Qí Xīng.

Deputy Chief Elden: Alright, Qí Xīng, whatever you're doing with the reel, stop it now, or I'll make you stop it.

Qi Xing: I'm not doing anything.

She stands, her hat a few feet away, her body slumped against the wall behind her as she barely manages to stay upright. She forces a crooked grin.

Qi Xing: It's the film reel. It's reached its limit.

From her coat, she pulls out the object responsible for all this chaos.

Had Liáng not once held the film reel herself, she might not have recognized it at all.

Liang Yue: The Reunion of the Three Swallows? What's happening to it?

Liang Yue: Wait, there's something else here.

An-an Lee: No doubt about it! Evil spirits! An insane number of them!

An-an shoves through the crowd, rushing to Qí Xīng's side. With just one glance at the film reel, her face goes pale.

Upon hearing An-an's words, Liáng's expression darkens.

Liang Yue: So you think so, too? We had a similar encounter at the City Hall not long ago.

Liang Yue: Mr. Wong must've lost some of his spiritual energy to the film reel, leaving his body open to wandering evil spirits.

Liang Yue: Since then, I've suspected that—

The uneasy speculation lodges in her throat, but An-an voices it for her.

An-an Lee: Of course! Aiyah, I should've realized earlier.

The ghost hunter lets out a long, frustrated sigh, then furrows her brows in thought, her expression growing increasingly grim.

An-an Lee: Obviously, evil spirits would be attracted to the film reel. It's like leaving a pot of honey in front of a wasp's nest.

An-an Lee: A living soul is a wandering spirit's favorite meal, so with the number of souls gathered in the film reel, it's like a total feast.

An-an Lee: All that evil spiritual energy must have the film reel bursting at the seams.

An-an scans her surroundings, alarm in her eyes. The collapse is approaching fast. It's as if reality itself is about to be swallowed whole.

Yet neither Liáng nor An-an can see a single wandering or evil spirit. A sudden realization strikes Liáng. Her gaze snaps to Qí Xīng.

But upon seeing her, her eyes widen in shock.

Liang Yue: Ms. Qí Xīng, your hand!

Qi Xing: *cough* I must admit ...

Deep, jagged cracks have spread across the entire film reel and climbed up Qí Xīng's hand and arm like sinister veins.

Qi Xing: The film reel isn't the only thing at its limit. I can't hold on much longer.

The vessel containing Qiángliáng strapped around Liáng's waist starts to shudder. To Qiángliáng, the malevolent energy emanating from Qí Xīng must be eradicated.

Liang Yue: What does that mean?

A thought flashes through Liáng's mind.

Liang Yue: Could it be that the film reel has been out of control since the beginning?

Qi Xing: That depends on how you define the beginning.

Even though Qí Xīng avoids answering, Liáng knows she's right.

Scattered pieces of the puzzle find their place, and finally, the picture begins to form a whole.

Liang Yue: Since the moment Ms. Latham played the cursed film, people have started to suffer from mental disorders. But if you think about it, the sequence of events doesn't make sense.

Liang Yue: There were only five victims of the "film incident" in Hong Kong eight years ago. But this time, the number of victims was growing rapidly. That was until you got involved, Ms. Qí Xīng.

Liang Yue: Ever since you took possession of the film reel, only a small number of specific people have been targeted. We thought you were exploiting the reel's power to carry out your vigilantism, but in truth ...

Liang Yue: You were trying to control the reel by limiting its victims to those you deemed as villains.

Though disbelief still colors her voice, her words are not a question.

Elden and the others stare, caught between shock and suspicion, as they turn toward the woman they assumed was the true culprit.

Deputy Chief Elden: Is that true?

Qi Xing: You flatter me, little vigil. I simply didn't want her legacy to become a tool of evil. That was never her intention.

Liang Yue: So that's why you did all this? You wanted us all at the parade because you were losing control of the reel?

Liang Yue: But isn't your goal to kill Ms. Noire? Was that also a setup?

Liang Yue: If the film reel wasn't part of your plan, then what was?

Liang Yue: ...!

A conclusion she herself once stated resurfaces in her mind, and she realizes she made a critical error.

Liang Yue: Ms. Qí Xīng still can't accept the way Ms. Noire ended Detective C07 III. That's her motive.

Liang Yue: The ending consists of two major elements: the Shèhuǒ Parade and a villain who should've been punished.

Liang Yue: She now sees Noire as that villain.

Liang Yue: Noire isn't the villain, is she?

Liang Yue: In your perfect grand finale, the villain you intend to kill at the parade is none other than yourself.

Qi Xing: It's a good ending for everyone. The big bad finally gets her comeuppance.

Qi Xing: And who better fits the role than me?

Liang Yue: This is the grand finale you want to have? But why does it have to end like this?

Qi Xing: Because this is the way it has to be.

Qi Xing: When a drop of ink falls onto paper, no matter how hard you wipe, it can never be spotless again.

Qi Xing: People say that "Every saint has a past, and every sinner has a future." Heh, what garbage. Some mistakes can never be forgiven.

Liang Yue: What happened to Hé Rìjūn was an accident. You shouldn't blame yourself for her death. It wasn't your fault.

Qi Xing: But it was my fault. It was my stubbornness, my selfishness, that pushed my dear friend, who really, truly cared for me, toward the cliff.

Qi Xing: How can someone like me carry the title of C07? I don't deserve to stand in the spotlight ever again.

Qi Xing: Heh, punishing those equally despicable pieces of scum made me feel better for a while, but it didn't last.

Qi Xing: That sickening feeling inside, that disgust in myself, it wouldn't stop. I looked everywhere for a way to heal it. But then I realized ...

Qi Xing: ... that the biggest piece of scum was me.

Qí Xīng looks up at the sky and lets out a long breath. For the first time, her expression softens, as if she has finally released a burden, and within her eyes, something new flickers—hope.

Qi Xing: The answer was so simple. I can hardly believe it took me so long to see it. And now, it's time to put an end to this nauseating nightmare.

Liáng cannot understand it.

Liang Yue: No, you're being too harsh on yourself. Hé Rìjūn doesn't blame you. I'm certain of it.

Qi Xing: Quit it, vigil. Look around you. Can you still claim that I'm not to blame?

Liang Yue: I ...

Noire: Well, I can. And let me tell you. Teresa was much stronger than you say she was.

Liáng turns to see Poitier helping Noire back into her wheelchair.

Noire: Yes, Teresa would cry often, but that made her no less determined of an artist, and before long she'd be at my door saying, "I made some edits. Take a look."

Noire: You know that's what she was like. Do you seriously think she gave up dreams, her life, just because of a few harsh words?

Noire: No! I could never have a coward like that as a partner.

Noire's face is twisted in a fury Liáng has never seen before. It sets a fire in the woman beneath her glare, making her frown in turn.

Qi Xing: Whatever you say. Director or not, you can't tell me what to do anymore. I will have this ending.

Qi Xing: Come on, officers, finish the job. I'd do it myself if I had the strength.

Her voice is unwavering.

Qi Xing: I've learned a lot these past years. If you want to save this city, you'll have to kill me. Those spirits will disappear, and everything will be back to normal.

Qi Xing: A perfect grand finale, isn't it? So, what are you waiting for?

Deputy Chief Elden: Tsk, so it's come to this, has it?

Elden swears under his breath as he reaches for the gun at his waist. Qí Xīng watches on, seemingly pleased.

Liang Yue: Wait, sir!

Lightning shoots through Liáng's body. Her feet, once nailed to the ground, suddenly feel weightless.

She steps forward.

Liang Yue: There's no guarantee that things will play out like Ms. Qí Xīng said.

Liang Yue: Please, let me try something. After all, exorcism is my and Qiángliáng's specialty.

Qi Xing: Wait, what are you—

Before either Elden or Qí Xīng can react, the film reel is already in Liáng's grasp.

Deputy Chief Elden: Liáng!

Poitier: You outta your mind or something?

Liang Yue: Yes, there are a huge number of evil entities bound within it.

Liang Yue: And this is probably the most formidable opponent Qiángliáng and I have ever faced.

Liang Yue: But I must confront this challenge.

Liang Yue: Not to protect the honor of my family or to mimic Co7, either. But because I want to. Because it's right.

Liang Yue: Every story has an ending, and I must act to create the best one for everyone.

Liang Yue: Sorry, I don't have any flowery words or clever arguments, but if you're willing to help me ...

Liang Yue: Please, Qiángliáng, heed my call.

Liang Yue: Ugh!

Liang Yue: Th-This isn't good. Is this the best I can ...

Liang Yue: ?!

Liang Yue: Qiángliáng?!

Liang's Father: On the emperor's order, Fāngxiàngshì the Wise sought the assistance of the twelve gods of Shètí. Bestowed with their divine might, Fāngxiàngshì bound the creatures and turned their monstrous power to the service of the people. These creatures became known as the Xiǎndào Beasts, guardians of the perilous path.

Liang's Father: However, even formidable creatures such as these couldn't defend against all the evil spirits across the continent.

Liang's Father: But the people never gave up, for they knew that as long as they kept fighting ...

Liang's Father: ... a Xiǎndào Beast would one day come to their aid, expelling the fiends and restoring peace and prosperity.

Liang Yue: Qiángliáng, no!

Rescreen

SC-21

The storm clouds gradually disperse, and sunlight streams into the ward. In the corner, the television broadcasts a news report.

Reporter: Last night, the Chinatown Shèhuǒ Parade drew hundreds as tourists and locals gathered for the Eastern spectacle.

Reporter: These photos, shared by an enthusiastic tourist, show the enormous holographic images that were created on-site using arcane skills to present a stunning performance of the Chinese folk tale, Qiángliáng's Exorcism.

Reporter: The event has been deemed a well-organized success, with many promising to attend again next year. Locals have expressed their thanks.

Reporter: One spokesperson said, "It's been wonderful to share our culture with people from all around the world. Chinatown is always ready to welcome new friends from both near and far."

Reporter: In other news, the arcane vigilante Nightpiercer, who has perpetrated dozens of attacks across the city, has been apprehended by the DAA.

Reporter: Nightpiercer was revealed to be Qí Xīng, a former Hong Kong movie star. Some members of the public have expressed continued support for the vigilante due to the questionable backgrounds of her victims.

Reporter: Deputy Chief Elden of the Division of Arcane Affairs gave his response:

Deputy Chief Elden: Vigilante justice is incredibly dangerous to our society. No individual has the right to bypass the law and enact their judgment on others.

Deputy Chief Elden: Taking the law into your own hands will only lead to chaos, violence, and potential harm to innocent people.

Deputy Chief Elden: We urge the citizens of Los Angeles to place their trust in us as we continue to dedicate ourselves to maintaining a safer society for everyone.

Deputy Chief Elden: If you share our passion for justice, we encourage all citizens to direct their assistance and feedback to the Division of Arcane Affairs.

Reporter: The LAPD has just announced a plan to add a number of positions for Arcane Affairs Officers in the coming year to address the DAA's staffing shortage.

Reporter: The St. Pavlov Foundation's Vigiles Bureau training program is also set to begin in the coming months. To apply, please dial—

Hearing this news, the woman hops up joyfully and turns to the man sitting up in bed.

Woman: Hey, they're hiring Arcane Affairs Officers.

Woman: Hasn't it always been your dream to don the uniform? Looks like they accept older applicants, too. Why don't you give it a shot when you're better?

Enraged Man: Knock it off! I've been a greengrocer for twenty years. There's no way I could be a cop, right?

He waves off his wife, but as he does so, he turns to the man beside him with a nervous look on his face, expecting the idea to get shot down.

But the reaction he gets is unexpected.

Private Investigator: What are you staring at me for? If you wanna do it, just do it. I'm sure the neighborhood would be glad to see you wearing the badge.

Private Investigator: Besides, I spent some time with the officers at the parade. I'm sure that you'll be just as capable as them. You're gonna have to toughen up a little, though.

Liáng, who has been watching the exchange, smiles.

Liang Yue: Mr. Wong, you're strong, healthy, and have a natural talent for arcane skills. With a little training, I'm sure you'll become an outstanding officer.

Liang Yue: There's a lot that goes into being an officer, but I believe what matters most is the heart to pursue justice and the courage to protect others.

Liang Yue: The doctor said you can be discharged soon. You should seriously consider applying for the position.

Enraged Man: Well, in that case, I'll think about it.

Woman: Thank you so much, young lady. I heard you were the one who got rid of the curse and saved everyone.

Woman: You're our hero.

She clasps Liáng's hand tightly in a warm grip. This time, her hand is steady. Liáng returns the handshake.

Liang Yue: You're too kind, madam. I was only doing my job.

Liang Yue: And I didn't do it alone. It was a combined effort.

Poitier: Well, that's that. No more cursed film crazies. Almost all the victims have recovered.

Poitier: Most of them have already been discharged, too. Just a few poor saps who got hit harder still around, but they should be out of here before long.

Poitier: Same goes for the victims in the parade. They've all regained their Saam W-Wer—uh—what's it called again?

An-an gives a helpless sigh.

An-an Lee: It's Saam Wan Chat Paak ah, madam. Just call it spiritual energy or something like that.

An-an Lee: I heard that those crooks who were taught by a thing or two by Qí Xīng have also recovered, well, mentally lah. They're pretty physically messed up, so they'll have to stay here for a while, I think.

Liang Yue: So many victims and not a single death. That's a blessing.

Poitier: Qí Xīng pulled her punches, apparently. I guess deep down she wasn't the "deliverer of justice" she claimed she was.

Poitier: Well, no use wondering about it. Years on this job'll quickly show you that the madness in arcanist blood always comes out in arcanist criminals.

Poitier: Trying to understand them is a waste of time.

Liang Yue: That may be the case, but ...

Liang Yue: I think that if we look at each other as individuals, we can come to understand one another eventually.

She takes out the brick-sized mobile phone she has carried with her since she was six years old.

But now, its screen remains dark. No matter how much Liáng tries to summon the spirit residing within, there is no response.

Liang Yue: If we all try our best.

Holding onto hope, Liáng tries a few different button combinations on the phone. Usually, the screen would light up, but this time, there is nothing.

Poitier: Still nothing from Qiángliáng?

Liáng lowers her gaze and shakes her head.

An-an Lee: Well, what did you expect? That huge spooky spookster was a nasty opponent on its own, not to mention all the ghosts that were attracted by that film reel.

An-an Lee: It was creepy lah. All those ghosts in one place. It was more crowded than the Dai Pai Dong, I mean, the Chinatown food stall on a Saturday night.

An-an Lee: What's worse, those specters drained the Saam Wan Chat Paak of innocent people. If that hadn't happened, then Qiángliáng wouldn't have had to sac—

An-an cuts herself off. It would be too cruel to say these words in front of Liáng.

Liang Yue: Qiángliáng was lost because of my incompetence. I don't know how I'll be able to face my family now.

Liang Yue: And there's something else that's bothering me.

Liang Yue: When Qiángliáng pulled in the evil spirits, I thought I was going to die with it, but it looked at me and pushed me aside. It bore everything, all alone.

Liang Yue: Why did it go to such lengths to help me? Because I'm its Zhènzǐ?

Liang Yue: The way it looked at me, I think it wanted to tell me something.

Liang Yue: But I didn't understand what.

Liang Yue: Qiángliáng had been by my side since I was six, but I always saw it as a heavy burden, or a double-edged sword.

Liang Yue: I never saw it as an independent individual or as a friend. I never tried to truly understand it.

Liang Yue: And now, I've probably lost the opportunity to ever understand it.

Liáng sighs and falls silent. The other two exchange a glance and simultaneously pat her on the shoulders.

An-an Lee: Come on, enough with the long face. Maybe Qiángliáng will respond to you one day lah. You never know! And I'm here if you ever need my professional ghostbusting service. Exclusive discount just for you ah.

Poitier: Agreed. Isn't it a literal legendary beast that's existed for ages? No way it bit the dust just like that.

Poitier: I bet it's recharging in its lair or something. Then it'll come back when it's full of juice again.

Liang Yue: I hope so.

She knows these are just comforting words, but their concern for her gives her the strength to move forward nonetheless.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Oh, Poitier, there you are. And the ghostbusting girl and Liáng. Great!

A familiar figure waves from the end of the hallway as she hurries over. Noticing Liáng's slightly surprised expression, she slows her steps.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Oh, sorry, I mean Officer Liáng. But if you don't mind—

Liang Yue: O-Of course, I don't. Just call me Liáng.

Despite her swift response, Liáng still feels a little surprised when she sees the officer extend her hand toward her.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Oh, where are my manners? Name's Jenny Carter. Just Jenny's fine. Unlike your instructor, I don't try to hide my appreciation of people.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: I gotta say, you've done an awesome job. Folks at the department have all been talking about it. We're proud of you. Please tell me there's some way to postpone the end of your field training.

This is the second hand Liáng has shaken today.

Liang Yue: Th-Thank you. That's very kind. Um. What brings you here?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Deputy Chief Elden, of course. Who else?

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Foundation staff have arrived. They're gonna take over Qí Xīng's interrogation and everything. They're gonna take the film reel back to their headquarters, too.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: But your request has been approved. We can watch Reunion of the Three Swallows before they take it away.

Division of Arcane Affairs, LA

Deputy Chief Elden: For crying out loud, the DAA isn't a movie theater. Where'd all these people come from?

Elden scans the group before him.

Noire: My apologies, sir. I invited them.

Noire: This may be the only chance for Teresa's last work to be shown to the public. I want as many people to see it as possible.

Noire: Every filmmaker wants their work to be shown to the world. I appreciate your understanding.

Before Elden can respond, An-an cuts in.

An-an Lee: Come on, Ā sir, it's no big deal. Everyone here knows what really happened. We just want to know what the film's about.

Private Investigator: Yeah, didn't you say something on TV about assistance and feedback? You'd be going back on your word if you ignored us now.

Deputy Chief Elden: Hey, don't you go talking circles around me again.

Even in this harmonious scene, the two men can't help but bicker.

Poitier rolls her eyes. Luckily, the two are quickly interrupted by a woman in a Foundation uniform.

Foundation Staff: No need to worry, Deputy Chief Elden.

Foundation Staff: After thorough examination, we've determined that the film reel no longer possesses the ability to twist reality.

Foundation Staff: It was our negligence that allowed the film to be taken in the first place, so, as Mr. Zhōu said, the people deserve to know the truth.

Foundation Staff: Besides, every viewer is required to sign this confidentiality agreement before entering the screening room. Alright, everyone, please hurry. The movie starts in fifteen minutes.

An-an Lee: Oh, I'm pumped. No way I'm missing this. Gimme a pen.

An-an heads over to the desk, and the DAA officers and Chinatown private detectives follow suit.

Liáng and Noire, on the other hand, hang back. They already signed the confidentiality agreement. After all, they are the ones who drafted it.

Noire: You have my thanks, vigil.

Noire: If it weren't for you, I doubt Ā Xīng and I would have had this chance to watch our good friend's swan song.

Noire: I also have to thank you for helping me stop Ā Xīng and for helping me keep my promise.

Liang Yue: Your promise?

Noire pats her hands on her thighs.

Noire: Yes, I swore on these two legs.

Noire: In the past, all I cared about was making the best film. I saw everyone, even my actors and writers, as tools to reach that goal. But I was wrong.

Noire: There's no such thing as a best film, only a better film. And to make a better film, I need a team around me.

Noire: What matters most is the people who make the film, not the film itself.

She turns her head and looks toward the bolted door at the other end of the room.

Noire: But as long as we're living, there's still a future. Maybe I should hire a good lawyer for Ā Xīng. They can probably secure a shorter sentence.

Noire: When she's free again, both physically and mentally, perhaps we can make a movie together, just like old times.

Liáng is momentarily stunned.

Liang Yue: Are you sure? With all due respect, Ms. Noire, that will probably be a very long time from now.

Noire: So? Even if we're old ladies by then, as long as we can still move, I'm certain we can make movies.

Noire: Speaking of which, you'd make an excellent addition to my crew, Ms. Liáng. Don't hesitate to contact me if you reconsider your career choice.

Liang Yue: You're very generous, Ms. Noire. But I think I'll stick to being a fan for the time being.

Liang Yue: I look forward to seeing what you do next.

Noire: You won't be disappointed.

Noire: By the way, have you seen Ms. Latham lately? I tried to invite her, but she didn't pick up the phone. She must've left it in her room again.

Liang Yue: Actually, I ran into her at the hospital earlier. Ms. Scott just regained consciousness. She wanted to visit her.

Noire's smile fades slightly, and a contemplative expression comes over her.

Noire: Ms. Scott ... Something tells me that there's still an unsolved mystery there.

Liang Yue: You mean a truth hidden behind all these incidents?

Noire: Yes. Like a chessboard, we are the pawns placed on the front line. Somehow, we've managed to fight our way out, escaping our planned doom.

Noire: But who is the player who placed us there? They're still a mystery, watching us from the shadows. I don't like this feeling.

Liang Yue: I'll keep an eye on the matter.

Liang Yue: I already made a detailed report to my superiors. If there's anything else going on, I'm sure the Vigiles will put a stop to it.

Noire: I suppose we'll have to wait and see.

Noire's expression does not ease. It seems the title Vigiles Bureau doesn't bring her much confidence. Before Liáng can inquire further, Poitier calls her.

Poitier: Hey, you two, get your asses in the screening room. We're all waiting for you.

Liang Yue: On our way.

Noire: Nothing's more important than a movie that's about to start. Let's go, vigil.

They exchange a smile and enter the makeshift theater together.

After the Show

小径

This place was once known for its inexhaustible mines, the riches of its rainforests, and its brave and passionate people. But now, the first two are gone.

Chaos and power struggles loom over the younger generation, while the rich and well-connected sit atop their piles of corpses and rubble and feast. Dining off golden plates with silver spoons, turning their noses up from the dogs at their feet.

But that gold has lost its shine and their silver spoons have tarnished, everyone can see them for what they really are. So, what now? Either the people save themselves or turn their fate over to the hands of the so-called "savior." What would you do, if it were you?

Choices

1. I'd save myself first.

2. So, why can't this "savior" save me?

Branch 1

That's a smart choice. Now that the carnival's over, people have to deal with more than just their hangovers—they must figure out how to save their own skins.

Most though will just run around like chickens with their heads cut off, begging for their pain to be taken away. But all they'll get is another morphine shot—nothing close to a real solution.

Fear spreads like a disease. Until an entire generation is out on the streets, hoping to find anything that will lift them out of their misery.

Branch 2

Who's asking the questions here, me or you? But fine, I'll clue you in a little about this "savior".

I once met a kid from Buenos Aires who told me about the "hand of god" that gave them the World Cup. He saw it as proof there was a higher power, something men should follow and seek protection from.

Maybe he had a point, I don't know. Maybe there's truly something greater out there, or maybe it's just what we mortals need to believe.

These men from the Apostles Brotherhood used to be regular church-goers just like anybody else. But faced with an opportunity to rise above their own cruel realities, they all too readily turned away.

They left their old altars and took communion with a new god. Will this new path save them? Is it worth all their efforts? I can't say.

But you wanted to know if this 'savior' can save its own. Well, I guess you've got your answer now.

Choices

1. Are we going to be alright?

No need to start panicking just yet. Things are still under control. Your lady friend has stepped up to solve this mess, and the veteran knows what he's doing.

This city is unlike any you've seen before. You must learn its secrets to survive—remember which street kids are from which alley and what intel they can be relied on for, learn the dates when the dealers bring their "medicine" into port, and figure out which water tanks hide the key to the local gang's safehouse.

Don't look at me for answers. It's none of my business.

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Anonymous Visitor

SC-22

Hospital

Loggerhead: Scott's ward, Scott's ward. Did I take a wrong turn?

Loggerhead: Oh, excuse me, doctor. Could you tell me where Constance Scott's ward is? I'm kinda lost.

Doctor: You're in the wrong area. You need to go straight forward this way, take a left at the corner, and a right at the next.

Loggerhead: Forward, left, then right. Okay. I'll remember it now. Thanks for the help.

Doctor: Sure.

Loggerhead makes her way down the hallway, muttering the directions to herself as she goes.

But then, she stops and turns back in confusion.

Loggerhead: Hm, that's odd. Why do I feel like I talked to that doctor a few days ago?

Loggerhead: Must just be my bad memory. The lady last time was more friendly.

She tilts her head before quickly, deciding to let it go.

Loggerhead: Wait, which way did she say again?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Sorry, doctor, it isn't time for the routine checkup yet.

Doctor: You're right, but yesterday's medical report showed some concerning fluctuations in the patient's data.

Doctor: It's probably nothing serious, but we should conduct a clinical check on the patient just in case.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Please wait a moment. Let me verify this with your superior.

Doctor: Of course, officer. You can never be too cautious, especially when the patient's involved in a sensitive case.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Yeah. Thanks for your un ... der ...

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Ugh ...?

The patient inside the ward hears the conversation outside the door come to an abrupt halt.

She sits with her hands cuffed to the railing, turning her head away from the window and toward the closed door before her.

Scott: What's wrong?

There is no response from the other side.

Several seconds later, the doorknob turns. Standing in the doorway is a doctor. She looks vaguely familiar.

Doctor: Good afternoon, Ms. Scott. How are you feeling today?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: ...

Before the door is closed again, Scott catches a glimpse of the Arcane Affairs Officer staring straight ahead. He doesn't so much as glance in her direction.

Something is wrong. Scott shoots up straight.

Scott: Who are you?

Doctor: Someone brought you these flowers.

Scott: Flowers?

Only then does she notice that the doctor is holding a glass vase filled with pure white flowers, fresh and delicate.

Scott: No. Something's not right.

Scott: I heard what you said to the officer. How are you supposed to do a medical check with a flower ...

Scott: ... vase ...

Scott: ...

Scott vaguely hears her own voice being swallowed, but somehow, she doesn't care. All her attention is locked on the vase.

Not the flowers, but the vase itself. At first glance, it looked like any other glass item. But now that it's under the sunlight, it is shimmering like crystal, refracting dreamlike colors around the ward.

Scott: Is this ... crystal?

A barrier blocking off her memories suddenly bursts.

Scott: It's you, madame.

Scott: You said you wouldn't contact me unless something bad happened. Is there something wrong with the object you bought?

???: No, it is perfect. You have been of superb help.

Scott: It was my honor to serve you, madame. And I must say, you have incredible foresight.

Scott: The Vigiles caught me, but they couldn't get any useful information, because I can't remember any.

???: But you still seem to be in a rather precarious situation.

Scott: Y-Yes, but you needn't worry. I can handle this myself.

???: That is good to hear.

The other end of the communication incantation falls silent. If not for the light still refracting from the vase, she might have thought the other party already hung up.

Scott: By the way, I met Matilda not long ago.

Scott: She was worried about you. Have you not contacted her?

???: That is not necessary.

???: Were she more perceptive, she would have already discovered me herself. She will find me when she's ready.

The voice on the other side shows little interest in the topic.

Scott smirks to herself but struggles to find another excuse to prolong the conversation.

But her moment has already passed.

Scott: Hm?

The colors twist, and her consciousness begins to spiral.

Scott: *sigh* What was I doing again?

???: I am contacting you to express my gratitude.

???: Thank you very much, Ms. Scott. And please believe me, you are far more gifted than you think.

The woman's voice rings out from a particularly distorted and colorful spot in the room. It is elegant, dignified, and strangely familiar.

Scott: Wh-Who are you?

The voice does not answer.

???: However, those black dogs have a keener sense of smell than I thought. I'm afraid our relationship has come to an end.

???: Goodbye, Ms. Scott.

Scott: Huh? W-Wait!

A bullet shatters the vase, shattering the dream and crashing her back to reality.

At some point, the door was silently opened. A pair of black leather boots steps over the shards of the broken vase and comes to a stop at Scott's bedside.

Black Ibis: Ha, they run fast, that's for sure. Looks like this fish is bigger than we thought.

Black Ibis: Have you figured out what happened to the two officers?

The woman turns to her cadet.

A man, also dressed in the same black uniform, is dragging the unconscious body of the doctor who visited earlier beside that of the DAA officer who had been keeping guard outside.

Black Ibis's Cadet: They're under some kind of hypnosis. Caster's no amateur, either. Arcane fluctuations are impossible to trace.

Black Ibis: Not bad. Not bad at all.

She crouches down to pick up a shard of glass. As she examines it, her mouth curls into a smile.

Black Ibis's Cadet: Not bad? This is really bad. We already knew Scott was the culprit, but you just had to use her as bait to "reel in the fish hiding in the darkness."

Black Ibis's Cadet: Now all we have is Scott with no memories of what happened and a stone-cold trail. Truly genius!

Black Ibis's Cadet: And I still don't get why you're keeping all this from Liáng. She's your cadet and right here in the city. We should've had her join the investigation.

Black Ibis's Cadet: Ha, I can't wait to see her face when she finds out what's been going on. And I'm not defending you this time, either.

Faced with her cadet's accusations, the woman feigns innocence.

Black Ibis: Defending me? There's nothing to defend.

Black Ibis: If we'd told her about our plan, she would've started acting differently and spooked our fish.

Black Ibis: Besides, the whole point of her field training program in the LAPD was to see if she could handle things on her own. And she's proven that she can.

Black Ibis: The Division of Arcane Affairs seems to adore her, so I'm sure the Deputy Chief will give her an excellent write-up. Everything's turned out great, hasn't it?

Black Ibis: See how considerate I am? How I always do things in my cadets' best interests? How could you make me out to be such a heartless, irresponsible monster?

She exaggerates a sorrowful expression, which only makes her cadet roll his eyes in exasperation.

Black Ibis: Oh, don't give me that look. Anyway, I think I've got an idea as to what's going on.

Black Ibis's Cadet: Really?

The woman drops her act and smiles knowingly.

Black Ibis: Our big fish got away, yes, but just confirming that a fish this big exists has already made this worth our time.

Black Ibis: Now, back to the stolen arcane items. There are five in total, including the cursed film reel and the wind-up toy that the Timekeeper shattered.

Black Ibis: Tell me, Bob, does our fish need all five arcane items?

Black Ibis's Cadet: It's Alan, not Bob. How many times do I have to tell you?

Black Ibis's Cadet: And to answer your question, no, I don't think so. The wind-up toy's already been destroyed, and the film reel's been recovered by a fellow cadet.

Black Ibis's Cadet: These items did cause a few problems, but I don't see any common thread between the incidents they caused.

Black Ibis: Correct, Brian. Those two items were probably just decoys to divert our attention.

Black Ibis's Cadet: Again, it's Alan.

Ignoring her cadet's correction, she goes on.

Black Ibis: A clever fish knows how to muddy the waters to hide itself. Of the five objects, they probably only need one.

Black Ibis: Take a guess, Buck. Which one do they need?

Black Ibis's Cadet: It's Alan! A-L-A-N! There isn't even a single B in it.

The cadet sighs, half in reluctance, half in realization.

Black Ibis's Cadet: Well, out of the three, which one is—Wait, could it be?!

Black Ibis: Bingo.

From the way her cadet's face darkens, she can tell he has found the answer.

Black Ibis's Cadet: Does that mean the legend's real? It can really be used in "that" ritual?

Black Ibis: It would seem so.

Black Ibis's Cadet: So, it's Manus Vindictae again.

He speaks the name, his expression grim.

Black Ibis's Cadet: They must've planted a mole somewhere among the Foundation's elites, someone with clearance to the Arcanum Containment Department.

Black Ibis: Hm. It seems our fish doesn't wear the black robe.

The woman taps her chin. This response makes her cadet's eyes widen in disbelief.

Black Ibis's Cadet: Huh? So you're saying there's someone behind all this who wants to perform "that" ritual and somehow has the means to steal from the Foundation? There's just no way.

Black Ibis: The stolen items would probably go to the Manus eventually, but I have a hunch that our wily fish isn't totally on their side.

Black Ibis: Manus Vindictae obviously considered the succubus a valuable asset before she got away, right?

Black Ibis: So if our fish was a die-hard loyalist, they would've delivered the wind-up toy to their master straightway, rather than letting it be passed around all over the place.

Black Ibis: While our fish is in collusion with Manus Vindictae, they're swimming in murky waters. They may be pursuing their own agenda.

She curls her lips into a smile and flicks the shard of glass from between her fingers.

Black Ibis: Things are starting to get interesting, aren't they?

Black Ibis: Like I said earlier, not bad at all.

With that, the two figures in black vanish out the door.